Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Psalms

Psalms 1:1

- Blessed: The Hebrew term 'ashrey appears twenty-six times in the Psalms. While some translations use "blessed," a different term (barak) is used for blessings (Psalms 5:12; 45:2; 107:38).
- The godly are people who trust the Lord and try to live in ways that please him. They avoid living under the influence of sinners.

Those who do not fear the Lord are "the wicked" (Psalm 36:1). They oppose those who love God, do right, and the poor and oppressed (see 10:2–13; 37:14). The wicked might seem devoted to God (50:16). Sometimes they enjoy success, but it does not last long (37:35). They will face sadness and ruin when they must deal with the results of their bad actions (1:4–6; 9:16; 32:10).

- People who turn away from God's path and rebel against him are sinners (Psalms 25:8; 78:17). They commit serious crimes like adultery (being unfaithful to their spouse) and murder (compare Psalm 51).
- sit in the seat of: This expression describes a person who is controlled by sin (compare Psalm 1:2; 26:3–7; Deuteronomy 6:7).
- Mockers are people who disrespect and reject God's wisdom. Mockers hate the Lord and insult anyone who tries to correct them (Proverbs 9:7–8). They seek only the "wisdom" that justifies their actions. These bold people have little respect for God, his plans, or his followers (see Psalms 86:14; 119:51, 69, 78, 85, 122). These three terms (wicked, sinners, mockers) describe all kinds of people who do not live in a way that pleases God.

Psalms 1:1–2

The Lord brings true happiness to those who turn away from evil and find joy in him.

Psalms 1:1–6

Psalm 1 is a wisdom psalm. It sets the tone for the whole book of Psalms. The psalm clearly contrasts the happiness of godly people with the judgment of the wicked. In the end, the way of wisdom will triumph.

The psalm describes an ideal picture of a godly person, similar to Psalm 8. This picture shows what the Lord expects from his people. It also points forward to the coming Messiah, God's chosen king (Psalm 2).

The people of Israel did not live up to this ideal. The kings from David's family also failed to meet it. Even the best kings could not bring about the lasting righteousness described in Psalms 1, 2, and 72.

In the New Testament, the apostles use the Psalms to describe the life and work of Jesus the Messiah. Their teaching shows that Jesus alone fulfills the ideal of the godly person described in the Psalms. Only Jesus fully pleased God and secured redemption (rescue from sin), true happiness, and peace.

Psalm 1 also introduces a note of hope that continues through the Psalms. It looks forward to the final hallelujah in Psalm 150). At that time, the Lord will remove all evil from his creation and bring blessing and life to his people.

Psalms 1:1–2.12

The first two psalms serve as an introduction to the whole book of Psalms (called the Psalter). Psalm 1 presents the Lord's guidance in wisdom, while Psalm 2 shows God's rule over a rebellious and sinful world. Together, these psalms invite people to abandon foolishness, which leads to destruction. These psalms invite people to follow God's path instead, which leads to wisdom and salvation. The New Testament confirms that God will govern the nations through Jesus Christ, his chosen representative (Hebrews 1:5; Revelation 12:5; 19:15).

Psalms 1:1–8.9

Psalms 1 and 8 form an **inclusio** (a literary pattern where the beginning and ending act like matching bookends). Together, they describe what God expects from the ideal person. These psalms compare the godly person with the wicked and praise the dignity and worth God gives to the godly (see Psalms 19; 33; 104; 145).

Jesus the Messiah, introduced in Psalm 2, fully embodies this ideal. He is the Lord with complete power and authority, and the perfect example of true humanity. The New Testament applies Psalm 8 to Jesus, showing that God placed everything under his authority (Hebrews 2:6–8; see 1 Corinthians 15:27).

Psalms 1:2

- The law of the Lord is called torah in Hebrew. It means God's instruction or teaching for his people (see study note on Deuteronomy 4:44).
- Meditating involves inner reflection, which can be positive (Psalms 1:2; 63:6; 77:12; 143:5) or negative (see Psalms 2:1; 38:12). The Lord's word is the object of godly meditation (119:48).

- day and night: This includes all times, whether walking, standing, sitting, or sleeping (see Deuteronomy 6:7).

Psalms 1:3

Well-watered trees stay strong and produce plenty of fruit (compare Jeremiah 17:8).

Psalms 1:3–5

The future belongs to those who follow a righteous path.

Psalms 1:4

The future judgment (Psalm 1:5) will remove the wicked and everything they have done (Psalms 35:5; 83:13; Isaiah 17:13; see study note on Jeremiah 13:24).

Psalms 1:5

The wicked cannot endure the Lord's judgment. They are already condemned (see Psalms 5:5; 7:6; 101:7).

Psalms 1:6

- When God takes care of people who obey him and punishes people who do evil, it shows how God gives people what their actions deserve (see Galatians 6:7–10). This is called "retribution." The wicked might appear successful for a short while, but their lives are short and meaningless in the end. God and the people who remain faithful to him will have the final victory (see Psalms 9:5, 6, 18; 10:16; 37:20; 73:27; 92:9; compare 142:4; Isaiah 57:1).
- People who live in a way that pleases God are happy (Psalms 1:1; 5:12; 14:5). They are happy because God protects and cares for them, listens when they ask for justice, and secures their future (see 121:3–4).
- A person's path is their life and character.

Psalms 2:1

plot: The Hebrew verb translated as "meditates" in Psalm 1:2 suggests opposing the Lord through speech (Isaiah 59:13) or thought (Psalm 38:12; Proverbs 24:2).

Psalms 2:1–3

Their useless paths lead to death (Psalm 1:4, 6), but sinful human beings join together to oppose the true God and his Messiah.

Psalms 2:1–12

This royal psalm describes the Lord choosing a king descended from David. It celebrates the mission of all the kings in David's family line. It also introduces the hope of an ideal ruler. This ruler will accomplish the Lord's goal of bringing all nations into submission (Psalm 2:11) or to destruction (2:9). The New Testament identifies Jesus as this descendant (see Acts 13:33; 1 Corinthians 15:25–27; Hebrews 1:5; 5:5; Revelation 19:15).

Psalms 2:2

The kings hate the Lord's established order in the world, so they want to be independent of him (see Psalm 36:4). They plan to dominate the Lord's people (Psalm 31:13; see 83:1–4). Their goal is to undermine the Lord's rule by overthrowing his Anointed One (or his Messiah).

The Lord chose the kings of David's family line to establish his kingdom on earth. The New Testament confirms that Jesus, the appointed and anointed Son of God (Acts 4:26; 13:33; Hebrews 1:5; 5:5), fulfills the role in which these earlier kings failed.

Psalms 2:3

break Their chains: These kings think that recognizing the true God and his chosen ruler will lead to their enslavement (Isaiah 28:22; 52:2; compare Lamentations 3:7; Romans 1:1; 1 Corinthians 7:22; Titus 1:1).

Psalms 2:4

enthroned in heaven: The Lord's position in the universe is so secure that he laughs at humans who claim they can oppose his power and authority (see Psalms 3 7:13; 59:8).

Psalms 2:4–6

The Lord sees the human threat as unimportant. He offered a solution long before they rebelled. He will stop their unrest by appointing a human leader, a descendant of David, to rule the nations.

Psalms 2:6

My King: The Lord himself appoints and establishes his anointed ruler. The word anointed means chosen and set apart by God for a special purpose.

Psalms 2:7

today I have become Your Father: In the ancient Near East, people often believed in a father-son relationship between gods and kings.

In Israel, the Lord adopted kings as his sons. God set David apart as his most excellent and exalted son (Psalm 89:27). All descendants of David were the Lord's representatives or agents.

Jesus is an eternal member of the Godhead (the one God who exists as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit; John 1:1). He is also a descendant of David (Acts 13:33; Hebrews 1:5; 5:5). Because he is both eternal and from David's family, Jesus uniquely fulfills God's plan. He is fully divine and truly human. For this reason, he is rightly called the Son of God.

Psalms 2:7–9

The Lord adopted the king from David's family to conquer rebellious nations by force (see Psalm 89:26–27).

Psalms 2:8

- In the Old Testament, the relationship between the Lord and Israel's king can be compared to a suzerain-vassal relationship. A suzerain was a great king. A vassal was a smaller king who served him.

In this picture, the Lord is the great King. Israel's king rules under his authority (see Deuteronomy Book Introduction, "Literary Form"). The Lord invites his anointed king to ask for what he needs (see Psalm 21:2, 4).

- All nations will be subject to David's descendant, the Messiah.

Psalms 2:9

The Lord grants his chosen ruler the power to conquer nations as his inheritance (Isaiah 11:4; Revelation 2:27; 12:5; 19:15), ending their rebellion, resistance, and independence.

Psalms 2:10

The Lord is pleased when people submit to him and seek his protection. Wise people accept the Lord's correction and want to change.

Psalms 2:11–12

- rejoice: Leaders should accept the Son as their true and only King.
- Kiss the Son: Kissing was an expression of submission (Hosea 13:2).
- The Lord gives joy to those who fear him. To fear the Lord means to honor him, respect him, and obey him (Psalm 1:1–2). The Psalms also say that the Lord protects those who trust him (18:30; 34:22; 119:1–3).

Psalms 3:1

This difficult time in David's life (see 2 Samuel 15–18) helps readers understand the promises of Psalm 2 better. The Lord gave victory to his chosen king (Psalm 2), but God controlled how and when this victory happened.

Psalms 3:1–2

- A psalmist is the writer or speaker of a psalm. The psalmist here faces many enemies. Those enemies speak boldly and without respect (Psalm 4:6; 12:4; 40:15). They question whether the Lord can really save him (10:11; 22:7–8; 71:10). Their words trouble the psalmist because it seems the Lord will not answer his prayer.
- These enemies hold great power (compare Psalm 2:1–3). Unlike Psalm 2, this psalm does not resolve the crisis.

Psalms 3:1–8

This psalm expresses sorrow that the hopes from Psalms 1–2 have not been fulfilled. Even when surrounded by enemies, godly people should not doubt the Lord's just actions. Instead, they can trust in God's goodness and expect God to rescue them.

Psalms 3:1–7.17

This group of psalms moves from an orderly world to a troubled one. Psalms 1–2 describe stability. The righteous person is blessed, and the Lord's anointed king rules with authority.

In the psalms that follow, the tone changes. The Lord's anointed cries out for help. He faces enemies, strong opposition, and evil plans.

It even seems at times that the Lord is far away. The psalmist feels confusion and distress instead of confidence and calm.

Psalms 3:3

The psalmist compares his enemies' arguments (Psalm 3:2) with the Lord's help. The Lord acts as a shield for his people, turning their defeat and shame into victory and glory.

Psalms 3:3–4

The psalmist looks away from his enemies and focuses on the Lord.

Psalms 3:5

By focusing on the Lord (Psalm 3:3–4) during his crisis, the psalmist can rest, confident in his safety (see study note on Psalm 4:8). The Lord cares for his servant. God protects him and keeps his mind and heart free from fear (Psalms 37:17; 54:4; 119:116; 145:14).

Psalms 3:6

The psalmist feels peaceful and confident because the Lord protects and cares for him. This shields him from evil and gives him a new understanding of reality (Psalm 23:4; 27:1, 3; 46:1; 56:4, 11; 91:5–6; 118:6).

Psalms 3:7–8

- The psalmist does not seek revenge. Instead, he waits for the Lord to take vengeance.
- Arise: The psalmist asks the Lord to act now.

Psalms 4:1

Waiting for the Lord's answer helps you grow in patience and strengthen your faith (Psalm 38:15).

Psalms 4:1–8

This personal lament includes:

- a prayer for rescue (Psalm 4:1)
- a rebuke of the enemy (Psalm 4:2–3)
- advice to the faithful (Psalm 4:4–5)
- a statement of confidence (Psalm 4:6–8)

Psalms 4:2

- The opponents of those who follow God rely on false beliefs, deceit, and idol worship.
- my honor (or my glory): The psalmist's honor, or possibly the Lord's, is being challenged.

Psalms 4:4

- Feeling angry is not a sin, but letting anger control you can lead to sin (see Psalm 37:7–8; compare Ephesians 4:26–27, 31–32).
- Instead of acting on their emotions, godly people think about their circumstances overnight. They might be disturbed as they sleep, but silence opens their hearts to trust in the Lord (Psalm 4:5).

Psalms 4:5

Offer the sacrifices of the righteous: Redirecting emotions toward the Lord prevents a godly person from doing too much self-reflection (Psalms 40:6–8; 51:17).

Psalms 4:6

the light of Your face: When the psalmist speaks about God's face, he is asking for God's favor and peace (Numbers 6:25–26). God's favor can change a situation from darkness to light (see Psalm 27:1).

Confident faith protects against anger, resentment, jealousy, and a desire for wealth as the highest good. When God's favor is enough, other desires lose their power.

Psalms 4:8

Peace comes from God's blessing and protection (see Psalm 4:6 and 37:11).

Psalms 5:1–2

The phrase give ear to my words appears in several prayers as a call for God's attention during difficult times (Psalms 39:12; 84:8; 143:1; compare Psalms 17:1; 54:2; 130:2). The needy ask their God, "Are you listening?"

Psalms 5:1–12

This morning prayer (Psalm 5:3) shows strong trust in the Lord's help and protection. The psalmist asks for God's response and waits for it (Psalm 5:1–3).

He describes the plans of the wicked in detail but stays focused on God. The psalmist knows the wicked cannot be with God (Psalm 5:4–6, 9; see 1:5).

He keeps returning to the Lord (Psalm 5:7–8, 10; see 5:1–3), and then he prays for the godly community (5:10–12; see 3:8).

Psalms 5:3

- The psalmist starts and ends each day with prayer, looking for new signs of God's faithfulness and goodness (Psalm 143:8).
- wait in expectation: The psalmist does not demand God's grace but hopes for it (see Micah 7:7; Habakkuk 2:1).

Psalms 5:5

- The boastful: Mockers (see study note on Psalm 1:1), the wicked (Psalm 73:3; 75:4), and the arrogant (10:2) use their words to distort the truth and challenge the faith of the godly.
- The Lord allows only the godly into his presence (see Psalm 1:5). His holiness and justice do not tolerate oppression or evil actions.
- You hate: The Lord rejects proud sinners (see also Psalm 11:5).

Psalms 5:7

- God promises his loving devotion (his covenant goodness and faithfulness) to his people (see Psalm 25:6; 69:16; Lamentations 3:32).
- Your house: The righteous desire to enter God's presence with awe and wonder (see Hebrews 12:28).

Psalms 5:8

- God guides those who are obedient, submissive, and patient as they wait for him to lead, provide, and protect them (Psalm 27:11; 43:3; 143:10). He does not guide those who expect God simply to approve their own decisions.
- Following the right path of wisdom leads to the Lord (Psalms 47:11; 61:2; 139:24).

Psalms 5:9–10

The psalmist again describes the terrible acts of the wicked, who cannot stand in God's presence.

Psalms 5:10

- The psalmist prays for the justice and retribution that God promised against the wicked (Psalm 1:6). The wicked are those who have rebelled against the Lord.
- The wicked set traps to harm (Psalm 38:12) or trick others (140:4–5).

Psalms 5:11

- A blessing rests on all who take refuge in God (see Psalm 18:30).
- Joy and praise go well together. The godly rejoice when they see evidence of God's rescue. They sing joyful praises as a new song (see Psalm 33:3).

When the Lord brings peace to the world, defeats evil, and rewards good people, they will have lasting joy (Psalms 9:2–4; 53:6; 90:14–15; 118:24).

- The children of God, who find refuge in him, love his name. To love his name is to love his very character.

Psalms 5:12

- The psalmist cares not only for himself but for all the godly people.
- A shield, here an image of God's protection, deflects spears and arrows from the one holding it.

Psalms 6:1

do not rebuke me ... or discipline me: The psalmist does not clearly connect God's discipline with sin here (compare Psalm 39:8–11), but it might be implied.

Psalms 6:1–3

The psalmist asks for God's favor and restoration at a difficult time.

Psalms 6:1–10

The occasion for this lament might have been sickness or a mental or spiritual depression from which the psalmist sought healing.

Psalms 6:2–3

The psalmist became physically weak while waiting for God's answer to his prayer (Psalm 6:6; see 77:3; 119:81; 142:1–3; see also Psalm 101). Fasting (abstaining from eating food) might have contributed to his suffering, but it is not mentioned.

Psalms 6:4–5

The experience was so painful that the psalmist might as well have been dead, or perhaps he feared for his life.

Psalms 6:5

from Sheol?: In the Old Testament, Sheol is the place of the dead. It is not necessarily associated with punishment.

Psalms 6:6–7

- The psalmist feels deeply exhausted due to his spiritual distance from the Lord (Psalms 22:1; 31:9–10; 102:5).
- When eyes grow dim, it means the body is failing (see Psalms 13:3; 31:9; 38:10; Matthew 6:22).

Psalms 6:8–10

In a closing note of triumph, the psalmist reasserts his confidence in the Lord.

Psalms 7:1

Pursuers, a common term for enemies, actively look for people in order to harm or destroy them (Psalm 31:15; 56:1–2; 71:11; 143:3).

Psalms 7:1–17

This psalm includes the following:

- A lament (Psalm 7:1–2): The psalmist cries out to God for help and protection from enemies.
- An oath of innocence (Psalm 7:3–5): The psalmist declares that he has done no wrong and maintains his integrity.
- A call for God's justice (Psalm 7:6–9): He asks God to act against evildoers and defend the righteous.
- An affirmation of God's just kingship (Psalm 7:10–16): The psalmist praises God as a fair judge who rules the world rightly.

- A concluding hymn of praise (Psalm 7:17): The psalmist ends with a song of thanksgiving, honoring God's righteousness and deliverance.

Psalms 7:title

An unknown person from the tribe of Benjamin remained hostile to David.

Psalms 7:2

Like a lion, a wicked enemy relentlessly and violently pursues its prey (Psalms 10:9; 17:12; 22:13, 21; 35:17; 57:4), but God promises victory (91:13).

Psalms 7:3

The psalmist does not claim to be without sin, but he knows that he does not deserve the cruel attacks of his opponents (see 35:7).

Psalms 7:3–5

The psalmist declares his innocence, opening himself up to examination (Psalm 7:9).

Psalms 7:5

- trample: Compare Psalm 44:5; 60:12; 91:13; 108:13.
- to the ground ... in the dust: Disgrace and shame can lead to death and the grave (Psalm 143:3; see 13:3–4).

Psalms 7:6

God's judgment brings justice, despite the chaos created by enemies (see 7:11).

Psalms 7:6–9

With this appeal to God for justice in the world, the psalmist also submits to God's examination.

Psalms 7:8

- The judgment is against the defendants (the peoples) and in favor of the righteous plaintiff (the psalmist; see Psalm 43:1).
- The psalmist, though not free from all sin, is a person of true integrity (see Psalm 15:2; 25:21; 41:12; 78:72; compare Job 1:1, 8; 9:20, 22).

Psalms 7:9

God knows the thoughts and intentions of every person. He does not see only outward actions. He examines what is hidden in the mind and the heart (see Psalms 11:3–4; 26:2; 139:1, 23).

Psalms 7:10–13

The psalmist moves from his own situation (Psalm 7:1–9) to speak for all the godly who seek redemption (7:10–16). He protects and vindicates his people. When his followers cry out for help, God hears them and acts to rescue them.

Psalms 7:11

The righteous judge cannot be bought or bribed. He does not abuse his power (Psalm 9:4; compare 82:1–8).

Psalms 7:12–13

sword ... bow ... deadly weapons ... arrows with fire: As the Divine Warrior, God attacks to defend himself and his people.

Psalms 7:14

Evil starts with small words or actions and leads to worse deeds over time (see Isaiah 59:4–5).

Psalms 7:17

- I will thank ... sing praise: The laments in Psalms 3–7 usually shift from lament to praise, as does the entire book of Psalms.
- Most High: This is an ancient title for God (see Genesis 14:19).
- God is just and reliable, so his order prevails in this world.

Psalms 8:1

- The LORD (Hebrew Yahweh) is the covenant God of Israel (Exodus 3:15). This name emphasizes God's faithfulness and relationship with his people.

He is also Lord (Hebrew 'adonay), which emphasizes his authority. As Lord, he is the king over the earth and all creation.

- The word translated as majestic (and sometimes mighty) can describe:
- kings (Psalm 136:18),
- heroes (Psalm 16:3),
- mountains (Psalm 76:4), or
- waves breaking on the seashore (Psalm 93:4).

While all these things are awe-inspiring and mighty, they are less impressive than the Lord.

- A person's name represents their reputation.
- The earth and the heavens reveal the Lord's splendor. All creation worships and praises the Lord (Psalm 66:4; 113:3; 145:21).

Psalms 8:1–9

Psalm 8 begins the second part of Book One of the Psalms (Psalms 8–14). The psalmist praises God's creation and the dignity of the ideal human (see Psalm 1). Instead of the world of enemies, wicked people, and unfair justice shown in Psalms 3–7, this psalm presents the world as God first made it. Someone who is tired (both physically and emotionally) can imagine a place of dignity in God's world.

Psalms 8:2

- silence: The loud noise of the adversaries contrasts with the praise of God. In the end, the praise of God will overwhelm the sound of evil (Psalms 31:18; 63:11; 101:5; 143:12).
- Those who oppose God are filled with vengeful anger (Psalm 2:1–3; 44:16; compare 149:6–7).

Psalms 8:3

Many nations near Israel worshiped the sun, moon, and stars as gods. They thought these objects controlled life and events.

The psalmist reminds us that, while the sun, moon, and stars are great and beautiful, they are only created by God.

Because these things are his creation, they point to God's power and majesty. They give a reason to praise the Almighty, who alone is worthy of worship.

Psalms 8:3–5

God's glory is vast and awe-inspiring. At first, it might seem that people are too small or unimportant to matter to him.

Yet God has given humans honor and dignity. He has crowned them with glory and set them in charge of creation.

This shows that every person has value. Humans are called to care for and rule over the world responsibly, reflecting God's glory in their lives.

Psalms 8:4

son of man (literally son of Adam): This means "a human being." Through the influence of Daniel 7:13–14, son of man became a title with divine meaning in the New Testament. See Hebrews 2:6–8, where this passage is quoted.

Psalms 8:5

You made him a little lower than the angels: Humans bear God's image. The Lord has given humans dignity and tasked them to rule (Genesis 1:26–27).

Hebrews 2:6–8 applies these words to Jesus Christ, the ideal human who fully realized God's purposes.

Psalms 8:6

made him ruler of the works of Your hands: The psalmist is still referring to humans in general.

Paul applies these words to Jesus as the perfect man who has made the created order, and even death (1 Corinthians 15:25–27), subject to God and his glory.

The New Testament connects these themes of creation and salvation with Jesus Christ (John 1:1–2, 14; Colossians 1:16).

Psalms 8:7–8

Wild animals, including birds and fish, remind us of God's creation of the animal world in Genesis 1. Contrary to beliefs among Israel's neighbors in the ancient Near East, animals are not sacred.

Psalms 9:1

- The verb translated as give thanks is also translated as thank in Psalm 7:17. This shows a strong connection between Psalms 7 and 9 (see 7:17; 8:1–2).

The phrase with all my heart shows the psalmist's deep devotion and commitment (Psalms 86:12; 111:1; 119:10; 138:1).

- I will recount: These stories teach the next generation (Psalms 78:4; 145:4). If forgotten, a generation might easily turn away from the Lord (Psalms 78:11, 32).
- Your wonders: These include the Lord's judgments on the enemies of his people (Psalm 9:4) and his care for the oppressed (9:9). The wonders in creation, redemption, and revelation show his character and power (Psalms 89:5; 111:4; 119:18, 27). His powerful acts inspire public praise (Psalm 9:1; 26:7; 75:1).

Psalms 9:title

However, that tune (or song) is no longer known. The same is true for the tunes mentioned in Psalms 22, 45, 56–60, 69, 75, and 80.

Psalms 9:1–10.18

This hymn celebrates the Lord's rule and triumph over evil. It may also respond to the laments in Psalms 3–7.

Some believe that Psalms 9 and 10 should be read together as one psalm in two parts. This is because Psalm 9 has a title, while Psalm 10 does not.

Despite some missing or inverted letters, the two psalms form an acrostic of the Hebrew alphabet. This means that each line or section begins with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet.

Other alphabetic acrostics include Psalms 25, 34, 37, 111–112, 119, and 145.

The ancient Greek and Latin translations treat Psalms 9 and 10 as one psalm.

Psalms 9:2

rejoice ... will sing praise: The psalmist often connects joy with praises, as one leads to the other (Psalm 5:11–12; 32:11; 67:4; 90:14; 92:4).

Psalms 9:3

retreat ... stumble: The Lord overpowers even powerful enemies (see Psalm 27:2). Israel also experienced judgment when it resisted the Lord (107:12).

Psalms 9:3–6

The psalmist praises God's judgment of the wicked. This shows the Lord's promise to establish his kingdom on earth is trustworthy (Psalms 1:6; 2).

Psalms 9:4

The throne represents the Lord's royal authority.

Psalms 9:5

God created the heavens and the earth with a word (Genesis 1), and he can end nations with a word (see Psalm 2:5).

Those who do evil will not endure forever. God promises that their power and influence will come to an end (Psalm 69:28; Psalm 109:13; Revelation 21:4).

Psalms 9:7–10

The godly do not rely on human governments, which can be weak or corrupt. They understand that earthly rulers are limited and sometimes unfair.

Instead, they put their hope in God's eternal rule. God governs with perfect justice and fairness (see Psalms 96–100).

Psalms 9:9

- The Lord offers shelter in dangerous situations and protection from powerful and oppressive people. The psalms often describe the LORD as:
- a fortress (Psalm 18:2; 31:2),
- a rock (Psalm 18:2; 42:9),
- strength (Psalm 18:1), and
- a strong tower (Psalm 144:2).

These images appear frequently in royal prayers (see Psalm 9:9; 18:30).

- Even oppressed, afflicted, and marginalized people (Psalm 10:17; 74:21) can receive divine protection.
- Times of trouble (Psalm 10:1; 20:1) contrast with moments when the Lord openly shows favor to the afflicted (69:13; 102:13; see Psalm 107:6).

Psalms 9:10

At times, a person may feel separated from the Lord. The psalms describe moments of spiritual alienation or distress (Psalms 22:1; 42:9; 119:8)

Even in these times, the psalms affirm God's faithfulness. The Lord does not abandon his people (16:10; 37:25, 28).

Psalms 9:11

The psalm writers often connect the idea that God dwells (or sits, or is enthroned) with a specific place, such as:

- heaven (Psalm 2:4; see 47:9),
- Jerusalem,
- "between the cherubim"(Psalms 80:1; 99:1),
- "on high" (Psalm 113:5), or
- "at my right hand" (Psalm 110:1).

Since the Lord rules the world, everyone must know about his unforgettable deeds of salvation (see Psalm 9:1; 64:9; 66:16; 105:1).

Psalms 9:11–12

Understanding that the Lord judges some wicked people (Psalm 9:3–6) and promises to judge all evil (9:7–10) inspires praise. The psalmist invites the godly community to join him.

Psalms 9:12

The Lord saves his servants and punishes those who have harmed them (Psalm 18:46). He defends his servants by fairly judging his enemies on earth (Psalm 58:11). Those who follow God do not seek revenge. Instead, they wait for the Lord to defend them (Psalm 94:1–2; Deuteronomy 32:35; Romans 12:19).

Psalms 9:13–14

- The psalmist returns from a vision of the glorious future to the reality of facing his enemies (Psalm 9:3).
- The gates are a strong image of the powerful grip of death (see Psalm 13:3–4).
- The gates of Daughter Zion (that is, Jerusalem) provide an intentional contrast to the gates of death.

Psalms 9:18

Hope requires waiting for the Lord's rescue or justice (Psalms 25:3, 5, 21). The godly experience hope, rest, and peace as they wait for the Lord (see Psalm 1:6; 27:14).

Psalms 9:19–20

- The psalmist concludes his lament by asking God to act on his behalf. He prays for the Lord's intervention against those who do wrong. This includes a request for divine vengeance (God's just punishment of evildoers). The psalmist trusts that only God can bring true justice.
- but men: People who gain power and honor can become oppressive and assume glory for themselves (see Psalm 8:4; 10:18).

Psalms 10:1

The opening questions set the mood. The Lord does not seem to hear the prayers of his people (Psalm 22:1, 19; see 2 Kings 4:27; Isaiah 1:15).

Psalms 10:1–18

The lament in Psalm 9:13–20 continues in Psalm 10 (see study note on Psalms 9–10). However, the mood shifts from confident statements to anguished questions. The psalmist prays for rescue, trusting that the Lord, as a just king, take care of the needy.

Psalms 10:2

The wicked openly defy God with their actions and words (Psalm 17:10; 31:18; 59:12; 73:8; 123:4). Although the Lord will deal with them (Psalm 31:23), they trouble the righteous (see Psalm 5:4–6) before their condemnation and judgment.

Psalms 10:2–11

Wicked and oppressive people might succeed, causing harmful effects. Evil can be as dramatic as the psalmist portrays it here, or it could be more subtle.

Psalms 10:3

Unlike those who have evil desires, the godly wait for justice (Psalm 10:17).

Psalms 10:4

there is no God: See Psalms 10:11; 14:1.

Psalms 10:6–7

Even though they act wrongly (Psalms 5:9; 28:3; Romans 3:14), the wicked still hope for a future free of trouble like the righteous will enjoy.

Psalms 10:8

The wicked rely on violence (Psalms 11:5; 37:32) and deception (Proverbs 12:6; 23:27–28).

Psalms 10:12–15

With confidence that the wicked will be held responsible for their deeds and that the Lord will care for the helpless, the psalmist prays intensely for rescue from evil.

Psalms 10:14

The Lord cares for those who suffer. He will notice and punish those who do evil (see Psalm 72:14; 116:15).

Psalms 10:15

- The psalmist prays and calls for a strong curse (see "Prayers for Vengeance" Theme Note).
- Arms represent the ability to wage war (Psalms 18:34; 44:3).

Psalms 10:16

As the true and just king, God will bring the wicked to an end, as he promises (Psalm 1:6).

Psalms 10:17–18

The psalmist expresses his confidence in the Lord.

Psalms 10:18

People often misuse their power and enslave the very people God wants them to serve (see Psalms 9:19–20; Luke 22:25–26).

Psalms 11:1

- God offers protection (refuge; see Psalms 5:11; 9:9; 25:20) when justice fails.
- The mountains offer another place of refuge (see Psalm 121:1).

Psalms 11:1–7

The psalmist affirms his faith in the righteous God. Even though the world appears hopelessly chaotic, both the godly and the wicked can depend on God's justice. The godly can depend on him as a refuge and shelter.

Psalms 11:2

The wicked live in the shadows and create gloom for the godly (Psalms 82:5; 139:11; 143:3; Proverbs 4:19).

Psalms 11:2–3

In the ongoing struggle between those who do evil and those who follow God, the wicked often harm the righteous. This can leave the godly confused and full of questions.

Psalms 11:3

The wicked create a world of darkness (see Psalms 82:5).

Psalms 11:4

The righteous King rules from heaven, where his throne remains free from human corruption (see Psalm 2:4). He examines everyone and sees everything that happens on earth (see Psalm 14:2–3).

Psalms 11:5

- hates: See Psalm 5:4–6; Proverbs 6:16–18.
- Wicked deeds result in destruction and violence (Psalms 58:2; 73:6; 74:20).

Psalms 11:6

God sent fiery coals and burning sulfur on Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19) as symbols of judgment (Psalms 18:8; 120:4; 140:10).

Psalms 11:7

The godly are assured of the Lord's favorable presence when they see his face (see Psalm 23:6).

Psalms 12:1–4

Evil becomes so widespread that the godly pray for rescue (Isaiah 57:1; Micah 7:2; compare Psalms 1:6; 37:20; 58:7; 104:35).

Psalms 12:1–8

This prayer from the community asks the Lord for help against the many evil acts in the world. Because God answers, the godly can face the future with confidence, knowing that God protects them.

Psalms 12:4

The words they say reveal the character of the wicked. They deceive and overpower the godly and arrogantly question the Lord's purposes.

Psalms 12:6

- The godly can trust the Lord's promises, but not the lies of the wicked (Psalm 12:2–4).
- Sevenfold means entirely or completely.

Psalms 12:7–8

Those who follow God know that he cares, even when the wicked oppress them. God sees the corrupt and foolish people who praise those who do evil (see Psalms 9:19–20; 14:2–6).

Psalms 13:1–2

How long?: Repeating the question four times shows intense worry and deep pain (Psalm 79:5).

Psalms 13:1–6

The psalmist's loud cry for help becomes a confident song of hope.

Psalms 13:2

A feeling of deep sadness and pain can make it hard to see any hope (Psalm 6:3). Without God's answer to his prayers (Psalm 22:1), death seems unavoidable, painful, and slow (Psalms 6:6; 32:3; 55:4; 61:2; 102:5; 116:3). The psalmist struggles to pray and longs for God's redemption (Psalms 25:17–18; 31:10; 38:8; 39:2).

Psalms 13:3

The psalmist's suffering feels like death (Psalms 22:15; 55:4; 88:15; 94:17; 116:3).

Psalms 13:3–4

Only the Lord can provide understanding and comfort. The psalmist hopes for the Lord's justice so his enemies will not celebrate.

Psalms 13:5–6

The psalmist no longer hears the mockery of his enemies. Instead, he feels joyful because he trusts in the Lord.

Psalms 14:1

Also known as fools, the wicked talk to themselves, think, scheme (Psalm 10:4, 6, 11), and make claims. However, because they ignore God's revelation, they lack understanding (Psalms 14:1; 39:8; 53:1; 74:18, 22).

Psalms 14:1–3

Paul uses phrases from the Greek translation of this passage in his description of the wickedness of all people (Romans 3:10–12).

Psalms 14:1–7

This wisdom psalm includes elements of lament and prophetic speech. The ideals of Psalm 8 clash with foolish human attitudes and sinful actions. Except for verses 5–6, this psalm is similar to Psalm 53.

Psalms 14:2–3

From heaven (Psalms 33:13; 80:14; 102:19), the Lord sees the wicked, who are clearly evil (Psalm 11:3–5). All humans lack wisdom and do not live in the way God originally intended for them (Psalm 10:4–11; see Romans 1–3).

Psalms 14:4

The evil live at the expense of others (Psalms 27:2; 44:11; 53:4; see Isaiah 5:8) and have no reverence or knowledge of God (Psalm 79:6).

Psalms 14:5

Though the wicked perish (Psalm 1:5–6), God is with the righteous.

Psalms 14:7

- The psalmist prays for the renewal of God's relationship with his people.
- Jacob is another name for Israel (see Genesis 35:9–10).

Psalms 15:1

- Only those who follow God may be in the Lord's presence (Psalm 5:4). As his guests, they experience his hospitality and protection.
- tent: In David's time, God's sanctuary was a tent (the tabernacle; see 1 Samuel 21:6; 2 Samuel 6:17; 7:6; 12:20; 1 Chronicles 6:32).

Psalms 15:1–5

This wisdom poem contrasts the lifestyle of the righteous with the actions of fools (Psalm 14). The questions in this psalm invite people to examine themselves and not pay attention to problems with the wicked. The question of who dwells in God's presence leads into a description of godly character qualities (compare Psalm 24:3–6; Isaiah 33:14–16).

Psalms 15:1–19.14

The psalms in this section emphasize integrity and purity (Psalms 17:15; 18:20–26; 19:13–14). They describe people as living in God's presence (Psalms 16:9–11; 17:15) and remaining steadfast (15:5; 16:8).

Psalms 15:2

The godly speak truthfully and act faithfully in their relationships. Unlike the wicked, they are open and transparent (Psalm 12:2–4).

Psalms 15:5

- The Lord prohibited Israel from charging interest to people in need (Exodus 22:25–27).
- The assurance of God's presence keeps the godly from destruction (Psalms 16:8; 46:5; 125:1). Their situations may temporarily unsettle them, but they ultimately remain strong (Psalm 30:6; 94:18; 112:6).

Psalms 16:1

The psalmist feels safe because only the Lord offers:

- security (Psalm 16:5–6),
- guidance (Psalm 16:7–8), and
- the joy of his presence (Psalm 16:9–11).

Psalms 16:1–11

In this psalm of confidence, the poet quickly transitions from a brief request (Psalm 16:1) to expressions of deep commitment to God and his people (Psalm 16:2–6). The psalm concludes with confident praise (Psalm 16:7–11).

Psalms 16:2

I said to the LORD: The various writers of the psalms pray, lament, and praise the Lord throughout the Psalter (the book of Psalms). The Lord answers them (see Psalm 12:5–6).

Psalms 16:4

The psalmist separates himself from unholy worship, rituals, and words (see Psalm 15:3–5).

Psalms 16:5

The cup of blessing represents how God supplies all the psalmist's needs (Psalm 23:5; see 116:13; compare 75:8; Isaiah 51:17).

Psalms 16:6

The land is God's gift for his people (Deuteronomy 18:8).

Psalms 16:7–8

- God's guidance gives life (Psalm 16:11; see 5:8; 23:1–3; 32:8; 73:24).
- The psalmist relies on the Lord for strength and joy, feeling God's presence beside him (Psalm 16:11; see 73:23; 109:31; 110:1, 5; 121:5).
- Peter quoted Psalm 16:8–11 in his sermon on the day of Pentecost (Acts 2:25–28).

Psalms 16:9–11

The psalmist feels confident because he knows that even death cannot separate him from the Lord. He fears separation (see Psalm 13:3–4), but he remains confident that he will see the Lord (see 11:7).

Psalms 16:10

The psalmist shows belief that life goes on after death. The apostles applied this text to the resurrection of Jesus (Acts 2:25–33; 13:35).

Psalms 16:11

at Your right hand: See Psalm 16:7–8; 110:1.

Psalms 17:1

comes from lips free of deceit: Deception characterizes the wicked. The righteous reject such deceit as a failure of character and pray for rescue from such people (Psalms 5:6; 43:1; 120:2). They love honesty, truth, and integrity (Psalms 15:2–3; 24:4; 101:7).

Psalms 17:1–15

The psalmist asks for God's protection and justice, affirms his own integrity, and prays for the Lord to defeat his strong enemies.

Psalms 17:3

Although he is not perfect, the psalmist dedicates himself to the Lord. He does not want to sin through lies, flattery, or gossip (see Psalms 10:7; 15:2–3; 17:1).

Psalms 17:3–5

The psalmist declares his innocence (Psalm 17:1) and commits himself to integrity by being open to God's examination.

Psalms 17:6–9

This prayer for God's care continues the request begun in Psalm 17:1–2 for redemption from evil.

Psalms 17:8

- as the apple of Your eye (literally as the pupil of your eye): This metaphor shows God's care and love for the psalmist (see Deuteronomy 32:10).
- The shadow of God's wings is a place of his protection from enemies and hardship (Psalms 36:7; 57:1; 61:4; 63:7; 91:4).

Psalms 17:13–14

The psalmist prays confidently for the Lord's victory, knowing God is more powerful than the evildoers. The psalmist finds joy in the Lord's inheritance (Psalm 16:5), whereas the wicked search for joy in this world.

Psalms 17:15

behold Your face: The psalmist does not allow temporary concerns raised by adversaries to stand in the way of his experiencing a real and lasting relationship with the Lord.

Psalms 18:1

- The servant of the Lord was given the duty to establish God's kingdom on earth (see Psalm 78:70; 132:10; 144:10).
- The Lord rescued David from all his enemies by helping him defeat them (see 2 Samuel 8:1–14).

Psalms 18:1–50

This psalm describes a royal story of God rescuing his king. A similar version of this psalm appears in 2 Samuel 22:1–51. The psalm encourages those who hear the earlier prayers for help in Psalms 16 and 17.

The psalmist describes the dramatic nature of God's rescue in three different ways (Psalm 18:7–15, 16–19, 30–36). The psalm also offers hope that a future Son of David will completely defeat evil (Psalm 18:43–50; compare Psalm 2).

Psalms 18:2

A shield symbolizes protection, salvation, and victory (Psalms 7:10; 18:2, 30, 35; 84:11; 91:4; 115:9, 10, 11; 119:114; 144:2). It inspires trust, patience, and confidence in God.

Psalms 18:3

God deserves praise for his greatness and faithfulness (Psalms 48:1; 96:4; 145:3).

Psalms 18:6

God lives in his sanctuary, the heavenly temple (Psalm 102:19; see 14:2–3). He knows everything and sees every

person. He will defend and vindicate those who live in a faithful and righteous way (see Psalm 11:3–7).

Psalms 18:7

The destabilization of the whole earth will be a means of God's judgment (Psalm 77:17–18; 96:9; 97:4; 99:1; 104:32; Isaiah 29:6; Micah 1:3–4; Nahum 1:2–6; Haggai 2:7, 21).

Psalms 18:7–15

The psalmist describes the Lord coming down from heaven to earth. This moment includes powerful signs such as earthquakes, fire, smoke, darkness, and rain. All creation trembles when God appears.

The psalm shows God as the Divine Warrior (a title that describes God fighting for his people, see Psalm 97:2–5) and as the Judge who rules with justice (see 50:1–6).

Psalms 18:8

- His nostrils ... His mouth: The psalmist compares God to an angry person or a fierce creature (see Job 41:12–22).
- The frightening images of smoke, flames, and glowing coals show God's anger against sin.

Psalms 18:9–11

The Lord rules over all of nature (see Psalm 104:2–4; 148:5–6).

Psalms 18:10

a cherub: See study notes on 1 Chronicles 28:18; 2 Chronicles 3:10–13.

Psalms 18:19

God loves and delights in the psalmist (see Psalm 18:1), so he will save him (37:23; 41:11; 91:14–16).

Psalms 18:20–24

The psalmist states that loyalty brings rewards. He trusts in the Lord (see Psalm 16:1) and promises to live with integrity (see Psalms 1, 15, 24; see also 19:12–14).

Psalms 18:21

- kept the ways of the LORD: The psalmist follows God's instructions faithfully (see Psalm 25:8–10).
- have not wickedly departed: The psalmist avoids foolishness (see Psalms 1 and 14) and chooses wisdom (see Psalms 1 and 15).

Psalms 18:25–29

The faithful God remains true to his character. He loves faithfulness, innocence, and purity, and he hates wickedness (see Psalm 1:6).

Psalms 18:26

- The pure have clean hands (see Psalm 18:20–24).
- to the crooked You show Yourself shrewd: The Lord understands everyone's character and responds to them fairly.

Psalms 18:27

haughty: The Lord hates pride (Psalm 101:5; 131:1; see Proverbs 6:16–17; 21:4; 30:13).

Psalms 18:28

light my lamp: The Lord renews the psalmist's life, helping him overcome the darkness of difficult times (see Psalms 112:4; 119:105).

Psalms 18:29

scale a wall: God helps his servants fight their battles.

Psalms 18:30

- perfect: God's character is full of integrity. He is completely trustworthy (see Psalm 18:26).
- God promises to protect his people, and he keeps this promise.
- Seeking God's protection requires trust and faith. Despite his feelings or external circumstances, the psalmist makes a deep commitment to the Lord. He experiences joy (Psalms 5:11; 64:10) as he waits for the Lord's rescue (Psalm 57:1).

Psalms 18:30–36

The psalmist experiences God's rescue and provision of victory.

Psalms 18:32–34

The psalmist's victories come from the Lord. He completely depends on God.

Psalms 18:36

A wide path represents freedom and safety (see Psalms 4:8; 119:35).

Psalms 18:37–42

With help from the Divine Warrior, the psalmist experienced victory over his enemies.

Psalms 18:40

Placing a foot on the necks of the enemy represents total victory (see Joshua 10:23–26).

Psalms 18:43–45

With God's help and victory, the psalmist gained success in battle and in ruling the nation. In this way, the psalm reflects the promise about David's royal line in Psalm 2.

This psalm also answers some of the earlier prayers for help. The laments in earlier psalms begin to find resolution here.

Psalms 18:46–50

The psalmist again reflects on the Lord's victories. God's amazing rescue and the king's victory are cause for celebration.

Psalms 18:47

God defends and vindicates his servant. In this way, God fulfills the mission he gave him (Psalm 2; see 47:3; 144:2).

Psalms 18:49

The psalmist's vision of praise among the nations inspired Paul in his mission to the Gentiles (Romans 15:9).

Psalms 18:50

God appointed David, his chosen leader, to bring order to God's world (see Psalm 2). Both David and his descendants received this responsibility.

Psalms 19:1

- The glory of God refers to the Creator's splendor or visible presence (Psalm 113:4).
- God (Hebrew 'el): El is an ancient name for God. It shows his power as the Creator.

Psalms 19:1–4

The created world shows God's wisdom, and the heavens are where God lives (Psalm 2:4; see 8:1; 57:5; 89:6; 115:3). From heaven, God watches over people (Psalms 11:4; 14:2; 33:13; 53:2; 80:14; 102:19) and helps his followers (18:6–8, 13; 20:6; 57:3; 76:8; 144:5).

The heavens remain unaffected by human failures and rebellions (see Psalm 2:1–4). They show God's faithfulness, righteousness (Psalms 36:5; 50:6; 57:10; 85:11; 89:2, 5; 97:6; 108:4), and wisdom (136:5; see 119:89–90). The heavens reveal the Lord's glory (see Psalm 19:1) and prove his presence and work.

Psalms 19:1–14

God's wisdom is clearly shown in many places:

- It appears in the heavens (Psalm 19:1–4),
- in nature (Psalm 19:4–6),
- in his teachings (Psalm 19:7–11), and
- in the life of the psalmist (Psalm 19:12–14)

Like Psalm 8, this hymn uses creation to lead people to reflect on God. It offers a calm moment after the intense prayers and victory songs in earlier psalms.

The psalm begins with creation as a source of wisdom. It then moves to God's word as the perfect source of wisdom. Finally, it ends with the human need for redemption.

Psalms 19:3–4

- God's wisdom does not need to be spoken. Through creation, it is seen, felt, and experienced. Paul applied this text to condemn Israel for its lack of receptivity to Jesus Christ (Romans 10:18).
- The sun is part of God's creation, but it is not a god, as people of other nations in the ancient Near East commonly believed.

Psalms 19:7–11

God's instructions to humans show his character and wisdom. His guidance is valuable and enjoyable (Psalm 119:103). It nurtures the individual (Proverbs 16:24; 24:14) and holds more value than material possessions (Psalm 81:13–16).

Psalms 19:12–14

The psalmist knows his weaknesses, so he prays to remain faithful and commits himself to the Lord.

Psalms 19:13

- A person who commits deliberate sins does so with a proud and defiant attitude (Psalm 86:14; 119:21, 69).
- The great transgression is rebellion (see Psalm 32:1).

Psalms 19:14

words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart: The psalmist desires to please God in everything he says and thinks (see Luke 6:45; Romans 12:1–2).

Psalms 20:1

- The title God of Jacob shows God's long-standing relationship with his people (see Psalms 46:7, 11; 75:9; 76:6; 81:1, 4; 84:8; 94:7; 114:7; 146:5).
- protect you: See Psalm 59:1–2.

Psalms 20:1–5

The community prays for the king's protection and victory.

Psalms 20:1–9

This royal prayer asks God to give victory to the king (Psalm 20:1–5). It then expresses confidence that God will bring rescue (20:6–8). The psalm ends with the people asking God to answer their prayer (20:9).

Psalms 20:1–24.10

This series of psalms shows a journey from confidence and commitment (Psalms 20–21), through anguish and abandonment (Psalm 22), and finally to comfort, insight, and hope (Psalms 23–24).

Psalms 20:3

Gifts and burnt offerings show submission to the Lord (compare Psalm 40:6).

Psalms 20:4–5

make all your plans succeed ... grant all your petitions: These requests might be those mentioned in Psalm 21:3–6 (compare 27:4).

Psalms 20:5

Troops carried a victory banner to battle. They gathered under it and encouraged each other to act (see Isaiah 11:10, 12).

Psalms 20:6

God chose his anointed king to be ruler (see Psalm 2:7).

Psalms 20:6–8

A community member (Psalm 20:1–5) responds with words of assurance and confidence in God's help.

Psalms 20:7

chariots and ... horses: These were tools used in war (see Psalms 33:16–17; 76:6; 147:10; Isaiah 30:16; 31:1–3).

Psalms 21:1–13

God's people thank him for giving victory to the king.

Psalms 21:2

God has given the king what he desired. God protected him and blessed him (see Psalm 20:5; see also 2:8).

Psalms 21:3

rich blessings: See Proverbs 10:6.

Psalms 21:3–6

The king returned victorious from battle and received honor from the people. His greatest honor came from God, who gave him blessings, life, and his presence.

Psalms 21:4

God offers a rich quality of life (Psalms 61:6–7; 91:14–16; 128:4–6). This life is characterized by:

- God's presence (Psalms 16:11; 23:6; 27:4; 36:9),
- joy (Psalm 16:11)
- goodness (Psalm 23:6; 34:14–15), and
- protection (Psalm 41:2; 61:7).

Psalms 21:6

God's eternal blessings also bring a full life now (see Psalm 133).

Psalms 21:7

The king was victorious not because of his strength or goodness, but because God honored his faith.

Psalms 21:8–12

As long as even a single enemy opposed the king's authority, God's kingdom was not fully present. This prayer requests victory over all evil in the world.

Psalms 21:9

The fiery furnace and fire represent the seriousness of God's judgment on the wicked. In the Old Testament, fire often represents God's anger against sin and destructive judgment (Psalms 11:6; 18:8; 50:3; 68:2; 78:21; 79:5; 80:16; 89:46; 97:3; 104:4; 140:10; see Isaiah 66:24).

Psalms 21:10

descendants ... offspring: Evil will end when God destroys all opposition to himself (Psalm 109:13; compare 18:50; 22:30–31; 25:13; 102:28).

Psalms 21:13

Be exalted (compare Psalm 57:5, 11; 108:5) expresses communal praise and joy in God's greatness and power.

Psalms 22:1–2

The psalmist feels deeply separated from God (see Psalm 10:1).

Psalms 22:1–21

The psalmist switches between thinking about his current difficult situation and remembering the Lord's past faithfulness. He ends the psalm with a prayer for rescue.

Psalms 22:1–31

All previous laments seem minor compared to this outcry against the enemy and God's abandonment. The psalm has two main sections:

- the lament (Psalm 22:1–21) and
- praise for redemption (Psalm 22:22–31).

This naturally leads to Psalm 23.

The apostles saw this psalm as expressing the sufferings of Jesus Christ. He ultimately fulfilled the purpose of David's humiliation, rejection by people, and divine abandonment (Matthew 27:35, 39, 43, 46; Mark 15:34; John 19:23–24, 28; Hebrews 2:12).

Psalms 22:3

- God, the holy King, is set apart from all his creation, but he chooses to reveal himself to Israel.
- God strongly desires that his people praise him.

Psalms 22:6–8

Both the Lord and the people reject the psalmist. He clearly describes his pain (Psalm 22:1–2). He lives like a humble animal.

Psalms 22:7

People ridicule the psalmist's trust in the Lord (see Psalm 3:2; Matthew 27:43), which shames him (Psalms 44:13–14; 74:10; 89:50; 109:25).

Psalms 22:9

The Lord took care of the psalmist before the psalmist could do anything for himself (see Psalm 71:6; 139:13).

Psalms 22:9–11

The psalmist thinks about his past relationship with God (see Psalm 22:3–5). The Lord has been his very life.

Psalms 22:12

Bashan, a region famous for its herds and plants, produced strong bulls (Psalm 68:30).

Psalms 22:12–18

The psalmist again shares his deep pain and suffering (see Psalm 22:1–2, 6–8). His trouble comes from human beings who act like wild animals.

Psalms 22:14

The psalmist feels like he is poured out like water. This describes a temporary and empty life that leaves him drained.

Psalms 22:15

- Facing adversity is as terrible as dying of thirst (see Psalm 137:6).
- Jesus might have thought of this verse when he said, "I am thirsty" (John 19:28).

Psalms 22:16

The wild pack of dogs represents aggressive and dishonest people.

Psalms 22:17–18

- I can count all my bones: The psalmist's enemies have shamed him by taking his clothes. Jesus also faced this humiliation (see Matthew 27:35).
- stare and gloat over me: Enemies make the psalmist a target of their ridicule (see Psalms 35:24, 26; 38:16; 55:3; compare 59:10).
- cast lots: Casting lots was sometimes a way for religious people to seek God's guidance (Leviticus 16:8; Numbers 27:21; Acts 1:24–26). Here, the lots are thrown as a game of chance. The soldiers threw dice for the clothing of Jesus after the crucifixion (Matthew 27:35; Mark 15:24; Luke 23:34; John 19:24).

Psalms 22:19–21

The psalmist prays to God for help with his troubles. Only the Lord can protect him from dogs, lions, and oxen.

Psalms 22:20

The sword shows that the enemy wants to kill.

Psalms 22:22

- I will proclaim Your name: The writer of Hebrews applies these words to Jesus (Hebrews 2:12).

Psalms 22:22–24

The psalmist praises the Lord and calls for the godly to join him. He tells of God's goodness to the needy, including himself.

Psalms 22:23

The godly respond with awe (see Psalm 22:25).

Psalms 22:24

Unlike how he responds to the wicked (see Psalm 21:8–12), God cares for the needy and listens to their prayers (Psalm 51:17; 69:33; 102:17).

Psalms 22:25

The great assembly might include all nations (Psalm 22:27; 26:12; 35:18).

Psalms 22:25–31

The psalmist promises to praise the Lord, the great King of the earth (Psalm 22:27–28), who helps those in need. Only God deserves praise.

Psalms 22:26

God understands what his people need and provides for them (Psalm 63:5; 81:16; 103:5; 107:9; 132:15; 145:16; 147:14).

Psalms 22:27

families of the nations: All clans and tribes of humanity (see Genesis 12:3; Revelation 5:9–10) will submit to the Lord (Psalm 96:1–3; see Psalms 2, 72; Isaiah 2:2–4; 1 Corinthians 15:25–27).

Psalms 22:28

God alone rules over the whole world (Obadiah 1:21).

Psalms 22:29

The Lord invites everyone, both rich and poor (Psalm 22:26), to the banquet as long as they worship him.

Psalms 22:30

Future generations will join those from the past in praising the Lord (Psalm 22:3–5). The descendants of the godly will receive blessings (Psalm 22:30–31), unlike the children of the wicked (21:10).

Psalms 22:31

The Lord's acts of redemption (Psalms 40:9; 50:6; 71:15, 16, 24; 97:6) show that he is righteous (see 4:1). His righteousness gives him the character needed for leadership, making fair decisions, and building relationships. This virtue brings harmony and order (see Psalm 50:6).

Psalms 23:1

The Lord promises to care for his children (Psalm 34:9–10; Isaiah 51:14). He showed this ability to Israel in the wilderness (Deuteronomy 2:7) and in the promised land (Deuteronomy 8:9).

Psalms 23:1–3

People in the ancient Near East commonly viewed their rulers as shepherds.

Psalms 23:1–6

This psalm, which expresses trust and confidence in the Lord, has been a favorite of God's people for generations. It assures us of God's presence during difficult times. It brings to mind images of the Good Shepherd (Psalm 23:1–3; see Ezekiel 34:12; John 10:11) and the messianic banquet (Psalm 23:5–6; see Isaiah 25:6; Revelation 19:9).

Psalms 23:1–28.9

These psalms develop the importance of:

- integrity (Psalms 25:4–7, 12–14, 21; 26:6, 11; 27:7–12),
- God's care as a shepherd (Psalms 23:1; 28:9),
- God's guidance (Psalms 23:2–3; 25:5; 27:11),
- God's goodness (Psalms 23:6; 25:7–8; 27:13), and
- living in his house (Psalms 23:6; 26:8; 27:4, 8).

Psalms 23:2

- Sheep rest after they have eaten enough (Zephaniah 3:13; see Isaiah 11:7; compare Isaiah 13:20; 27:10).
- The Lord guides the sheep for their benefit (see Psalm 5:8).
- Sheep drink only from still water, so the shepherd finds peaceful streams for them.

Psalms 23:3

- Compare Psalm 19:7; The Law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul.
- The Lord guides by:
- rescuing his people from evil (Psalm 23:4–5; see 31:3),
- bringing them back to himself (Psalms 5:8; 61:2),
- caring for his people (Psalms 48:14; 139:10),
- ruling his people (Psalm 67:4),
- counseling his people (Psalm 73:24),
- protecting his people (Psalms 78:53; 107:30; 143:11), and
- instructing them in wisdom (Psalm 27:11; see Proverbs 4:11).

- The Lord's name guarantees the relationship. He protects his reputation against any claims of abandoning his people or allowing them to sin (see Psalms 25:11; 31:3; 106:8; 143:11).

Psalms 23:4

The shepherd used his rod and staff to protect against danger.

Psalms 23:5

- A feast shows the Lord's care and mercy for his people (see Psalm 22:26, 29). Enemies may watch, but they cannot disturb the guests.
- The ritual of anointing the head with oil honored guests (Psalm 92:9–11), and provided hospitality and refreshment (104:15; 133:2).

Psalms 23:6

The Lord shows his unfailing love through his presence and the unique benefits he provides (Psalms 69:16; 86:17; 109:21; see 18:6; 61:4). He gives care that surpasses the temporary challenges from enemies (Psalm 7:1).

Psalms 24:1

The Lord made the earth and everything in it, and now he rules over it (see 1 Corinthians 10:25–26). He sees all its people (Psalm 33:14), no matter their status (49:1–2).

Psalms 24:1–2

The kingdom belongs to the Creator, the Great King (see Psalm 22:27).

Psalms 24:1–10

The shepherd from Psalm 23, who is also the King of the world, takes control of Zion.

Psalms 24:2

God created everything in an orderly and stable manner (see Psalm 89:11; 102:25; 104:5).

Psalms 24:3

- These questions encourage people to stop focusing on their issues with the wicked and to reflect on themselves (see Psalm 15:1).
- God's holy place is the holy mountain, referring to both Jerusalem and heaven.

Psalms 24:3–6

The citizens of the King's realm include all who seek him. The Lord invites them to enter his presence.

Psalms 24:4

- People with clean hands have not caused harm or damaged relationships (see Psalm 9:12; 15:2–5).
- People with pure hearts dedicate themselves completely to the Lord. This is shown through strong character, honesty, and selflessness (Psalm 51:10; 73:1; see Matthew 5:8).

Psalms 24:10

The LORD of Hosts rules from his home, the temple in Jerusalem (Psalm 84:3–5). He keeps out sin and sinners (Psalm 24:326) but protects everyone living in Zion.

Psalms 25:1

The psalmist commits himself to the Lord instead of to idols (see Psalm 24:3–4).

Psalms 25:1–3

The psalmist is confident that the godly will be proven right and his enemies will fail (see Psalm 25:15–22).

Psalms 25:1–22

This personal lament includes wisdom teachings and a community lament. It starts and ends with a declaration of trust in the Lord (Psalm 25:1–3, 15–22). The psalmist prays for guidance (Psalm 25:4–7) and urges the godly to live wisely (25:12–14).

In addition to the enemies who trouble him, the psalmist confesses his sins(Psalm 25:7, 11, 18) as part of his distress. Trust grows by understanding God's nature: He is compassionate, faithful, and good (Psalm 25:8–10).

Psalms 25:2

Enemies would rejoice by singing a victory song.

Psalms 25:4–6

The right path, the path of wisdom (see Psalm 5:8), involves being open to instruction that leads to life (27:11; 43:3; 73:24; 119:12).

Psalms 25:4–7

In this prayer for guidance, compassion, and forgiveness, the psalmist asks the Lord for wisdom. He admits his past mistakes and recognizes that his hope is in his merciful Savior.

Psalms 25:5

Biblical hope is not just wishing for a good outcome. It means trusting in the Lord's will and having the courage to face disappointments (Psalm 33:22; 130:5).

Psalms 25:6

compassion: See also Psalms 51:1; 57:1; 103:8.

Psalms 25:8–10

The Lord keeps his people close to himself.

Psalms 25:11

The psalmist asks for forgiveness for his many sins (Psalms 25:7; 32:1–5). The sins of Israel's kings showed the weaknesses in David's family line and why it failed in Old Testament Israel (see Psalm 89).

Psalms 25:12–15

Those who fear the Lord will receive further instruction and experience God's presence (Psalm 25:14) and blessing (25:13).

Psalms 25:13

- prosperity: See Psalm 23:6.
- inherit the land: Unlike the wicked, who will perish (Psalm 1:6), the godly have a secure future. In the end, God will bless them, and their blessings will last (see Psalm 37:9, 11, 22, 29, 34; Isaiah 57:13; Matthew 5:5).

Psalms 25:15

free my feet from the mesh: See Psalm 5:9–10; 31:4; 140:5; Proverbs 3:26.

Psalms 25:15–22

The psalmist expresses confidence in the Lord, commits to a life of integrity, and prays for rescue.

Psalms 25:17–18

The psalmist finds no relief (see Psalms 4:1; 13:1–2) as his problems worsen. He connects his anguish to sin but does not explain the nature of his sin (see Psalm 25:7, 11).

Psalms 25:19–20

The psalmist asks God to handle these enemies, knowing that the Lord hates violent people (see Psalm 11:5).

Psalms 25:21

The psalm ends with a promise of trust and hope, just as it began (see Psalms 9:18; 25:5).

Psalms 26:1–3

The psalmist opens himself to divine examination of his life, especially in the areas of his character and devotion.

Psalms 26:1–12

In this personal lament, the psalmist prays for redemption because of his innocence and the Lord's justice.

Psalms 26:3

For God's truth to become part of one's character requires a habitual commitment.

Psalms 26:4–5

Because of his devotion to the Lord (Psalm 26:1–3), the psalmist separates himself from evil people (see Psalm 1:1).

Psalms 26:6

- Ritual purity required the worshiper to wash their hands. This act symbolized separating from evil and evildoers (see Psalm 73:13).
- The altar symbolizes God's presence (Psalm 43:4).

Psalms 26:6–8

The psalmist demonstrates his loyalty to the Lord through pious rituals, praise, and acknowledgment of the Lord's presence in the temple.

Psalms 26:8

The sanctuary represented the visible presence of the Lord (see Psalm 18:6).

Psalms 26:9

Do not take my soul away with sinners: The end of the godly cannot be the same as that of the wicked.

Psalms 26:12

- The psalmist standing on solid ground represents salvation (compare Psalm 143:10).
- in the congregations: This means in the great assembly at the temple (Psalms 26:6–8; 22:25).

Psalms 27:1

Light shows the Lord's goodness (Psalm 27:13; see 4:6; 23:6; 31:19; 38:10; 43:3; 56:13).

Psalms 27:1–3

The psalmist acknowledges the Lord at the center of his life (Psalm 27:1). Because of God's presence, he engages his adversaries with confidence. They cannot intimidate him or disrupt his inner peace.

Psalms 27:1–14

This psalm combines two types—a psalm of confidence (Psalm 27:1–6) and an individual lament (27:7–14)—united by the theme of longing for the Lord's presence. The psalmist focuses on the Lord, making his own circumstances less important. The psalmist shows strong faith by being open to the Lord's guidance, timing, and priorities.

Psalms 27:2

The psalmist's enemies want to take advantage of him and live off his resources (see study note on Psalm 14:4).

Psalms 27:3

keep my trust: See Psalms 25:2; 26:1.

Psalms 27:4–6

Seeking and enjoying the Lord's presence gives the psalmist confidence and security. He trusts in God's protection and looks forward to giving thanks and praise (see Psalm 18:6).

Psalms 27:5

tent (or tabernacle): This early shrine was where the Israelites worshipped before they built the temple.

Psalms 27:6

- my head will be held high: This is a sign of victory.
- The granting of the request of Psalm 27:4 leads to sacrifices with joyful shouts.

Psalms 27:7–8

Unlike the wicked (Psalm 10:4), who only want a temporary advantage (78:34–36), the godly search for the Lord like a thirsty person seeks water in the desert (63:1; 105:4; 119:2, 10; Matthew 6:33). They act wisely (Psalm 34:10, 14) while waiting for the Lord to resolve their crisis (34:4; 69:6; 77:2; 119:58).

Psalms 27:7–12

The psalmist asks for the Lord's mercy, presence, and guidance. For the psalmist, God is the greatest good, while enemies and other situations are less important.

Psalms 27:13–14

The psalmist shows confidence and hope in the Lord's presence. Living in faith means waiting patiently, knowing the Lord is good. This life is not always easy for the faithful (Psalm 42:2–3; 43:5), but their future is secure (37:9; 130:7; see 9:18).

Psalms 28:1

if You remain silent: The psalmist asks the Lord to act (Psalm 35:22; 50:3; 83:1; 109:1).

Psalms 28:1–2

The psalmist asks the Lord to listen. His urgent request comes from the tension between his close relationship with the Lord and the trouble he is facing.

Psalms 28:1–9

In this personal lament, the psalmist asks for justice and mercy. He trusts in the Lord's strength and faithfulness and prays for the Lord's people.

Psalms 28:2

People often raised their hands as a sign of devoted prayer (Psalms 63:4; 134:2).

Psalms 28:3–5

The psalmist asks God to punish his enemies and prove his innocence.

Psalms 28:5

The wicked do not acknowledge the difference between the sacred and the common, so they have no respect for the Lord's creation, redemption, or revelation.

Psalms 28:6–8

The psalmist anticipates rescue because of his confidence in the Lord's justice.

Psalms 28:7

my strength and my shield: The Lord protects the psalmist (see Psalm 59:9, 17).

Psalms 28:9

- The poem closes with intercession for the Lord's people.
- bless Your inheritance: See Psalms 29:11; 133:3.

Psalms 29:1–2

- The psalmist issues a call to honor the Lord for his power (see Psalm 96:7–8).
- O heavenly beings: Angels or deities who, some believed, held special powers. The psalmist did not believe in other gods but called on people who thought they were real to look to the Lord as the only God.

Psalms 29:1–11

This nature hymn in praise of the Creator declares that the Lord holds all power over nature. God uses the same unsurpassed strength to care for his people.

Psalms 29:3–9

The Hebrew word qol can mean "voice," "noise" (1 Kings 1:45), or "thunder" (Joel 3:16). The Lord's voice is awe-inspiring and overpowers any sounds people might attribute to other gods.

Psalms 29:5

The cedars of Lebanon were famous for their large size and high quality (see Isaiah 2:13).

Psalms 29:6

- Lebanon's mountains and Sirion (another name for Mount Hermon) are high mountains to the north of Israel.
- The Lord can make even huge mountains shake when he commands it (see Psalm 114:4).

Psalms 29:8

The Wilderness of Kadesh was south of Judah. People could hear God's voice across the land, from the north (Psalm 29:6) to the south.

Psalms 29:10

The image of strong floodwaters relates to the great flood (Genesis 6:17). The Lord rules as king over all creation. No one challenges his kingdom.

Psalms 29:11

The ruler of nature blesses his people with peace (see Psalms 28:8–9; 37:11; 133:3).

Psalms 30:1

- I will exalt You is a call to praise and thank the Lord (Psalms 34:3; 81:1; 99:5, 9; 107:32; 118:28; 145:1; see Exodus 15:1; Isaiah 25:1).
- You have lifted me up: God saved the psalmist from death (Psalm 30:3).
- God, in his justice and care, did not let the psalmist's enemies win (see Psalms 26:9; 27:12; 28:3; 31:8).

Psalms 30:1–3

The psalmist praises God for his victory over difficult circumstances, comparing it to being saved from death.

Psalms 30:1–12

This individual thanksgiving psalm begins by praising the Lord for his salvation (Psalm 30:1–3). It then contrasts God's favor with his anger (Psalm 30:4–7) and ends with a transformation from mourning to dancing (30:8–12).

Psalms 30:title

Perhaps David wrote this psalm before the dedication of the temple, making his own experience representative of the nation's.

Psalms 30:4

The godly should celebrate the Lord's acts of rescue with song and praise (Psalms 33:21; 97:12; 103:1; 105:3; 145:21).

Psalms 30:6–7

- I will never be shaken: The psalmist admits his overconfident attitude (compare Psalm 32:3–4).
- my mountain stand strong: In the psalms, this phrase powerfully symbolizes stability and God's control (see Psalms 11:1; 18:7; 36:6; 46:2; 72:3; 76:4; 83:14; 97:5; 114:4, 6; 125:2).
- I was dismayed: The absence of God's favor destroys the security of the proud (compare Psalm 104:27–30).

Psalms 30:8–12

The psalmist faced death (also in Psalm 30:1–3), either literally or figuratively. When he turned to the Lord, the Lord rescued him and changed his mourning into joyful dancing. Only God's favor can permanently and powerfully overcome human failure and deep despair.

Psalms 31:1–5

The Lord provides safety to anyone seeking his protection. The psalmist trusts and submits to the Lord. See also Psalm 71:1–3.

Psalms 31:1–24

The psalmist urges the faithful to seek safety in the Lord and wait for his salvation. After experiencing something like death, he shares how the Lord remained faithful. This psalm points ahead to the suffering of Jesus (Luke 23:46).

Psalms 31:2

The psalmist urgently asks the Lord to notice his desperate situation (PSalms 71:2; 88:2; 102:2).

Psalms 31:5

Into Your hands I commit my spirit: The psalmist will trust his Lord, whether he lives or dies. Jesus said these words on the cross before he died (Luke 23:46).

Psalms 31:6–8

Trusting the Lord means believing he cares about our well-being.

Psalms 31:8

in the open: This means a wide area, unlike a narrow or tight place that causes distress (see Psalm 18:19).

Psalms 31:9–13

In this prayer for mercy, the psalmist places a description of his intense suffering and the pain of rejection between two statements of trust in the Lord (Psalm 31:6, 14).

Psalms 31:10

my bones are wasting away: This phrase powerfully describes how despair can harm our physical health.

Psalms 31:14–18

Hope does not trust weak and unreliable human beings. It trusts only in the Lord. The suffering person places his life in God's hands while he waits for the Lord to bring justice.

Psalms 31:15

My times are in Your hands: To give up control of timing is one way to express submission.

Psalms 31:17

The psalmist, who did not deserve to be disgraced, invokes the principle of retribution (see study note on Psalm 1:6; see also "Prayers for Vengeance" Theme Note).

Psalms 31:19–20

The psalmist, who did not deserve to be disgraced, invokes the principle of retribution

Psalms 31:19–24

The psalmist thanks the Lord for answering his prayer and rescuing him (Psalm 31:1–18).

Psalms 31:21–22

Blessed be the LORD: The psalmist expresses his joy at the experience of God's goodness and love. Throughout his struggles, the Lord has cared for him.

Psalms 31:23–24

Out of his own pain and renewed awareness of the Lord's goodness, the psalmist turns to others who suffer. He holds out the promise of God's loving care for those who persevere in hoping for the Lord.

Psalms 32:1–2

The Lord's forgiveness brings people back into a relationship with him, removes their guilt, and gives them joy. Paul quoted this text when explaining justification by faith alone (Romans 4:4–8).

Psalms 32:1–11

This wisdom psalm of confession and thanks urges the godly to learn from the psalmist's journey through sin, denial, confession, and forgiveness. The early church used this psalm as one of the seven penitential psalms (psalms of repentance, see also Psalms 6, 38, 51, 102, 130, 143).

Psalms 32:3–5

The psalmist admits his sin (see Psalms 19:12–13; 25:7, 11, 15–22) and his resistance to confessing sin. The Lord pressed him hard until he confessed his guilt.

Psalms 32:4

The psalmist believes his suffering comes directly from the Lord's discipline (compare Psalms 38:2; 39:10).

Psalms 32:5

God has forgiven the guilt and rebellion mentioned in Psalm 32:1. The Lord's nature is to reconcile and forgive (Psalms 78:38; 85:2; 130:4), but he requires people to confess and repent.

Psalms 32:6

The godly will learn from the psalmist's experience to pray for forgiveness before it is too late.

Psalms 32:7

The Lord promises to be a safe place for his people (Psalm 31:20). Instead of feeling terrified (Psalm 31:13), the psalmist hears songs of victory all around.

Psalms 32:8

God interrupts the psalmist's teaching with a message inviting the godly to receive the Lord's wisdom (see Psalms 5:8; 23:3; 25:4–6).

Psalms 32:9

The foolish person lacks wisdom. Ignoring the Lord's advice harms life and makes a person like an animal (see Isaiah 1:3; James 3:3).

Psalms 32:10

Difficulties common to all of life will come to the wicked, whereas the Lord promises to protect the godly with his care.

Psalms 33:1–3

The psalmist urges the godly to praise the Lord with melodies, with a new song, and with skillfully-played music.

Psalms 33:1–22

This hymn of creation (see also Psalms 8, 19, 104, 145) might be a continuation of Psalm 32. It urges readers to praise God (Psalm 33:1–3), to recognize the power of his word in creation (33:4–7), and to respect the Creator (33:8–11). It gives hope to forgiven sinners (Psalm 32) that they can live a new life in the fear of the Lord and under divine protection.

Psalms 33:4–7

God's word shows his character and power.

Psalms 33:7

The nations surrounding Israel thought that the sea had divine power, but it is under God's control, within boundaries that he set (see Psalm 104:8–10).

Psalms 33:8

The power of the Lord extends to all the nations (see Psalm 22; 96:123).

Psalms 33:8–11

Fear of the Lord begins with awe for God and for his powerful word. His word created everything and continues to order and sustain creation. He frustrates the plans of people who oppose his will.

Psalms 33:10

The plans of powerful people will only succeed if God allows it (see Isaiah 8:9210).

Psalms 33:11

- God's word still orders creation and will do so forever.
- God's purposes are wonderful (Psalms 40:5; 92:5).

Psalms 33:12

People who fear God are chosen as his inheritance (see Psalm 33:13–19). This does not include rebellious people (Psalm 78:62).

Psalms 33:13–19

From the heavens, the Lord searches out and cares for anyone who fears him (see Psalm 14:2–3).

Psalms 33:16–17

army ...great strength. ... horse: Even military power is under God's control (see Psalm 33:10–11; Ecclesiastes 9:11).

Psalms 33:18

God watches over all who live by his counsel (Psalm 32:8). He protects, rescues, and stays close to them (Psalm 34:15–22).

Psalms 33:20–22

The faithful see God's power in creation and world events. They respond with trust, commitment, joy, and hope as they pray and wait for God's help.

Psalms 33:22

The psalmist uses wordplay to contrast his people's certain hope (Hebrew yakhal) in the Lord with the supposed strength (Hebrew khayil) of the wicked's horses.

Psalms 34:1

Abimelech is another name for Achish (see 1 Samuel 21:10–15). The body of the psalm makes no explicit connection to this event.

Psalms 34:1–3

The psalmist encourages those in need to join him in praise.

Psalms 34:1–22

This wisdom psalm includes a thanksgiving song of praise (Psalm 34:1–7) that celebrates the Lord for caring for and protecting godly sufferers. It also includes an invitation to wisdom (Psalm 34:8–14) and explains wisdom concerning the Lord's care for the needy and the suffering of the wicked (Psalm 34:15–22).

Psalms 34:5–6

The psalmist describes his experiences of answered prayer.

Psalms 34:7

The angel of the LORD showed God's presence during the journey through the wilderness. He protected Israel from Egypt's forces (Exodus 14:19–20), and he will guard all those who are godly (Psalm 91:11).

Psalms 34:8–14

The godly encourage everyone to seek wisdom, to fear the Lord, and to place themselves under the protection of the Lord's angel.

Psalms 34:9–10

Fear of the Lord includes reverence and respect, and it motivates a life of wisdom (see Proverbs 1:7; 9:10).

Psalms 34:11

Anyone who listens, even children, can become wise followers of God.

Psalms 34:11–13

Wisdom has three parts:

1. fearing the Lord (Psalm 34:11),
2. doing good (Psalm 34:14), and
3. rejecting evil (Psalm 34:13).

Psalms 34:12–16

Peter quotes this passage in his instructions for peaceful living (1 Peter 3:10–12).

Psalms 34:13

Godly people choose their words carefully. Speaking evil and telling lies is unwise (see Psalm 10:7; compare 17:1).

Psalms 34:14

The way of peace leads to harmony and order, whereas evil destroys them (see Psalm 37:11).

Psalms 34:15–16

The Lord distinguishes between wise and foolish people; he shows his concern for the wise by rescuing them from trouble (Psalm 34:15, 17–20). However, God destroys the foolish (Psalm 34:16, 21).

Psalms 34:18

Those who are brokenhearted have a spirit of deep sorrow for sin and a strong dependence on the Lord. God accepts this humble spirit as a proper sacrifice (Psalm 51:17). The wicked hate people who are brokenhearted (Psalm 109:16). But the Lord heals them and restores them (Psalm 147:3; see Isaiah 57:15; 61:1).

Psalms 34:19–22

The godly might suffer, but the Lord will reward them in the end. Similarly, the wicked might prosper for a time, but ultimately they will perish (Psalms 1:6; 34:15–16).

Psalms 34:20

- Bones represent a person's whole self (see Psalm 6:2).
- not one of them will be broken: John applied this statement to Jesus at the crucifixion (John 19:36).

Psalms 35:1–28

In this lament, the Lord's troubled servant asks God to notice his situation and defend him.

Psalms 35:4–10

The psalmist desires the Lord's salvation. The language may seem harsh, but it comes from a wish for justice and for the Lord to help the needy and oppressed.

Psalms 35:6

- A dark and slick path suggests instability and sudden disaster under the Lord's judgment (see Psalms 69:23; 73:18; 82:5; 107:10; 143:3).
- The angel of the LORD is an agent of judgment as well as salvation.

Psalms 35:10

Nothing in the universe can compare with the Lord (see Psalms 86:8; 89:6, 8; Isaiah 40:18, 25).

Psalms 35:11

False witnesses want nothing but violence (see Psalms 11:4–6; 54:3).

Psalms 35:11–18

The psalmist presents the Lord with the reasons for his suffering. Evil has many faces. He is tired and worn out, and he knows that only the Lord can help him.

Psalms 35:16

The psalmist's attackers gnashed their teeth to show their jealousy.

Psalms 35:19

John applied this claim of innocence (see also Psalm 69:4) to Jesus (John 15:25).

Psalms 35:19–25

In this prayer for justice, the psalmist faces a crisis so great that only the Lord can resolve it. The psalmist chooses the right path and believes that vengeance belongs to the Lord.

God's patience allows the wicked to continue in their evil ways. Because of this, their hearts grow harder and they find reasons to justify their behavior.

Psalms 35:21

Aha, aha!: This Hebrew word (he'akh) expresses a feeling of joy.

Psalms 35:26–28

The psalmist calls on the Lord to judge the wicked and to rescue the godly and bring them joy.

Psalms 36:1

no fear of God: Paul uses this phrase to describe how all people are morally corrupt (Romans 3:18).

Psalms 36:1–4

Foolish people reject wisdom and goodness while they chase after evil.

Psalms 36:1–12

This lament contrasts the foolish world made by the wicked with the wise world created and maintained by the Lord. The wicked care only about themselves, while the Lord cares for all creation. He will step in to bring justice to his world. The righteous will enjoy his protection, but the wicked will die.

Psalms 36:5–6

God's all-encompassing goodness surpasses that of the created order. God graciously meets his people's practical needs.

Psalms 36:5–9

As the source of wisdom, the Lord is reliable and incomparable. His faithful care extends to all parts of the created order.

Psalms 36:6–9

All creatures live by God's grace (1 Timothy 4:10).

Psalms 36:7–8

God invites everyone to a feast in his house (compare Proverbs 9:1–6).

Psalms 36:9

Light represents salvation and celebration (Psalms 18:25–29; 27:1; compare Psalm 35:6).

Psalms 36:10–11

God's wisdom covers all of creation and protects those who follow him.

Psalms 36:12

The psalmist is sure that the chaos caused by the wicked (Psalm 36:1–4) will stop when they die.

Psalms 37:1

envy: The jealous desire to have what others enjoy leads to further sin (Psalm 73:3; Proverbs 3:31; James 1:14–15; 4:1–2).

Psalms 37:1–9

The wise respond to evil by trusting in the Lord. Trust has five parts:

1. Do not become irritated or jealous of those who do evil (Psalm 37:1–2).
2. Delight in the Lord (Psalm 37:3–4).
3. Submit to the Lord (Psalm 37:5–6).
4. Practice patience in hope (Psalm 37:7).
5. Avoid anger (Psalm 37:8–9).

Psalms 37:1–40

This psalm addresses the issues raised in Psalm 36:

- How should the godly react to evil?
- When will the Lord bring justice?
- Why does he allow the wicked to harm his creation?

Psalm 37 provides clear answers that reduce the tensions of life (Psalm 37:1–9, 34) and promise that the meek will have a future (Psalm 37:10–11, 39–40).

The contrast between the godly and the wicked highlights the uselessness of foolishness (Psalm 37:12–24, 27–33). The psalmist's personal insights add a human element (Psalm 37:25–26, 35–38). He encourages viewing the land's inheritance with a long-term perspective: The earth belongs to the Lord, who will give it to those he blesses—the humble and godly who trust, hope, and follow him (see Psalm 37:9, 11, 22, 29, 34; see also Isaiah 57:13; Matthew 5:5).

Psalms 37:2

Human life is limited and does not last long (see Psalms 90:5–6; 92:7; 102:4, 11; 103:15; 129:6; Isaiah 40:7–8).

Psalms 37:3

Doing good means developing a commitment to wisdom (see Psalm 34:14; Proverbs 3:5–7).

Psalms 37:3–4

Trusting in the Lord helps reduce irritability and envy (Psalm 37:1).

Psalms 37:4

To delight in the Lord means to follow the Lord's ways and find joy in him.

Psalms 37:6

Justice occurs when the Lord's will triumphs and the godly experience his rescue (Isaiah 45:8; 51:5–6; 58:8, 10–11).

Psalms 37:7

Be still: We should let the Lord be God rather than taking matters into our own hands.

Psalms 37:8

Irritability and anger can quickly damage a person's character.

When someone becomes easily upset or angry, it affects the way that person thinks and acts. Over time, this can weaken good habits and harm relationships.

Learning patience and self-control helps protect and strengthen character.

Psalms 37:9–11

The wicked will not possess the land; those who trust in the Lord will. The Lord promises an inheritance because he is committed to caring for his people.

Psalms 37:11

The Lord creates peace (Psalm 85:10)—he brings peace to a chaotic world (Psalm 29:11; 37:11; 85:8; 147:14). His wisdom leads the meek to peace (Psalm 119:165; Matthew 5:5).

Psalms 37:12–13

The wicked show their envy by gnashing their teeth (an expression of anger and hostility). They make plans to harm the godly. But the Lord laughs at them because he knows they will fail (Psalm 2:4).

Psalms 37:12–17

The wicked seek to destroy the Lord's order, but he defeats them.

Psalms 37:14–15

The wicked prepare weapons, but those weapons will turn against them (compare Psalm 7:12–13).

Psalms 37:16

It is better to be wise with little money than to be rich and evil (Proverbs 15:16; 16:8, 19; 17:1; 28:6).

Psalms 37:18–20

The Lord cares for the blameless in this life and for eternity, but the wicked will perish.

Psalms 37:20

Smoke represents the temporary nature of life (Psalm 68:2; 102:3).

Psalms 37:21

- To borrow and never repay shows a dishonest way of life.
- Generous givers freely share what they freely receive from the Lord (see Psalm 111:5; 112:5).

Psalms 37:23–24

The honesty and strength of a godly person's life come from the Lord (see Proverbs 4:12; 14:15; 16:9; 20:24).

Psalms 37:25–26

The Lord does not abandon his children or their descendants.

Psalms 37:27–33

The godly are wise; they do good and reject evil. The Lord cares for them, protecting them and ensuring that they receive their rightful portion of the land as their inheritance. The wicked might try to ambush the godly, but they will not succeed.

Psalms 37:30

The righteous base their counsel on the Lord's wisdom.

Psalms 37:31

The law of his God is in his heart: The godly accept God's instruction and live by it (see Psalm 119:11; Jeremiah 24:7; 31:31–34).

Psalms 37:35–36

The wicked might appear to be flourishing like a tree (compare Psalm 52:8; 92:12–13), but they eventually die and are forgotten (Psalm 37:2).

Psalms 37:39–40

The Lord provides strength for his people.

Psalms 38:1

The meaning of this phrase is uncertain (also in 70:1).

Psalms 38:1–4

The psalmist's sins brought the Lord's anger and rage. Because of this, the Lord disciplined and rebuked him, like arrows and blows striking him. As a result, his whole body is sick.

Psalms 38:1–17

These verses introduce the psalmist's confession (Psalm 38:18) and describe his miserable state.

Psalms 38:1–22

This psalm is a lament and a prayer for healing. The psalmist's suffering is linked to his unconfessed sin. He admits his sin and trusts the Lord with his situation.

Psalms 38:3

Sin can lead to sickness and even death (1 Corinthians 11:30). The psalmist may have felt physically ill, or his sickness was a metaphor for emotional distress. He understood it came from God and endangered his life (see Psalms 32:3; 39:10).

Psalms 38:4

The psalmist feels burdened because of sin (see Psalms 40:12; 41:4; compare Genesis 4:13).

Psalms 38:5–8

The severity of God's punishment brings anguish that affects every part of the psalmist's being.

Psalms 38:9–12

The psalmist wants to reconnect with God but feels distant. He feels lost and alone as his friends leave him.

Psalms 38:13

The psalmist suffers quietly before his opponents (see Isaiah 53:7).

Psalms 38:15

The Lord alone will resolve the conflict (Psalms 9:18; 27:14; 37:9, 34).

Psalms 38:17–20

The psalmist, unable to bear his suffering and close to collapse (compare Psalm 15:5), admits his sin (see Psalm 32:5).

Psalms 38:19

The psalmist feels more pain because his enemies hate him for no reason.

Psalms 38:22

In the Psalms, people often ask the Lord to act quickly in times of great need (Psalms 22:19; 31:2; 40:13; 69:17; 70:1; 71:12; 79:8; 102:2; 141:1; 143:7). However, wisdom and experience show that God's people often need to wait for him to act (Psalms 27:14; 37:7; Isaiah 8:17; 40:31).

Psalms 39:1

Jeduthun was a Levitical singer who was appointed by David, along with Asaph (1 Chronicles 9:16; 16:38; 25:1).

Psalms 39:1–3

Suffering in silence makes the psalmist's anguish, pain, and inner distress worse.

Psalms 39:1–13

This prayer for rescue shows the psalmist's discouragement, which comes from not fully understanding his situation.

Psalms 39:4–5

how fleeting my life is: This perspective comes out of suffering (see Psalms 78:39; 89:47–48; 90:3–10). The human lifetime is but a moment to God (Psalm 90:4), as temporary as a breath (see Psalms 39:11; 144:4).

Psalms 39:4–6

Due to his suffering and sin, the psalmist concludes that life is meaningless and short (see Job 7:7–10; Isaiah 40:6–8). He had expected only a wicked life to be like that (see Psalms 37:2, 20; 103:15–16), but now it seems irrelevant whether a person is godly or not.

Psalms 39:8

The idea that rebellion leads to suffering is a common theme in Psalms 32, 38–41.

Psalms 39:9–11

The psalmist links suffering with God's discipline, assuming that it is punishment for his sin.

Psalms 39:11

The Lord uses discipline to correct his children (Psalms 38:1, 3, 7; 40:12; see Proverbs 3:11–12; Hebrews 12:5–6).

Psalms 39:12

A foreigner could not own land (see Leviticus 25:23). The patriarchs had lived as guests in Canaan (Psalm 105:23).

Psalms 39:13

Earlier, the psalmist asked God to stay close to him (Psalm 8:21–22). Now, he wants God to leave him alone. This is similar to how Job felt (Job 7:17–19).

Psalms 40:1–5

The psalmist thanks the Lord for rescue and affirms that people can trust God.

Psalms 40:1–17

This psalm has a thanksgiving song (Psalm 40:1–10) and a lament (40:11–17). The thanksgiving song explains why the psalmist is thankful (Psalm 40:1–5), shows a promise to stay committed (40:6–8), and shares a public testimony about God's character (40:7–10). The lament talks about the psalmist's troubles due to his sins (Psalm 40:11–12) and includes two prayers asking for justice (40:13–15, 17).

Psalms 40:6

- The Lord delights in the attitude and character of the person giving an offering more than the offering itself.
- my ears You have opened: The Greek text reads You have given me a body. In Hebrews 10:5–7, the writer quotes from the Greek version of Psalm 40:6–8. He presents these words as something Jesus said when he left heaven and came into the world.

Psalms 40:7

it is written about me in the scroll: Moses had recorded God's requirements for Israel's kings in Deuteronomy 17:14–15.

Psalms 40:11

The psalmist prays that the Lord will be true to his character when answering this plea for mercy.

Psalms 40:12–17

- The psalmist is troubled by both his adversities and his own sins and prays for rescue.
- This passage is almost the same as Psalm 70.

Psalms 41:1

The poor who suffer hardship have special protection under God's law (Leviticus 14:21; 19:10). They receive God's justice and guidance (Psalms 72:13; 82:3–4). The word translated as poor often means the godly (Psalm 113:7; see Zephaniah 3:12).

Psalms 41:1–13

In this wisdom psalm, the psalmist:

- asks for healing (Psalm 41:4, 10),
- laments his distress (Psalm 41:5–9), and
- expresses confidence in the Lord's blessing (Psalm 41:1–3, 11–12).

Psalms 41:3

on his bed of illness: This illness might be physical or spiritual (see Psalm 6:2; Psalm 38).

Psalms 41:4

The psalmist applies the blessing to himself (Psalm 41:12). He has helped the poor (Psalm 41:1), but he has sinned against the Lord in other ways. In his pain, he asks for healing and admits his sin. Only the Lord can provide the restoration that brings true joy (Psalm 30:2; 107:20–21).

Psalms 41:5

When will he die: The psalmist's enemies see his suffering as a judgment from God (see Psalm 1:6).

Psalms 41:5–9

The psalmist's enemies disguise themselves as friends, while his friends openly become his enemies.

Psalms 41:9

the one who shared my bread: Eating together was a sign of unity (Acts 2:42). Refusing to eat with someone was a sign of hostility (1 Corinthians 5:11). Jesus experienced the same kind of betrayal (John 13:1, 18).

Psalms 41:11–12

The psalmist knows that the Lord has forgiven him and will bless him.

Psalms 41:13

This doxology (song of praise) ends Book One (Psalms 1–41). Compare with Psalm 106:48.

Psalms 42:1

The sons of Korah were members of a Levitical choir. They were chosen by David to serve as singers in the temple (see 1 Chronicles 6:22–38; 9:19–34; 2 Chronicles 20:19). Their ancestor Korah was the rebel who opposed Moses and was swallowed by the earth (Exodus 6:24; Numbers 16).

Psalms 42:1–4

- The psalmist's deep desire for God arises from being far away from the temple as he remembers the past.
- The verb translated as "longs" appears only here and in Joel 1:20 (meaning "cry out"). In both instances, it describes extreme thirst in a dry desert (see Psalms 63:1; 143:6; see also 84:2).

Psalms 42:1–43.5

These psalms, like Psalms 9 and 10, form a unit with a lament and a bittersweet refrain of hope (Psalm 42:5, 11; 43:5). Many Hebrew manuscripts combine these two psalms into one.

The historical context is unclear; these psalms might represent God's people in exile, expressing loyalty to God while he punishes them for their ongoing disobedience.

The psalmist longs for the fellowship with God he had in Jerusalem (Psalm 42:4); his memories only deepen his discouragement. As the psalmist cries out to God, he remembers God's love and faithfulness (Psalm 42:8), which leads him to ask for vindication (43:1–4).

Psalms 42:3

- Crying so much that tears become food shows deep sadness (Psalms 80:5; 102:9; see 6:6; 56:8; 119:136; 126:5).
- The wicked try to impose their timing on God and deny his power to intervene.

Psalms 42:4

The psalmist remembers leading a large procession as part of the Levitical choir, possibly during the important holy days.

Psalms 42:5

The psalmist feels sad, but he can still function. He remembers that the living God is his Savior. This verse appears again in Psalms 42:11 and 43:5.

Psalms 42:5–6

The psalmist encourages himself with questions and answers.

Psalms 42:6

- Mount Hermon is a high mountain range northeast of Israel. The source of the Jordan is by Dan at the foot of Mount Hermon.
- Mount Mizar might be a peak in the Mount Hermon range.

Psalms 42:7

The raging seas, waves, and surging tides bring to mind God's anger (see Psalm 88:7).

Psalms 42:8

The psalmist sees rays of hope. A life focused on God includes joyful songs and prayers for justice and vindication (Psalm 42:9–10; 43:1–4).

Psalms 42:9–10

The psalmist brings his many doubts, discouragements, and questions directly to God.

Psalms 43:1–4

The psalmist turns to the Lord for rescue from his troubles, for guidance, for restoration, and for vindication.

Psalms 43:2

rejected me: Other psalms also ask if God has rejected his people (Psalm 44:9, 23; 60:1, 10; 74:1; 77:7; 88:14; 89:38; 108:11).

Psalms 43:3

- This prayer for God's redemption sees light and truth as guides (see Psalms 18:25–29; 27:1; 85:10–13; 89:14–18; see also 119:105; John 3:19; Ephesians 5:8; 1 Thessalonians 5:5–7).
- The temple on the mountain in Jerusalem symbolized God's holy presence among his people (Psalms 15:1; 43:3; 99:5, 9; 132:7).

Psalms 43:5

This verse is repeated in Psalm 42:5 and 11.

Psalms 44:1

We have heard ... the work You did: The story of redemption includes God's favor and power in his past acts of rescue (see Psalm 78:1–4; see also Psalms 105–106).

Psalms 44:1–26

This national lament after a defeat in battle continues the tone of the previous two psalms. It reflects on an unspecified moment in Israel's history and calls on God for salvation. The people:

- recite God's past acts of rescue (Psalm 44:1–3),
- recognize God's power to save (Psalm 44:4–8),
- describe their humiliation in exile (Psalm 44:9–16),
- claim their innocence and lament the injustice of their current situation (Psalm 44:17–22), and
- cry for vindication (Psalm 44:23–26).

Psalms 44:2

God drove out the pagan nations during the conquests recorded in Joshua.

Psalms 44:3

Though the Israelites used swords and other weapons (Psalm 44:6), they would have lost their battles without the light of the Lord's favor (see Psalms 18:25–29; 27:1; 89:15).

Psalms 44:4–8

God's people feel confident about his mighty acts; he was with them in the past, and he is their king in the present.

Psalms 44:9–16

The people have experienced defeat (Psalm 44:9–12), so they understand suffering and shame (44:13–16).

Psalms 44:11

scattered us among the nations: This likely refers to the exile (see Psalms 51:18–19; 89:38–51; 106:40–47; 137).

Psalms 44:22

Paul quotes this verse as a parenthetical aside in his list of things that cannot separate us from Christ's love (Romans 8:36).

Psalms 44:23

Wake up: Biblical authors often call for God's attention in a crisis (Psalms 35:23; 44:23; 73:20; 80:2; Mark 4:38).

Psalms 44:23–26

In the end, God's people can turn to the Lord and trust him for rescue. Their petition for God to remedy their situation is as strong as their lament about God's rejection.

Psalms 45:1

To the tune of "The Lilies" is no longer known (see also Psalm 69).

Psalms 45:1–17

This psalm celebrates a royal wedding; it might have been sung on many occasions and not just at one wedding. As God's representative, the king carried the responsibility of dispensing justice and maintaining order in God's world (see Psalm 2).

Psalms 45:2

This general description of the king's symbolic status anticipates his enduring legacy (Psalm 45:16). The Lord's blessing and the charge to reflect God's attributes are symbolized by his handsome appearance and gracious speech.

Psalms 45:3

Glory and majesty belong to the Lord (Psalms 96:6; 111:3).

Psalms 45:3–5

The psalmist describes the royal splendor the king showed when fighting his enemies.

Psalms 45:4

As God's representative of truth, humility, and justice (see Psalm 72:1–2, 4, 7), the king can perform impressive deeds (65:5; 96:4).

Psalms 45:6

Justice characterizes God's rule, as it should characterize the king's administration.

Psalms 45:6–9

- The king is like a god among humans. God anointed him, gave him a powerful throne, and he delivers justice as he rules eternally.
- The writer of Hebrews uses Psalm 45:6–7 to describe Jesus, arguing that the Son is greater than the angels (Hebrews 1:8–9).

Psalms 45:8

- Fine spices mixed with oil create unique perfumes.
- The king's palaces had wood panels with ivory inlays (see Psalm 6:4; Amos 3:15).

Psalms 45:9

Royal marriages often confirmed diplomatic alliances between kings, and the women became part of the royal harem (see 1 Kings 11:1–3).

Psalms 45:10–12

The bride is a representative of the king. Powerful people and nations try to gain her favor in order to get close to the king. This is a great honor, and she is encouraged to give herself fully to her new position.

Psalms 45:12

The Daughter of Tyre: Israel traded with Tyre, a powerful city-state. The city's most noble woman brings a wedding gift to the new queen, who represents an honored kingdom.

Psalms 46:1

According to Alamoth ("maidens"; see also study note on 1 Chronicles 15:20). In worship, a choir or a group of instrumentalists performed this hymn.

Psalms 46:1–3

Even during natural disasters, the citizens of Zion show no fear.

Psalms 46:1–11

This psalm of Zion celebrates God's special presence in Jerusalem (see also Psalms 48, 76, 87, 122). It encourages trust in the Lord because the people of Zion have his protection.

Psalms 46:4

This river provides life, renewal, and healing like the streams flowing through Eden (Psalm 36:8–9; see Genesis 2:10; Ezekiel 47; Revelation 22:2).

Psalms 46:4–6

The strong city, where God lives, protects its people. They enjoy the river flowing within the city. This river is calm, unlike the turbulent waters (representing the powers of the nations) outside the city.

Psalms 46:5

when morning dawns: In the ancient Near East, enemies attacked cities during the day. Even in dangerous times, the Lord will protect the place where his name is.

Psalms 46:6

People and nations live in chaos. They take every chance to benefit themselves (Psalm 83:2), stay busy with many things (39:6), and fill the world with noise. They are unstable and can fall apart, unlike the city of God (compare Psalm 15:5). But when the godly are troubled, they cry out to God for help (Psalm 42:5, 11; 43:5; 55:17).

Psalms 46:7

- This refrain reminds us who the God of Zion is.
- with us: Hebrew 'immanu, part of the name Immanuel, meaning "God with us" (Isaiah 7:14; 8:8; Matthew 1:23).

Psalms 46:8

Israel witnessed the Lord's amazing works in the wilderness (Psalms 107:24; 111:2), but the wicked, who do not care about them (28:5), end up desolate (73:19).

Psalms 46:8–9

This invitation to trust in the Lord offers a perspective on God's interactions with human powers.

Psalms 46:10

- A message directly from the Lord confirms the truth of the psalmist's vision (see also Psalms 12:5–6; 32:8).
- know that I am God: The Lord will fulfill his promises (Isaiah 45:3; 49:23; 60:16).

- God will be honored (Psalm 47; Isaiah 6:1); he will judge the nations and save his people (see Psalms 57:11; 89:13; 108:5–6; 118:16).

Psalms 47:1

People clap their hands in praise and recognition of wonderful deeds (Psalm 47:3–4; see 98:8; Isaiah 55:12; compare Nahum 3:19).

Psalms 47:1–2

As the ruler of all nations, God deserves praise.

Psalms 47:1–9

This psalm praises God's rule as king over the entire earth. It describes God's victory with Israel and other nations. Both Israel (Psalm 47:3–4) and the nations (47:9) are part of God's kingdom.

Psalms 47:3–4

The Lord gave Israel victory, especially under David (see Psalm 18:40–50). God's powerful acts of redemption show his love for Israel.

Psalms 47:4

- pride of Jacob: Jacob was the father of all Israelites (Genesis 32:28). The name Jacob often represents the nation of Israel.
- God loves and commits himself to Jacob (see Psalms 78:68; 127:2; see Romans 11:28).

Psalms 47:5

horn: Or rams' horns (see Psalm 81:3). People sometimes blew rams' horns during celebrations (Psalm 98:5–6; 2 Kings 11:14; 1 Chronicles 15:28).

Psalms 47:5–6

The psalmist describes the Lord as returning to heaven, having accomplished his victories. For a description of his descent, see Psalm 18:9–16.

Psalms 47:7

People from all over the world (see Psalm 96:1–3) will worship God.

Psalms 48:1–14

This song of Zion (see also Psalms 46, 76, 87, 122) clearly describes Jerusalem (Zion) as the city of the Great King, where the godly find protection (48:1–3). God rules from Zion with faithfulness, righteousness, and justice, inspiring his people with confidence and joy (Psalm 48:9–11). They dedicate themselves to witnessing Zion's glory so they can share it with the next generation (Psalm 48:8, 12–14).

Psalms 48:3

God lives in Zion to protect it from all enemies (see Psalm 46:5).

Psalms 48:7

The ships of Tarshish were built for long voyages and represent human achievement (see also 2 Chronicles 9:21; Isaiah 2:16). Their destruction might be the event mentioned in 1 Kings 22:48.

Psalms 48:9–11

The psalmist happily celebrates the Lord's presence with the community, thinking about God's faithful, righteous, and just rule.

Psalms 48:12–13

towers ... ramparts ... citadel: These structures show Zion's strength.

Psalms 48:14

No one is like God (Psalms 35:10; 71:19; 86:8; 89:6, 8; 113:5; see Isaiah 40:18, 25). He is the shepherd King (Psalm 95:7) who will guide (see 5:8; 23:2) the sheep of his flock (77:20).

Psalms 49:1–2

Anyone who will listen can gain wisdom (Proverbs 1:5, 8, 33).

Psalms 49:1–4

The wisdom teacher invites everyone to come and learn wisdom. He promises to teach them through a proverb and a riddle.

Psalms 49:1–20

In this wisdom psalm, a wise teacher warns about enemies who live richly and care only for themselves (Psalm 49:5–9). They cannot save anyone, not even themselves, from death or being forgotten (Psalm 49:10–12). Like fattened animals, they are led to slaughter (Psalm 49:14–20).

Psalms 49:4

The teacher used proverbs and riddles to teach wisdom (see Proverbs 1:5–6).

Psalms 49:5–8

If enemies who live for material rewards cannot sustain themselves, how can they give life to others?

Psalms 49:11–12

The teacher uses irony to teach wisdom. Everyone dies, and even those who give their names to lands or estates will be forgotten.

Psalms 49:13–15

The teachers of false wisdom cannot rescue themselves from death. Only God has that power.

Psalms 49:16–20

The wicked might have rich, luxurious lives, but they forget that they cannot avoid death.

Psalms 50:1–3

The whole universe must pay attention when God approaches to bring justice into the world.

Psalms 50:1–23

God appears as judge. He reminds both the godly and the ungodly that sacrifices and reciting the law are worthless without thankfulness, repentance, and justice.

Psalms 50:4–6

The Lord is coming to bring justice. This hope encourages his faithful people. However, those who have been unfaithful will not receive blessings when the heavens and earth testify against them (see Deuteronomy 30:19; 31:28; 32:1; Isaiah 1:2). The Lord comes to restore order to the world (see Psalms 5:8; 22:31; 33:5; 40:9; 50:6; 71:16; 97:6).

Psalms 50:7–13

The psalmist warns against valuing sacrificial rituals more than having the right attitude in your heart.

Psalms 50:9

Unlike pagan gods, God does not need food. Instead, he wants his people to serve him with sincere hearts (Psalm 50:14–15).

Psalms 50:10

the cattle on a thousand hills: God has no needs because he owns everything.

Psalms 50:14

- Thankfulness involves recognizing and appreciating God's blessings beyond personal gain (see Psalms 51:15–17; 54:6).
- True sacrifice means dedicating oneself to honor God (Psalm 50:23; Romans 12:1–2).

Psalms 50:15

God's response to his people's cry is to rescue them.

Psalms 50:16–21

This message is against the wicked, who only pretend to listen to God.

Psalms 50:17

My instruction ... My words: The wicked may observe rituals, but they reject more important matters such as justice, mercy, and faithfulness (compare Matthew 23:23–24).

Psalms 50:21

Because he is patient, God remained silent.

Psalms 50:22

God will destroy the wicked like a lion tearing its prey (Isaiah 5:29; 31:4; Ezekiel 19:3; compare Psalms 7:2; 22:13).

Psalms 50:22–23

The wicked will experience God's justice, while the godly will see God's everlasting salvation.

Psalms 51:1

A prayer for God's mercy and kindness is a type of lament. Sometimes, the psalmist asks for mercy because he recognizes his own weakness and sin (see also Psalm 6:2; 9:13; 25:16; 31:9; 41:4, 10). Other times, the plea comes from the psalmist's dedication to the Lord (see Psalm 26:11; 27:7; 119:29, 58, 132). In every situation, God's mercy leads to inner renewal.

Psalms 51:1–2

The person who regrets their wrongdoing cannot offer anything to God. They need God's favor, mercy, forgiveness, and blessing to experience renewal and restoration.

Psalms 51:1–19

This heartfelt prayer for restoration seeks God's favor, mercy, forgiveness, and cleansing. With a broken spirit, the psalmist admits his sin and takes respon-

sibility (Psalm 51:3–6). He then asks God to remove his guilt and renew him internally (Psalm 51:7–12). The psalmist commits again to living wisely and joyfully while serving God and others (Psalm 51:13–17).

Psalms 51:title

See 2 Samuel 11:1–27. The psalm does not directly mention this event.

Psalms 51:1–65.13

These psalms of David share a common theme. They reflect on the experience of evil. In Psalm 51, the psalmist admits his wrongdoing and asks for God's forgiveness. Psalms 52–64 express sorrow over specific evils David faced. A song of praise (Psalm 65) brings David's laments to an end.

Psalms 51:2

Wash me ... cleanse me: The psalmist asks for cleansing and freedom from the guilt of his sin (Psalm 51:7; see 26:6; Isaiah 1:16, 18; 4:4).

Psalms 51:3–6

The psalmist accepts the results of his sin against God. He understands that he has no goodness without God's renewal.

Psalms 51:4

Against You, You only: This is an exaggeration. The psalmist knows he also sinned against people (2 Samuel 11:2–4, 15–17), but his sin against God is more important. He expects God to rebuke him and will accept whatever verdict God gives (see Romans 3:4).

Psalms 51:5

I was brought forth in iniquity: The psalmist is not making excuses but is admitting how deep his sinfulness is. From the time we are conceived, we all share in the human condition of sinfulness.

Psalms 51:7

Purify me with hyssop (literally Purify me with the hyssop branch; see Exodus 12:22; Leviticus 14:4; John 19:29; Hebrews 9:19): The psalmist relies on God to cleanse and renew him (see Isaiah 1:18).

Psalms 51:8

- Regaining joy is a gracious gift from God.
- You have crushed: The psalmist feels completely broken (Psalm 6:2; compare 34:20).

Psalms 51:10

A loyal spirit produces inner strength. It helps a person remain faithful and continue even during difficulty.

Psalms 51:10–12

God's Spirit renews and recreates the human spirit.

Psalms 51:11

Your Holy Spirit: Only the Holy Spirit can change a person's will to make it "right" (Psalm 51:10) and "willing" to obey (51:12).

Psalms 51:13

As he learns from his sin and its consequences, the psalmist wants to teach others.

Psalms 51:14

bloodguilt: This expression refers to any injustice, not only killing someone (Psalm 9:12; 58:10; see 2 Samuel 11:14–26; compare Isaiah 1:15–17).

Psalms 51:18–19

build up the walls of Jerusalem: These verses were likely added as a prayer for national restoration after the exile (see Psalms 42–43). The entire community in exile shared the feelings expressed in this psalm.

Psalms 51:19

Sacrifices made with the right intentions come from a heart that is right with God and others (see Psalms 15:2–5; 24:3–6; 50:14; Matthew 5:23–24).

Psalms 52:1

The accuser, Doeg the Edomite, is an example of a person who chose to do evil.

Psalms 52:1–4

Liars deceive themselves by thinking they can be heroes with their words. They see themselves as innocent, even though they love evil and cause harm. Those who speak curses, sarcasm, bitterness, arrogant boasting, and lies (Psalms 31:18; 34:13; 59:7, 12; 120:2–3; 140:3, 9) create chaos, isolation, and destruction (James 3:5). Their sharp words cut like swords and daggers (Psalms 55:21; 57:4; 64:3), the fangs of a snake (140:3), or a razor.

Psalms 52:1–9

Wicked people use words to destroy relationships and communities. They foolishly think that they can be heroes by their words (Psalm 52:1–4), but their downfall

comes suddenly (52:5–7). In contrast, the godly renew their commitment to the Lord (Psalm 52:8–9) and find security in their future with him.

Psalms 52:3

Dishonest speech can change a person's character.

Psalms 52:5

God will strike the wicked down like a pagan altar, idol, or unclean vessel (Exodus 34:13; Leviticus 11:35; 2 Kings 10:27).

Psalms 52:5–7

God's judgment on the wicked will come suddenly and forcibly. The godly rejoice in God's justice, not in the misfortunes of the wicked.

Psalms 52:6

see and fear: In Hebrew, these words sound almost alike.

Psalms 52:8–9

- The psalmist commits himself to a life of trust in the Lord.
- An olive tree can live a long time with proper care (Psalms 1:3; 128:3). The psalmist wants to be near the Lord, who is his Savior and the source of his blessings (Psalms 18:6; 23:6).

Psalms 53:1–3

Paul uses the Greek translation of this passage to describe the moral corruption of all people (Romans 3:10–12).

Psalms 53:1–6

This psalm is similar to Psalm 14, with differences only in verse 5.

Psalms 53:5

scattered the bones: Israel's enemies would face a shameful defeat and would not have the peaceful rest of a proper burial (compare Psalm 141:7; 2 Kings 9:10; Jeremiah 8:1–2; Ezekiel 6:5).

Psalms 54:1

The Ziphites intended to use violence.

Psalms 54:1–7

This personal lament was caused by violent and godless people (Psalm 54:3). The psalmist prays to God and focuses on God's help (54:4). He asks God to save him from evil and judge his enemies (Psalm 54:5, 7).

Psalms 54:3

- The strangers were excluded from the covenant community (see Psalm 109:11; Proverbs 5:10).
- Proud and violent people do not respect God or others (see Psalms 35:11, 25; 86:14; Proverbs 11:16).

Psalms 54:6

A voluntary offering is a sacrifice of praise. Sacrifices of praise are the kind of offering God most desires (see Psalm 50:14–15, 23).

Psalms 54:6–7

In anticipation of God's response, the mood of the psalm changes from sorrow to thanksgiving.

Psalms 55:1–3

The occasion for this prayer is an attack by an enemy.

Psalms 55:1–23

The psalmist faces enemies led by a former friend (Psalm 55:12–14). This causes him great distress. He prays to the Lord and trusts him for justice (Psalm 55:22–23).

Jesus went through similar pain when Judas, his friend, betrayed him. He also experienced the psalmist's prayer being answered:

1. by taking the place of the wicked and receiving their punishment (Isaiah 53:7–9), and
2. by trusting the Father, who saved (Luke 23:46) and rewarded him (Isaiah 53:10–12).

Psalms 55:4–8

In the experience of deep anguish, the psalmist confesses that his adversity has become unbearable and he seeks an escape.

Psalms 55:12–20

The psalmist's enemy used to be a friend. Remembering their close relationship causes him pain (see Psalm 31:11).

Psalms 55:19–21

God is good and faithful, but the psalmist's enemies and so-called friend are deceitful and wicked.

Psalms 55:22–23

The psalmist commits all his cares to the Lord.

Psalms 55:23

To die young means missing out on God's full blessings (compare Proverbs 3:2, 16).

Psalms 56:1

- A Miktam: This may be a literary or musical term.
- David was seized by Philistines concerned about his loyalties and brought before King Achish (1 Samuel 21:10–15).

Psalms 56:1–13

In this lament, the psalmist first asks for help and then expresses confidence in God. This pattern occurs two times (Psalm 56:1–4, 5–13).

Psalms 56:4

man: Or mere flesh, in contrast to God, who is immortal and much more powerful (see Isaiah 2:22).

Psalms 56:5–7

The psalmist specifies his charge against his attackers as he prays for their evil to end.

Psalms 56:8

The psalmist uses wordplay with two similar Hebrew words: wanderings (nod) and bottle (no'd).

Psalms 56:11

man (Hebrew 'adam): The psalm also uses two other words for man:

- 'enosh (meaning "people," Psalm 56:1) and
- basar (meaning "mere mortals," Psalm 56:4).

All these words point to the short and limited nature of human life.

Psalms 56:13

The light of God's goodness and salvation will replace the darkness of death (see Psalms 18:25–29; 27:1).

Psalms 57:1

shadow of Your wings: Like a bird protects its young, God protects those who trust in him (see Psalm 17:8).

Psalms 57:1–11

The psalmist asks for mercy and protection, then expresses trust and confidence in the Lord (Psalm 57:1–4). When the wicked fall into their own traps (Psalm 57:6), the psalmist will praise the Lord (57:7–10).

Psalms 57:title

See 1 Samuel 22:1 or Psalm 24:1–8.

Psalms 57:2

- God Most High (Hebrew Elohim-Elyon) is a common title for God. He is more powerful than all real or imagined supernatural beings (see Psalms 91:1; 97:9; Genesis 14:18–22).
- who fulfills His purpose for me: Or who will end my [trouble], or who deals kindly with me.

Psalms 57:3–4

These verses are a prayer for rescue from strong enemies. The metaphor of fierce lions describes human foes. The psalmist feels unable to escape them without God's help (see also Psalms 35:11–21; 124:6).

Psalms 57:5

- This verse appears again in Psalm 57:11 and 108:5.
- God's glory, which is his visible presence that keeps out all evil (Psalm 8:1; 19:1–4; 24:7), will fill the entire creation (Isaiah 6:3).

Psalms 57:7–8

The psalmist is sure that God will stop the night of evil (compare Psalm 56:13).

Psalms 57:7–11

This section is repeated with a few changes in Psalm 108:1–5.

Psalms 57:10–11

God's glory reaches the entire universe, and people will praise his constant love and faithfulness.

Psalms 58:1

rulers (or gods): People used this term for high officials and administrators of justice (Psalm 82:1, 6). In other contexts, it might refer to angelic creatures (Psalm 89:7) or the gods of other nations (82:1; Daniel 11:36).

Psalms 58:1–5

The administrators of justice were furthering their own interests rather than those of the needy. The absence of justice gradually resulted in a violent society.

Psalms 58:1–11

The administration of justice is a mark of good government. God expects nothing less from his people. The psalmist condemns Israel's leaders for abusing their power, and he calls on the Lord to rain down his curses

upon the wicked. The demonstration of divine justice will reassure the godly that God is just.

Psalms 58:3

All humans are born with a tendency to sin (see Psalm 51:5). However, the wicked follow their sinful desires, while the godly struggle against them (Romans 7:19–23; James 4:1–10).

Psalms 58:4

Venom here means harmful speech (see Psalm 140:3).

Psalms 58:6

The psalmist calls on God to break the destructive power of the wicked.

Psalms 58:8

When moving over dry ground, slugs dry up.

Psalms 58:9–10

God's judgment will come suddenly. The certainty of vindication brings joy to the godly.

Psalms 58:11

Being shown to be right is the reward for those who live for God.

Psalms 59:1

See 1 Samuel 19:11–18.

Psalms 59:1–2

protect me (or lift me up high): When surrounded by evil, the godly pray for God to set them apart for himself and protect them.

Psalms 59:1–17

The psalmist laments the power of enemies who conspire with other nations.

Psalms 59:4–5

The psalmist asks God not to show mercy to the treacherous, deceptive, and wicked traitors (see Psalm 25:2).

Psalms 59:6–8

The wicked threaten like aggressive dogs, but the Lord shows that he does not fear them.

Psalms 59:11–13

The psalmist prays that the wicked will suffer the same pain they have caused others.

Psalms 59:14–16

The wicked will remain unsatisfied, but the psalmist will praise the Lord's strength and loving devotion.

Psalms 60:1

- This psalm was taught to young people as part of their education.
- When: See 2 Samuel 8:13–14.
- Aram-naharaim and Aram-zobah refer to the Arameans of northwest Mesopotamia and Syria (see study note on Genesis 24:10).
- The tune "Lily of the Testimony" is unknown today.

Psalms 60:1–4

When God's people experience his discipline, they affirm their loyalty and await God's answer.

Psalms 60:1–12

The psalmist laments a national defeat and cries out to God for rescue.

Psalms 60:3

we are staggered from the wine: Yayin, the Hebrew word for "wine," is often associated with drunkenness (2 Samuel 13:28; Isaiah 5:11; 28:7–8; see also Psalm 104:15; Deuteronomy 14:26; Isaiah 55:1). It symbolized God's judgment on the wicked (Psalm 75:8; Jeremiah 51:7).

Psalms 60:4

- God raised a banner over his people to serve as a rallying point and as a source of pride and confidence.
- The fear of God that leads to wisdom (Psalm 111:10) is not weakness. It gives the perspective and strength needed to do what is right.

Psalms 60:5

The psalmist prays for rescue based on the special relationship between God and his people.

Psalms 60:5–12

This section is repeated in Psalm 108:6–13.

Psalms 60:6

Shechem and Succoth represent the heartland of Israel.

These places were located in the central region of the land. Because of this, they can represent the center of Israel's life and strength.

Psalms 60:6–8

The Lord responds with a message of promise. He shares his land with his people as spoils of war.

Psalms 60:9

Destroying the capital (the fortified city) of a defeated invader would help prevent future attacks. Edom's capital was Bozrah, located to the southeast of Israel. Only God could grant victory.

Psalms 61:1–8

The psalmist asks God to protect him and guide him into his presence (Psalm 61:4–5). He prays for God to extend and protect the king's rule and promises to praise God.

Psalms 61:1–63.11

In these royal prayers, the psalmist longs for God's presence. All three psalms concern themselves with the king's security.

Psalms 61:2

- the ends of the earth: This phrase suggests a cry that comes from a place far away from God.
- The psalmist feels deep sorrow and distress.

Psalms 61:4

- The poet desires God's presence and seeks entry into God's earthly home for protection and care. Being welcomed into God's sanctuary (tent) is the greatest blessing (see Psalms 15:1; 23:6; 24:3–6). The Hebrew word for tent refers to the tabernacle and the tent David built for the ark (1 Chronicles 15:1). See also study note on John 1:14.
- The shelter of your wings represents God's protection and care (see Psalms 9:9; 17:8).

Psalms 61:5

- You have heard my vows: The psalmist's vows might be part of ceremonial sacrifices (Psalms 66:13–15; 76:11; 116:14, 18). He praises and thanks God for rescuing him.
- The inheritance refers to the promise of the land (see Psalm 60), the sacredness of the temple, the joy of God's presence (Psalm 119:111), or any similar reward (Psalms 16:6; 37:9, 11, 18, 22, 29, 34; 127:3).

Psalms 62:1

See 1 Chronicles 25:1; also in Psalms 39 and 77.

Psalms 62:1–12

This psalm expresses trust in the king and includes a prayer for him. The king relies on God even during tough times.

His tricky and strong enemies challenge him, but he stays strong. He urges himself and his people to trust God.

He wants them to view their human enemies from God's perspective, where they seem weak, temporary, and deceitful (Psalm 62:9).

Psalms 62:3–4

The enemies want to overthrow the king using lies and tricks.

Psalms 62:4

his lofty perch: This means the royal throne.

Psalms 62:5–8

The psalmist encourages himself and others to place their hope in God.

Psalms 62:9

are but a lie: People often try to appear stronger and better than they truly are.

Psalms 62:9–12

Humans are temporary, unlike God. Even when successful, their prosperity does not last long.

Psalms 62:10

Extortion involves using threats to force someone to give up their belongings. Stealing means taking what belongs to someone else.

Psalms 62:11–12

Only God balances power and loving devotion. He cares for his people by removing those who do evil from the world (see Psalm 1:6).

Psalms 63:1

- Together, soul and body refer to a person's entire being.
- dry and weary land: When David lived in the desert, he felt spiritually empty, away from God's people and the sanctuary.

Psalms 63:1–11

The king deeply desires God's presence. He experiences God's goodness in everything he does. Despite being tired and troubled by the wicked, the king finds strength in God and praises him. God is his source of life (Psalm 63:3), while the wicked face destruction (63:9).

Psalms 63:2

The psalmist remembers that he had found God to be present in his sanctuary (see Psalm 18:6; 61:4; 62:5, 11–12).

Psalms 63:3

better than life: The best life comes from a relationship with God (see Psalms 4:7; 63:5; Proverbs 16:8).

Psalms 63:6

Meditating on God requires focus, concentration, thought, and reflection (see Psalm 1:2).

Psalms 63:6–8

The psalmist thinks about and feels God's presence during the night. When it is dark, God is the light. The quiet night and the wait for morning offer time to reflect on the true meaning of life with the Lord.

Psalms 63:9

- The wicked planned to ruin the psalmist's life with lies and deceit, but they would fail.
- the depths of the earth: This refers to the place of the dead.

Psalms 63:10

Wild foxes and jackals are often associated with places that are ruined and abandoned (Isaiah 13:20–22; 34:10–15; Jeremiah 9:11; 49:33; 51:37; Lamentations 5:18; Malachi 1:3). The wicked will not receive honor in death. Scavenging animals will consume their bodies (Ecclesiastes 6:3; Jeremiah 22:18–19; 36:29–30).

Psalms 64:1–6

These verses form a prayer for rescue from bold and powerful liars.

Psalms 64:1–10

This lament speaks against the destructive plans and arrogant attitude of the wicked (Psalm 64:1–6). The psalmist prays to God and finds comfort in God's justice because the righteous judge will undo the wicked's actions. The godly will rejoice and gain wisdom as they think about God's powerful deeds.

Psalms 64:3

their tongues ... bitter words: Liars use their words to harm others. This description might also refer to practicing magic.

Psalms 64:6

- The enemies make a plan to harm the innocent without getting caught.
- Human beings can act with extreme evil through words, actions, or plans (Psalm 83:3; see Jeremiah 17:9).

Psalms 64:7–10

God acts righteously. God stops wickedness and gives the wicked what they intended for others.

Psalms 65:1

God alone deserves praise and is worthy to have vows made to him.

Psalms 65:1–3

Praise is the right response to God's great acts in redemption (Psalm 65:3–5) and in nature (65:5–13).

Psalms 65:1–13

This psalm recounts the reasons why all people should praise and revere God for his almighty power and merciful care for his universe.

Psalms 65:2

all people: This means all humans.

Psalms 65:3

You atone: God graciously removes the guilt of sin (see Psalm 32:5).

Psalms 65:4

- the one You choose and bring near: This includes people from Israel and other nations.
- Only those God sees as blameless live in his holy courts (Psalms 15 and 24).
- At the temple, God's earthly palace, all nations can gather to experience God's holy presence. No structure can separate humans from God (see Revelation 21:22).

Psalms 65:6–7

- God brought order to the mountains, the roaring oceans, and the pounding waves (see Psalms 95:4–5; 104:6–9).
- The psalmist compares the chaotic forces of nature with the rebellion of the nations (see Psalms 2:1–12; 33:6–11; 46:6).

Psalms 65:8

All over the world (Job 38:13; see Psalm 50:1–3), people should stand in awe of the Lord.

Psalms 65:9

The streams of God and all rivers show God's power and goodness through nature's order and the regularity of the harvests (see Psalms 1:3; 36:8; 46:4; Ezekiel 47:6–12; Zechariah 14:8; Revelation 22:1).

Psalms 65:9–13

The created world clearly shows God's power (Psalm 65:6–8). He shows his love by taking care of nature. Everything praises the Lord as all parts work together smoothly.

Psalms 65:13

Nature praises the Creator (see Psalm 79:13; 96:11–13; 148:3–5, 7–12; Isaiah 55:12–13).

Psalms 66:1–4

The psalmist urges nature to join a powerful song to praise God's glory, name, and power.

Psalms 66:1–20

This anonymous psalm includes two hymns (Psalm 66:1–12, 13–20) that praise God for saving his people.

Psalms 66:2

The glory of his name represents the perfection of God's character.

Psalms 66:3

God defeats his enemies (see Psalm 18:44; 59:11; 81:15).

Psalms 66:5–7

The story of the exodus and God's victory over the sea causes the people to be amazed (Psalm 66:5) and to worship (66:6). God performs miracles to redeem people for himself.

Psalms 66:7

God's power brings redemption. The same word appears in Psalm 65:6 to describe God's power in creation (see also Psalm 80:2).

Psalms 66:8–10

The orderly lives of the redeemed reflect the order of God's world. The Lord protects them from evil and purifies them.

Psalms 66:9

God guides his people into wisdom and away from foolishness (Psalms 17:5; 37:31; 121:3).

Psalms 66:10

For You, O God, have tested us: Like a silversmith heats silver to remove impurities, God's discipline removes sin from his people (see Psalm 12:6).

Psalms 66:11

God decrees and permits the many trying circumstances his people experience.

Psalms 66:12

You let men ride over our heads: Or You made people rule over us. This likely refers to a foreign ruler who controlled the Israelites.

Psalms 66:15

Vows often included sacrifices of thanksgiving, including burnt offerings (see Psalms 20:3; 40:6; 50:8; 51:19).

Psalms 66:16–20

The private testimony at the end of the psalm matches the public praise at the beginning (Psalm 66:1–4).

Psalms 66:18

Confession leads to restoration (see Psalm 32:5).

Psalms 67:1–2

This prayer is inspired by the priestly blessing in Numbers 6:24–26. God's kindness to Israel influences his reputation among other nations (see Psalm 96:1–3).

Psalms 67:1–7

This anonymous prayer asks for God's blessing. The psalmist speaks about knowing and worshiping God among all nations (compare Psalms 64:9; 65:8). The prayer asks for God's name to remain holy and that his kingdom come (compare Matthew 6:9–13).

Psalms 67:3

- God's international reputation leads to his praise among the nations (see Psalm 138:4). Their chaos and rebellion will stop when they join Israel in praising God.
- One God rules over everyone, and the nations will give thanks for God's just rule (see Psalm 67:4).

Psalms 67:4

God delivers the ultimate justice that people seek (Psalms 96:10; 98:9).

Psalms 67:6–7

- Large harvests show God's blessing (Genesis 26:12; Isaiah 30:23).
- all the ends of the earth: See Psalms 2:8; 96:1–3.
- People from every nation will join Israel in acknowledging the God of Israel.

Psalms 68:1–3

These verses form a prayer for God to rise and scatter his enemies, like when Israel entered the promised land (compare Numbers 10:35–36; Joshua 6–12).

Psalms 68:1–35

This prayer for God's victorious rule describes God's journey from Sinai to Zion (Psalm 68:7, 16–18, 24). He saved Israel from Egypt, led them through the wilderness, brought them to the promised land, and established his kingdom. He is a caring and victorious God, whose nature does not change. Therefore, the faithful hope and rejoice in the promise of God's universal rule.

Psalms 68:2

Both smoke and wax represent a temporary existence (Psalms 22:12–18; 37:20; 102:3).

Psalms 68:3

The fate of the godly is different from that of the wicked (see Psalm 1:6).

Psalms 68:4

Him who rides on the clouds: This is an ancient description of Baal, a Canaanite god. The psalmist uses it to describe the Lord as the true God "who rides upon the highest heavens" (see Psalms 68:33; 104:3). God has power over the clouds and the rain.

Psalms 68:4–6

The psalmist praises God's powerful and compassionate reign.

Psalms 68:5

- God, the Father of all marginalized and needy people, shows them compassion and protects their rights (see Psalms 10:14, 18; 69:33; 82:3).
- Like his dwelling, the Lord is holy. The supreme example of the holy God coming down to rescue humanity is Jesus Christ.

Psalms 68:6

- God freed Israel from slavery in Egypt (Exodus 20:2; see Psalm 69:33), and he continues to free prisoners today.
- The sun-scorched land represents being far from God and separated from blessing.

Psalms 68:8–10

- The earth shook as it does during an earthquake (see Exodus 19:18).
- the heavens poured down rain: Wells in the desert and rain showers in Canaan provided plenty of water.

Psalms 68:11

a great company of women proclaim it: A large group of women singers celebrates the victory in song (see Psalm 68:25; Exodus 15:20).

Psalms 68:13

The people who cared for flocks and moved from place to place were surprised to receive silver and gold ornaments from the battle.

Psalms 68:14

- The Almighty (Hebrew Shaddai) is an ancient name for God (see Psalm 91:1; Genesis 17:1).
- The exact location of Mount Zalmon is unknown; it might have been a mountain in Bashan (see Psalm 68:15).

Psalms 68:15

Bashan is a plateau northeast of Jerusalem and east of the Sea of Galilee. It was famous for its forests and pastureland (see Psalm 22:12; Isaiah 2:13). The mountains might have included Mount Hermon to the north of the plateau or Mount Zalmon, possibly Jebel ed-Druze to the east.

Psalms 68:16

Why do you gaze in envy: Bashan is more impressive than the mountains around Jerusalem, but it was not

the Lord's home. Only Mount Zion had the honor of being God's dwelling place.

Psalms 68:17

Chariots were the top weapon of the military in the psalmist's time. They represent the Lord's power to give victory (Psalms 20:7; 44:3).

Psalms 68:18

- You have ascended on high: The Most High victoriously established his reign in Zion.
- captives ... gifts: This image shows a victorious ruler leading a victory march after battle. Paul applied this image to Jesus Christ (Ephesians 4:8–13).

Psalms 68:19

Like a caring father or a shepherd, God carries his people in his arms (see Psalm 55:22; 68:5–6).

Psalms 68:19–20

God cares for his people like a shepherd, and the people praise him.

Psalms 68:21

God will crush the heads of His enemies: Compare Genesis 3:15.

Psalms 68:22

God will deal with all enemies, whether from high places (represented by Bashan) or low (the depths of the sea).

Psalms 68:24–27

A great company joins together in the pilgrimage to Zion.

Psalms 68:28–31

The people pray for God's help and victory over enemy nations (Psalm 68:1–3).

Psalms 68:29

The conquered kings will bring gifts to the Lord.

Psalms 68:30

Hostile and rebellious people delight in warfare and insurrection (see Psalm 2:1–3).

Psalms 68:32

The phrase kingdoms of the earth refers to all nations and power structures.

Psalms 68:32–35

The psalmist urges the people to praise God, who triumphs over his enemies.

Psalms 68:34

When the Lord shows his power, majesty, and strength to the nations, he makes his people stronger (see Psalm 96:4–6).

Psalms 69:1

Psalm 45 also mentions this tune, but Psalm 45 praises the glory of kingship. In contrast, Psalm 69 is the cry of a tired king who feels abandoned by the Lord.

Psalms 69:1–2

The psalmist sees himself as almost drowning but still surviving chaotic forces and his sense of separation from God (see Psalm 42:7; 69:14, 15; Isaiah 8:8).

Psalms 69:1–36

In this personal lament, the poet shares his vulnerability, humiliation, and deep pain. He asks God to defend him for the sake of the righteous.

Psalms 69:1–72.20

These last four psalms of Book Two contrast with the earlier psalms that describe God's mighty acts in creation and redemption, ending with God's march to Zion (Psalms 65–68). Psalms 69–71 describe the king's suffering, and Psalm 72 responds with a prayer for God to bless the king.

Psalms 69:4

John applied this lament to Jesus (John 15:25).

Psalms 69:5–6

The psalmist confesses his sins and prays that God's response to him will encourage others in similar conditions to place their hope in the Lord.

Psalms 69:7–12

Mistreated and abandoned by family, friends, and community, the psalmist seeks comfort, relief (Psalm 69:13–18), and justice (69:22–28) from the Lord.

Psalms 69:9

The psalmist is devoted to God and what is holy, yet people repay him with insults. Later, this verse was applied to the anger of Jesus at the temple's money changers (John 2:17) and his undeserved suffering (Romans 15:3).

Psalms 69:10–12

When the psalmist denies himself normal comforts to seek God in prayer, the wicked ridicule him.

Psalms 69:13–18

The psalmist can only pray for rescue and relief from his enemies.

Psalms 69:19–21

The psalmist feels alone and misunderstood. He cannot bear his doubts, and his troubles overwhelm him.

Psalms 69:21

vinegar to quench my thirst: This description applies to the suffering of Jesus (Matthew 27:34, 48; Luke 23:36; John 19:28–29).

Psalms 69:22–23

The psalmist asks God to give his suffering (Psalm 69:3) to his enemies. Paul applied these words to the unbelieving Jews of his day (Romans 11:9–10).

Psalms 69:25

Peter quoted this verse after the death of Judas Iscariot (Acts 1:20).

Psalms 69:28

May they be blotted out of the Book of Life: Compare Psalm 1:5–6; 9:5; Revelation 3:5; 20:15; 21:22–27.

Psalms 69:29–33

The psalmist prays that his pain will turn to praise.

Psalms 69:31

Making a vow often included a sacrifice (Psalms 20:3; 51:19; compare 50:13–14; 51:16).

Psalms 69:32–33

despise: See Psalm 22:24; compare Matthew 25:36; Hebrews 13:3.

Psalms 69:34–36

The psalmist prays for Zion, offering a new petition from a new circumstance. He applies the prayer (Psalm 69:1–33) to the desperate condition of Judah (see 51:18–19).

Psalms 69:36

God's people will inherit the land because the wicked will perish (see Psalm 37:8–9).

Psalms 70:1

To bring remembrance: The meaning of this phrase is not known (also found in Psalm 38:1).

Psalms 70:1–5

This psalm is almost exactly the same as Psalm 40:13–17. It has an urgent tone (Psalm 70:1, 5) that matches the nearby psalms (compare 69:17; 71:12).

Psalms 71:1–4

The poet recognizes God as a dependable protector who will act justly towards him and his oppressors. See also Psalm 31:1–3.

Psalms 71:1–24

This untitled lament by an aging believer is more a confession of confidence and hope than a cry of abandonment by God. The psalmist experienced God's power and protection in his youth (Psalm 71:5–8) and now prays for rescue from enemies who pursue him in his old age (Psalm 71:9–13).

Even in danger, he continues to speak of God's past faithfulness and looks forward with hope to sharing with the next generation that God is faithful and righteous.

Psalms 71:5–6

The psalmist has trusted God throughout his life (see Psalm 22:9).

Psalms 71:9

The poet prays for continued fellowship with God (see Psalm 9:10; 51:11). In his weakness, the poet needs the Lord's strength even more (see Psalm 143:7).

Psalms 71:9–18

The aging believer turns to the Lord for hope. As questions from his adversaries get under his skin and his own strength fails, he asks God to answer his prayers. He does not seek answers to prayer for himself but so that he can tell the story to the next generation.

Psalms 71:10

The psalmist's enemies plan and scheme together (Psalms 2:2; 21:11; 31:13; 35:4; 63:9–10).

Psalms 71:14

The psalmist compares his goodness to his enemies' evil. He focuses on the Lord, even in difficult times (see Psalms 9:17–18; 27:13–14).

Psalms 71:19–21

God's righteous character provides encouragement and strength in the midst of suffering. The wounded psalmist confesses faith in God's ability to transform his misery and weakness into abundant life.

Psalms 71:20

You will bring me back up: The psalmist hopes for the renewal of an abundant earthly life. This later became grounds for belief in the resurrection of the dead.

Psalms 71:21

Knowing God provides comfort also assures the poet of God's presence, care, and goodness (Psalms 23:4, 6; 86:17). God's comfort increases the psalmist's sense of being alive (see Psalm 119:50).

Psalms 71:22–24

As he awaits God's rescue, the psalmist prepares himself to declare with instruments and voice that God is faithful and righteous.

Psalms 72:1

justice ... righteousness: In the ancient Near East, kings were expected to represent justice. For Israel's kings, the standard was higher because they followed the Lord's example.

Psalms 72:1–7

Justice brings balance to nature, leading to harmony, prosperity, and fertility.

Psalms 72:1–20

This royal psalm concludes Book Two, with Psalm 72:18–20 serving as an epilogue for the entire book. The psalmist considers the future of David's royal line and Zion (see Psalms 46, 48). He prays that Israel's kings will be good and successful, spreading the Lord's blessing to all people worldwide. The exceptional righteousness and rule desired in this prayer hint at the future arrival of Jesus, the Son of David.

Psalms 72:3

Justice makes the world fruitful, abundant, harmonious, and good (see Isaiah 32:16–17).

Psalms 72:4

A just ruler will defend the poor against injustice, rescue them from violence, and bring their oppressors to account for their wrongdoing.

Psalms 72:5

May they fear him: In Hebrew, this phrase appears to be a response to the enforcement of justice. The Greek version reads May they endure, which makes this a prayer for long life (Psalm 21:4; 72:15, 17).

Psalms 72:6–7

- The administration of justice is refreshing like spring rain, allowing the godly to thrive (see Isaiah 45:8) like flowers.
- until the moon is no more: This phrase means forever (see Psalm 89:36–37).

Psalms 72:8–9

- from sea to sea: This phrase represents the entire world.
- Solomon's kingdom stretched from the Euphrates River in the east to the Philistine territory in the west (1 Kings 4:21; see Psalms 80:8–11; 89:19–25), where the Mediterranean Sea appeared to be at the ends of the earth (see 2:8).

Everyone will bow before this king, including desert nomads (Psalm 72:9), his enemies, and all the world's kings (see Micah 7:17).

Psalms 72:8–11

The anointed king will rule the entire world. Even enemy nations will obey him. In the ancient Near East, giving gifts to the king showed his success and reputation (see 1 Kings 10).

Psalms 72:10

- The western kings of Tarshish came from a major colony in the western Mediterranean. The eastern kings of Sheba came from southern Arabia, home of the queen of Sheba (1 Kings 10).
- Seba was likely south of Egypt, possibly on the western shore of the Red Sea across from Sheba.
- The gifts given to the king were a tribute and a sign of submission.

Psalms 72:11

All kings and nations must submit to the messianic king (God's chosen leader). The hope in Psalm 2:10–11 will come true (see 96:1–3; 1 Corinthians 15:25) when other leaders and peoples bow and serve this king.

Psalms 72:12

To deliver the needy means to bring an end to the rule of their oppressors.

Psalms 72:12–14

The anointed king will help those in need. He is both a judge and a father to the poor (Psalms 10:14, 17; 68:5).

Psalms 72:13

Like a father, the king feels pity for those in need (see Malachi 3:17).

Psalms 72:15

The people will bless him, fulfilling God's promise to Abraham (Genesis 12:3; see Psalm 133:3).

Psalms 72:15–17

The just kingdom will be long-lasting and universal. The summary combines the themes of abundance of crops, longevity, tribute of the nations, and the prayer of the nations.

Psalms 72:16

the forests of Lebanon: Lebanon was famous for its wood (see study note on 2 Chronicles 2:8).

Psalms 72:18–19

This doxology (song of praise) ends Book Two of the Psalms.

Psalms 72:20

This parenthetical note ends Book Two, which consists mostly of prayers of David. Books Three to Five were probably compiled after Book Two; they include additional psalms of David (Psalms 86, 101, 103, 108–110, 122, 124, 131, 133, 138–145).

Psalms 73:1

People with pure hearts (people who are sincere and devoted to God) are renewed by God's Spirit (Psalm 51:10). They choose to live in a godly way, turn away from sin, and enjoy God's presence (see Psalm 24:3–4).

Psalms 73:1–28

This wisdom psalm looks at the injustice of the prosperity of the wicked. The psalmist states that God is good to the godly, but his own experience is different (Psalm 73:2–12).

Almost overwhelmed by doubt (Psalm 73:13–16), the psalmist meets the Lord in the sanctuary. This meeting gives him a broader view and renews his trust in God (Psalm 73:17–26). His troubling doubts lead to a stronger desire for truth. He knows he can trust God and that God will save him (Psalm 73:27–28).

Psalms 73:title

Asaph was a Levitical singer appointed by David (1 Chronicles 6:39). His descendants were singers and instrumentalists (1 Chronicles 15:16–17). Many of the Psalms of Asaph (Psalms 50, 73–83) were likely written by Asaph's descendants later in Israel's history (for example, Psalm 74).

Psalms 73:1–75.10

The seeming success of the wicked (Psalm 73) and God's apparent rejection of his people (Psalm 74) raise questions about his justice. God rules the entire world and decides when to judge (Psalm 75).

Psalms 73:2–3

- The poet thinks it is unfair that wicked people prosper (see Psalm 72:7) and feels upset about it.
- The psalmist almost strayed from the path of wisdom and godliness (see Psalm 17:5; 37:31), but God prevented him from completely losing his way (38:16; 66:9; 94:18; 121:3).
- when I saw the prosperity of the wicked: Compare Psalm 72:3, 7.

Psalms 73:4–12

The psalmist gives an exaggerated picture of the happiness of the wicked (compare Psalm 1).

Psalms 73:6

Proud people choose pride and cruelty over wisdom (Proverbs 1:9).

Psalms 73:9

The proud boast, claiming that they own everything and are not subject to anyone (see Psalm 2:1–3).

Psalms 73:13–14

- These rhetorical questions expect a discouraging "yes" as an answer. The psalmist wonders if godliness has become a meaningless ritual (see Malachi 3:14–15).
- my heart: This refers to his whole being.
- The psalmist's pain comes from discipline and rebuke (Psalm 39:11; Proverbs 1:23, 25; 12:1).

Psalms 73:13–17

When the psalmist sees the effect of his discouragement and doubt, he turns to the Lord and gains new understanding.

Psalms 73:15–16

If the psalmist had spoken about his doubts regarding the value of living a godly life, he might have discouraged God's people and given God's enemies a chance to speak against God (compare John 13:20). Instead, the psalmist keeps the problem to himself and thinks about it.

Psalms 73:17–20

- During this period, God's sanctuary was the temple in Jerusalem. In God's presence, the psalmist receives special insight (compare Psalm 18:6).
- God deals with the wicked over the long term. He waits patiently and gives them time to repent (Ezekiel 33:11; 2 Peter 3:9). Those who do not repent will get what they deserve.

Psalms 73:21–22

The psalmist's feelings about the prosperity of the wicked had given him a bitter spirit.

Psalms 73:24

The Lord leads the godly through their troubles and changes their misery into splendor.

Psalms 73:25–26

Nothing in heaven or on earth is better than being near God.

Psalms 74:1

- God rejected his people because their sin made him angry (Psalm 106:34–46).
- Like a caring shepherd, God looks after his people, the sheep of his pasture (Psalms 23; 100:3).

Psalms 74:1–2

In the aftermath of Jerusalem's fall, it seemed that God had forgotten his special covenant relationship with his people.

Psalms 74:1–23

The psalmist laments the destruction of the temple in Jerusalem. This happened in 586 BC. The psalmist uses vivid imagery, asks questions, recalls fresh memories, and directly asks the Lord to act (Psalm 74:19–23).

Psalms 74:2

- The Lord chose and redeemed Israel from Egypt in the exodus (compare Exodus 15:13).
- Your congregation: This is another expression for "your people" (Psalms 28:9; 78:62; 94:14; 106:40).

Psalms 74:3–8

Like a guide, the psalmist points out to the Lord what took place during the destruction of Jerusalem in 586 BC.

Psalms 74:12

my King from ancient times: The psalmist acknowledges God's power and his historical bond with Israel (Psalms 5:2; 44:4; 84:3).

Psalms 74:14

Leviathan: See Psalm 104:26; Job 3:8; 41:1, 12, 22, 31; Isaiah 27:1. Here, the creature's multiple heads suggest a mythical monster.

Psalms 74:15

ever-flowing rivers: God gave water in the desert to his people (see Psalm 68:8–9; Exodus 17:6). He dried up the Red Sea (Exodus 14:21) and the Jordan River (Joshua 3:17).

Psalms 74:19–23

The poet urges God to act.

Psalms 75:1–10

This hymn of thanksgiving includes two direct messages from God that assure us of his justice (Psalm 75:2–3, 10). The Lord warns arrogant people who defy him, promising to humble them by force (Psalm 75:4–8). Together, the community and the psalmist give thanks for God's character (Psalm 75:1, 9).

Psalms 75:2–8

The Lord will bring justice in his own time.

Psalms 75:4–5

The wicked proudly defy heaven, where God lives. By boasting, they claim that they are wiser than God.

Psalms 75:6

No creature has the right to rebel against its Creator.

Psalms 75:7–8

The Lord alone is the Judge. He has the power to raise people up or bring them down (see 1 Samuel 2:7; Luke 1:52).

Psalms 76:1

A song: The Greek version reads for the Assyrian.

Psalms 76:1–3

God's victory over Zion's enemies hints at his future victory over all his enemies worldwide.

Psalms 76:1–12

This psalm appears to celebrate a victory. The victory might have been recent, such as over the Assyrians (see note on 76:1; see also Isaiah 37). Or, it might be remembering God's great acts of rescue in the past.

Psalms 76:3

God brings an end to the attacks of his enemies (see Psalm 46:9).

Psalms 76:4

The victorious king's splendor, glory, and majesty are greater than anything in the created order (Psalm 8:1; 29:4; 111:3).

Psalms 76:4–6

The psalmist praises God for his achievement and for his glorious majesty.

Psalms 76:7

feared: The Hebrew word nora' sounds like the Hebrew word na'or, translated "resplendent," in Psalm 76:4.

Psalms 76:7–9

The needy await their victorious God, while the wicked stand in fear of him.

Psalms 77:1–3

The night provides a special opportunity for prayer and meditation (Psalms 77:6, 11; see 6:6; 16:7; 17:3; 30:5; 63:6; 119:55, 62, 148).

Psalms 77:1–20

The psalmist laments that God has turned away from him, even though he feels innocent. He reflects on his situation (Psalm 77:3, 6, 12) and finds hope (see 25:5) in remembering God's past actions (77:11).

Psalms 77:3

- I remembered You, O God: God's people often face hard times. Remembering God's powerful actions at the beginning of their relationship assures them of God's commitment.
- Feeling overwhelmed, the psalmist is unable to deal with the crisis (Psalms 142:3; 143:4).

Psalms 77:4–6

As the psalmist meditates at night, he feels so disturbed that he cannot sleep or speak. He has pleasant memories of the past, but he cannot look beyond the present moment into the future.

Psalms 77:7

Feeling rejected (see Psalm 43:2), the psalmist asks if the situation is permanent.

Psalms 77:7–9

The psalmist questions his status before God.

Psalms 77:10

The psalmist is afraid that God's hand of protection (Psalm 44:3; 77:15; Exodus 6:6) and favor (Psalms 16:7–8; 110:1) are now against him for no clear reason.

Psalms 77:10–12

The memories of God's mighty works in the past fill the psalmist's mind.

Psalms 77:13–15

This central section of the poem reflects on God as the holy and powerful redeemer.

Psalms 77:16

the waters saw You and swirled: The Canaanites attributed divine power to the sea, but God is the one who made the sea and uses it for his own purposes.

Psalms 78:1–8

The introduction is an invitation to learn wisdom.

Psalms 78:1–72

This wisdom psalm urges people to learn wisdom and share it faithfully.

Psalms 78:2

- The psalmist tells Israel's story (Psalm 78:5–72) as a parable to teach wisdom and insight.
- Jesus quoted this verse to explain why he taught in parables (Matthew 13:35).

Psalms 78:3–4

This story of what God has done should be told from generation to generation (see Deuteronomy 6:20–25; Proverbs 4:1–4).

Psalms 78:5–6

The telling of the story should motivate God's people to obey what he commanded (Deuteronomy 6:4–9).

Psalms 78:7–8

God holds each generation responsible for its own actions. They should maintain faith and hope (see Psalm 9:18; 27:14) and avoid being stubborn, rebellious, and unfaithful (see Deuteronomy 9:6–7; 10:16; 30:6; 31:27).

Psalms 78:9–11

Ephraim was the second son of Joseph. He received a special blessing from Jacob (Genesis 48:15–20; 49:22–26; Deuteronomy 33:13–17). His descendants inherited land with fertile valleys and important roads (Judges 8:2). However, the people of Ephraim did not follow God's covenant.

Psalms 78:12

The wonders are the ten plagues against Egypt that God performed during Israel's captivity (Exodus 7–12).

Psalms 78:12–16

The focus shifts from Ephraim (Psalm 78:9–11) to all of Israel. The psalmist thinks about God's power in Egypt (see Psalm 81:4–7) and in the wilderness.

Psalms 78:13

God split the sea when Israel crossed through the Red Sea (see Exodus 14–15).

Psalms 78:14

God used a cloud and a light of fire to guide and protect Israel in the wilderness (Exodus 13:21–22).

Psalms 78:17–31

Israel rebelled in the wilderness despite God's abundant provision.

Psalms 78:23–25

- Abundance comes through the doors of heaven (Genesis 8:2; 2 Kings 7:2; Malachi 3:10).
- The Israelites ate manna for 40 years in the wilderness (Exodus 16:31–36; John 6:31).

Psalms 78:26–31

God powerfully satisfied the people's desires, but they did not respond with gratitude or faith. Therefore, God exercised his justice.

Psalms 78:32–39

Israel's rebellion resulted in God's judgment, but even their short-lived and insincere repentance motivated God to exercise forbearance.

Psalms 78:33

An entire generation died in the wilderness (Numbers 14:22–23, 28–35).

Psalms 78:34

they repented: This strong show of effort was not sincere.

Psalms 78:34–39

Israel continued to exist because of God's compassion, despite the people's rebellion and lack of belief (Psalm 78:7–8).

Psalms 78:35–39

The Israelites remembered the correct teaching about God (Psalms 9:9; 91:1), but they did not let God change the way they thought and lived (Leviticus 26:41).

Psalms 78:40–55

The Israelites rebelled even though the Lord had rescued them from powerful plagues.

Psalms 78:56–64

Israel's rebellion defiled the promised land. During the time of the judges, the people built shrines to false gods and worshiped idols (Psalm 78:58; see also Judges 2:11; 3:7, 17–18).

Psalms 78:60

God abandoned his dwelling at Shiloh because of the people's idol worship (1 Samuel 4:11; Jeremiah 7:12).

Psalms 78:67

The tribe of Ephraim was not completely rejected, but God favored Judah (Psalm 78:68).

Psalms 78:68–69

In the choice of Mount Zion instead of Shiloh as God's sanctuary on earth, God moved from the north to the south (see Psalm 69).

Psalms 78:70–72

The God who had turned against his own people (Psalm 78:62) chose David, a shepherd (Genesis 46:34;

1 Samuel 16:10–11), to lead them as their shepherd (Psalm 78:52; compare 23:1).

Psalms 79:1

Your inheritance: This phrase might refer to the land, the temple (see Psalm 61:5), or the people (see 79:2; 78:71).

Psalms 79:1–4

The poet laments the defilement of the temple and the success of the enemy.

Psalms 79:1–13

This lament describes the fall of Jerusalem in 586 BC. Israel's early history of rebellion, described in Psalm 78, angered God. As a result, Zion was destroyed. The temple was defiled, and the bodies of the dead lay across the land.

The psalmist then prays for forgiveness and rescue (Psalm 79:8–9) and asks God to repay the nation's enemies (Psalm 79:12–13). Other psalms lamenting the exile include Psalms 42–44, 102, 107, 126, and 137.

Psalms 79:5–8

The intensity of God's judgment surprises the people; they cry out in despair for compassion, forgiveness, and relief. Verse 6–7 are nearly identical to Jeremiah 10:25.

Psalms 79:6

The repentant among God's people ask him to vent his anger not on them but on their wicked and unrepentant enemies.

Psalms 79:8

The people's many sins in the past helped lead to the exile (2 Kings 17:7–23; 24:3–4). However, each person also suffered because of his or her own sin (Jeremiah 31:30; Ezekiel 18:20).

Psalms 79:9–11

The people ask God to rescue them. Although Israel's sins caused the tragedy, the pagan nations must also be held responsible for the bloodshed.

Psalms 79:12

- The exile resulted in national suffering and in individual searching for the Lord.
- Pay back: See Psalm 1:6; 94:2; Jeremiah 32:18.
- The phrase sevenfold means something is complete.
- Israel's neighbors included Edom, Moab, and Ammon (see Psalm 137:7; 2 Kings 24:2; Obadiah 1).

Psalms 80:1

The tune of "The Lilies of the Covenant" is unknown today.

Psalms 80:1–2

- O Shepherd of Israel: See also Psalm 23:1; 28:9; 78:52–53.
- shine forth ... mighty power: These expressions (Psalm 145:11) refer to God's visible presence.

Psalms 80:1–3

The psalmist urgently calls upon the Lord to act.

Psalms 80:1–19

This psalm of lament may come from the remnant (the small group that survived) of the northern kingdom after it fell in 722 BC. The people call on God as their Shepherd and as the God of Hosts (a title that describes God as the ruler over the armies of heaven). They hope that he will return to them and restore them.

They remember the Exodus and their special relationship with the Lord. The psalm ends with a promise of renewed commitment to him (Psalm 80:18).

Psalms 80:3

This verse is repeated (with a growing intensity) in Psalm 80:7 and 19.

Psalms 80:4–7

The people cry out for rescue from the shame of their recent defeat. The enemy's victory is less devastating, however, than the knowledge that they themselves are objects of God's wrath.

Psalms 80:8–9

Israel had been like a fruitful grapevine (Genesis 1:28; Galatians 5:22–23) that God transplanted to Canaan at the time of the conquest. However, the people forgot the source of their prosperity and chose to do evil (Isaiah 5:1–7; Hosea 10:1).

Psalms 80:8–11

Israel has a glorious past that began when God rescued the people from Egypt.

Psalms 80:10–11

Solomon's kingdom had extended west to the Mediterranean Sea and east to the Euphrates River (see Psalms 72:8–9; 89:25; 1 Kings 4:21).

Psalms 80:12

broken down its walls: God no longer defended Israel (Isaiah 5:5).

Psalms 80:13

The surrounding nations were ceremonially unclean, like a wild boar or vicious wild animals.

Psalms 80:15

Israel was the son that God had brought out of Egypt (see Hosea 11:1) and planted him in the Holy Land.

Psalms 80:16–19

The community prays for God to change their desperate situation and restore them. They are still the Lord's chosen people.

Psalms 80:17

The son God chose was probably the northern kingdom of Israel. But it may also refer to the king from David's line (Psalm 110:1).

Psalms 81:1–3

Before giving a warning, the psalmist calls Israel to think about their God through song and dance.

Psalms 81:1–16

This warning message invites Israel to worship only the Lord and to enjoy the fullness of his blessing.

Psalms 81:2

- An Israelite tambourine was a hand drum with a round frame and skin cover. People used it as a percussion instrument during celebrations, often to accompany dancing (Psalms 68:25; 149:3; 150:4).
- The sweet-sounding harp and lyre, both stringed instruments, are the most frequently mentioned instruments in the psalms (for example, Psalms 33:2; 57:8; 71:22; 150:3).

Psalms 81:3

- The ram's horn gathered armies and announced special holy days (Psalms 47:5; 98:6).
- New Moon: The first day of each lunar month was a festival.

Psalms 81:4–5

The festival, a time to celebrate and listen to the Lord, took place at God's appointed time.

Psalms 81:5

for Joseph: The tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh (the sons of Joseph) are used here to refer to the entire nation of Israel.

Psalms 81:6–7

The Lord heard Israel's cry in Egypt and rescued them from oppressive slavery.

Psalms 81:8–10

God pleads with his people to remember the covenant and the Ten Commandments.

Psalms 81:10

- God emphasizes that he and no one else rescued Israel.
- The nation should eagerly accept God's word (compare Deuteronomy 8:3; Ezekiel 3:1).

Psalms 81:11–16

The Lord helps Israel to understand that their failure was not because of his weakness.

Psalms 81:13–14

- God wants to give his goodness to his children, but they must listen (Isaiah 1:18–19; 28:12; 48:18–19; see Deuteronomy 6:3).
- God promises to defeat the enemies (Deuteronomy 9:3) of those who follow the paths of obedience and loyalty. He will also provide abundantly for his people (Isaiah 1:19).

Psalms 82:1

- God is ready to give judgment (see Isaiah 3:13).
- divine assembly: See Job 1:6.

Psalms 82:1–8

God condemns those who mistreat the helpless.

Psalms 82:2

Because justice defines God's rule (Psalm 89:4), he does not support the wicked. The psalmist is confused by this situation and cries out to God to bring justice (Psalm 82:3–4, 8).

Psalms 82:5

Unjust oppressors cannot bring or restore order. They wander about in darkness, unmoved by circumstances, even when the whole world order falls apart around them (compare Psalm 11:3).

Psalms 82:6–7

The gods (see study notes on Psalm 29:1–2; 58:1), like mere humans, cannot escape the judgment common to human rulers. Jesus quoted from this passage in John 10:34.

Psalms 82:8

The nations belong to God. He will take over the realms formerly ruled by local gods and give them to his people, just as he did with the promised land.

Psalms 83:1–4

The enemy has successfully intimidated God's people, so the poet prays that the Lord will hear and act.

Psalms 83:1–18

This community lament asks God to rescue his people and give them victory. The short and direct poetry suggests a time of great trouble. A strong group of nations plans to destroy Israel (Psalm 83:1–4) and joins together against God (83:5–8).

The psalmist remembers what happened to other enemies who attacked Israel in the past (Psalm 83:9–12). He prays that the same thing will happen to these enemies (83:13–16), so that they will recognize God's power and give him honor (83:17–18).

It is not clear whether this psalm refers to one specific historical event or whether it gathers together several nations as a poetic picture of Israel's enemies.

Psalms 83:5–8

they form an alliance: The allies agreed to fight against God and his people. The nations named in this alliance lived around Israel and Judah.

Psalms 83:6–7

- The Edomites were descendants of Esau. They lived southeast of Judah (see Genesis 25:30; 32:3; 36:1–8).
- The Ishmaelites were descendants of Hagar. They lived in the desert.
- The Moabites and Ammonites were descendants of Lot. They lived east of Israel and Judah.
- The Hagrites might have lived north of the Ammonites (1 Chronicles 5:10).

Psalms 83:7

- Gebal, also known as Byblos, was on the coast of Lebanon.
- The Amalekites lived south of Israel in the Negev desert.
- Philistia was southwest of Judah, near the Mediterranean Sea.
- Tyre was a port city on the Mediterranean Sea, northwest of Israel.

Psalms 83:8

- Assyria was located northeast of Israel and north of the Persian Gulf.
- Lot's descendants were the Moabites and the Ammonites (Psalm 83:6–7).

Psalms 83:9–11

The Midianites, led by Oreb and Zeeb and ruled by Zebah and Zalmunna, were Israel's enemies during Gideon's time (Judges 7:1–8:5). Barak's alliance defeated Sisera and Jabin (Judges 4).

Psalms 83:9–18

The psalmist prays that God will miraculously destroy the new coalition as he did three other enemies; doing so would bring him glory.

Psalms 83:12

The coalition wanted to destroy Israel to take over the land (see Jeremiah 3:19).

Psalms 83:13

tumbleweed ... chaff: This dry plant material blows away easily (see Isaiah 17:13).

Psalms 83:14–15

fire ... flame ... tempest: These images describe how God appears when he brings judgment (see Isaiah 29:6).

Psalms 84:1–4

The psalmist is far from the temple. He turns toward it in hopeful reflection.

Psalms 84:1–12

The psalmist deeply longs for God's presence. He feels weak with longing as he thinks about the temple and the pilgrims traveling to Jerusalem (Psalm 84:1–7). He prays for himself and the community (Psalm 84:8–9).

The end of the psalm (Psalm 84:10–12) shows that the temple represents God. The psalmist truly desires God's presence. He understands that God's goodness is better than life and that only God can grant his people favor and honor (Psalm 84:10–11).

Psalms 84:3

The poet envies the birds that have nesting places in and around the temple.

Psalms 84:4

The priests and those who worked in the temple also lived there.

Psalms 84:5

Travelers needed strength to meet the challenges of pilgrimage by foot along unpaved paths, in all kinds of weather and with the possibility of assaults.

Psalms 84:5–7

The pilgrimage to Jerusalem reminded people of the exodus, when God provided for his people in a wonderful way (see Psalm 78:15–16; 105:41). The psalmist describes how the hardships of the journey turn into joy when the travelers arrive.

Psalms 84:6

- The Valley of Baca is also called the Valley of Weeping or the Valley of Tears. It likely symbolizes the sadness that lonely pilgrims felt (see Psalm 23:4), rather than a real place.
- spring ... autumn rain: Even when pilgrims feel completely worn out, the hope of getting closer to the Lord encourages them (compare Isaiah 35:6–10; 41:18–20; 43:17–20; 49:10).

Psalms 84:9

Both kings and priests were anointed to dedicate them for service (see Psalm 132:17; Exodus 28:41; 1 Samuel 9:16; 16:1–13; compare Isaiah 61:1; Acts 10:38).

Psalms 84:10

The psalmist viewed being in God's presence as much better than being anywhere else.

Psalms 84:11

Some people worshiped the sun as a god, but the true God provides all that anyone needs.

Psalms 85:1

God brought Israel back from exile and restored its fortunes (see Psalm 14:7; 126:1).

Psalms 85:1–5

Though the psalmist gratefully acknowledges God's goodness, he also asks God whether his wrath will last forever.

Psalms 85:1–13

The psalmist leads the community that returned from exile in a lament and a prayer for complete restoration:

- He remembers how God rescued Israel from exile (Psalm 85:1–3),
- asks for clearer signs of God's goodness, and
- leads the people in prayer for full renewal (Psalm 85:4–7).

God answers with a message of peace (Psalm 85:8–9). The psalm ends with a poetic description of the greatness of God's salvation (85:10–13).

Psalms 85:2

When God forgave the guilt of their sins, he gave the people the possibility of fellowship with him (see Psalm 32:5).

Psalms 85:6–7

This prayer for renewal is based on God's unfailing love for his people.

Psalms 85:8–9

- When God speaks, his faithful people listen. He promises them peace, meaning wholeness and well-being (see Psalm 37:11). They respect the Lord and know that he and his salvation are near.
- The Lord does not tolerate foolish ways, such as those that resulted in the exile.

Psalms 85:10–13

In the renewed world of salvation, all the qualities of God's care (love, truth, righteousness, and peace) come together. They transform creation and make it new (see Isaiah 32:15–20).

Psalms 85:13

Righteousness is like a messenger preparing the world for God's coming in response to the prayers of his people (Psalms 85:4–7; 89:14).

Psalms 86:1

This is the only Psalm connected to David in the third book.

Psalms 86:1–4

God's devoted servant prays for mercy. The psalmist sees himself as a member of the covenant community and as a citizen of the world.

Psalms 86:1–17

The psalmist cries out to God for help and praises God's character while facing evil (Psalm 86:14, 17). He says that all nations will one day worship the gracious and powerful God (Psalm 86:8–10). Because of this hope, the psalmist commits himself to live in a right and honest way (Psalm 86:11) and to praise the Lord (86:12–13).

The final section contrasts the behavior of evil people with the character of the Lord (Psalm 86:14–17).

Psalms 86:5

The psalmist lists God's perfect qualities (Exodus 34:6–7), especially God's readiness to forgive sin (see Psalms 32:5; 85:2; 145:7–10).

Psalms 86:5–7

The psalmist appeals to God to remain true to his character, which is the basis for hope.

Psalms 86:8–10

All the nations must submit themselves to the Lord and worship him (Psalms 45:17; 117:1; 148:7–11).

Psalms 86:11

- The poet responds to the Lord by seeking faithful instruction in the truth.
- A person with an undivided heart has integrity and wholeness (see Psalm 73:1).

Psalms 86:12–13

In anticipation of God's rescue, the psalmist praises him and trusts in his goodness.

Psalms 86:14–17

Arrogant people exist both inside and outside the community. The psalmist asks God to show his character. God is so great that even a small glimpse of his goodness will silence the wicked.

Psalms 86:15

God shows mercy to his people (Psalm 51:1). God is compassionate (Psalm 25:6). God is slow to become angry (Psalms 103:8; 145:8). God is full of loving devotion and faithfulness (Hebrew khesed and 'emeth; Psalm 143:1)

This verse repeats a theme first expressed in Exodus 34:7; Numbers 14:18 (compare Psalms 103:8; 145:8; Nehemiah 9:17; Joel 2:13; Jonah 4:2).

Psalms 87:1

Jerusalem was Israel's capital and the location of the temple, God's earthly palace (see Psalm 84).

Psalms 87:1–7

This psalm presents Jerusalem as the city of God, where people from all nations are counted as citizens.

Psalms 87:4

- Zion is great, but it will be even greater as an international city where believers from all nations are citizens.
- God keeps a record of everyone who confesses him as their Lord (Daniel 7:10; Revelation 13:8).

Psalms 87:5–6

Jerusalem becomes the international city where all God's children are citizens.

Psalms 88:1

- A Maskil: This may be a literary or musical term.
- Heman the Ezrahite: Heman might have been:
- a wise person from the time of King Solomon (1 Kings 4:31),
- a descendant of Judah (1 Chronicles 2:6), or
- a member of the Levite family responsible for singing at the temple (1 Chronicles 15:17; 2 Chronicles 5:12).

Psalms 88:1–5

The psalmist calls on the Lord for salvation.

Psalms 88:1–18

In this lament, the psalmist sees himself as cast out from God's presence. At first, he calls on the Lord. When he finds no relief from his suffering, he presents three charges against God (Psalm 88:6–7, 8–12, 13–17).

Psalms 88:6–7

- In his first complaint, the psalmist blames the Lord for his suffering. God's overwhelming anger does not make sense to him.
- The phrase the darkest of the depths might refer to:
- the place of the dead (Psalm 143:3; see Lamentations 3:6), or
- the deep sea (Psalms 68:22; 69:1–2).

Psalms 88:8–12

In his second charge, the psalmist claims that God has isolated him and caused his loneliness (compare Psalms 31:11; 38:11). In that culture, loneliness was a curse because relationships mattered more than personal success.

Psalms 88:13–17

In his third charge, the psalmist accuses the Lord of rejecting him. The force and apparent cruelty of the psalmist's suffering overwhelm him.

Psalms 88:18

The psalmist restates his second and first charges.

Psalms 89:1

God's loving devotion gives reason to celebrate forever.

Psalms 89:1–52

Book Three (Psalms 73–89) starts and ends with serious questions. Psalm 89 begins with praise for how the Lord established David's throne and kingdom (89:1–37). But later the psalmist protests that the Lord seems to have rejected his covenant with David (Psalm 89:38–51; see 2 Samuel 7:8–16).

Psalms 89:title

Ethan the Ezrahite was a wise man (1 Kings 4:31; compare Psalm 88:1).

Psalms 89:3

The Lord has sworn by his own holiness (Psalm 89:35; see 110:4).

Psalms 89:3–4

The psalmist repeats God's covenant with David (see also Psalm 89:19–37).

Psalms 89:5

Those in heaven praise God's greatness (see Psalm 8:1) because they witness his faithfulness.

Psalms 89:5–8

God is the absolute standard of faithfulness, commitment, and order. The angelic beings and the heavens testify to his constancy.

Psalms 89:6

heavenly beings: Literally son of God (see study note on Psalm 29:1–2).

Psalms 89:9–10

- The Lord rules over all parts of the created order, including evil.
- You scattered Your enemies: The Lord will defeat (Luke 1:51) evil forces that oppose him (Psalm 2:1–3).
- with Your mighty arm: This phrase represents God's strength (Psalm 89:13).

Psalms 89:9–13

In this hymn, the psalmist celebrates God's complete and powerful rule over nature.

Psalms 89:12

Mount Tabor was in northern Israel. Mount Hermon formed the extreme northern border of the nation.

Psalms 89:14–18

God rules wisely over creation. The qualities of righteousness, justice, and faithfulness fit the description of a wise ruler. The happy people who live under his rule enjoy his protection.

Psalms 89:15–16

Those who are wise worship God, walk in his light, rejoice in their relationship with him, and delight in his character.

Psalms 89:17–18

The Lord protects his people with the same power by which he established the created order.

Psalms 89:19–37

The Lord chose David as his son and king of Israel (see Psalm 2:4–6; 2 Samuel 7:8–16) to protect his people.

Psalms 89:20

I have anointed him: This is the verb from which comes anointed one (Hebrew mashiakh, which means "messiah").

Psalms 89:26–29

The Lord adopted David as his son, appointed him as his commander over the nations, and promised to support him forever. Verse 26 recalls a verse from David's song of praise (2 Samuel 22:47).

Psalms 89:27

David would become the greatest of earthly kings. The Hebrew word translated highest is the same word used for God as "Most High" ('elyon).

Psalms 89:29

The Lord displays his faithfulness in the heavens, across his whole creation (see Psalm 89:2). In the same way, he confirms his commitment to the kings that would come from David's family.

Psalms 89:30–37

The Lord disciplines his children when they go astray, but he does not reject them. He knows they will break their trust and will need correction, yet he remains committed to keep his covenant. His faithfulness to David is like his faithfulness to the created world.

Psalms 89:35

holiness: The Lord is completely different from the created world (Psalm 22:3). His character is entirely pure. He acts according to his will (Psalm 115:3) and chooses to be faithful (89:1; 115:1). Therefore, he cannot lie.

Psalms 89:38

You are enraged: The psalmist is confused by the severity of God's anger.

Psalms 89:40

broken down all his walls: The Lord's people are completely vulnerable.

Psalms 89:42

Although the Lord promised to strengthen David, he has made David's enemies strong

Psalms 89:46–47

The psalmist wonders whether he will live long enough to see the Lord's anger end. Human life is short and passes quickly before the Lord (Psalm 90:4, 10).

Psalms 89:50

The phrase Your servants refers to the community loyal to the Lord.

Psalms 89:52

This doxology (a short praise to God) ends Book Three of the Psalms (Psalms 73–89). It was not meant to be read as part of Psalm 89. Its words of praise stand in strong contrast to the pain and questions expressed in Psalm 89. Compare Psalm 41:13; 106:48.

Psalms 90:1

- Moses led God's people from slavery in Egypt to Mount Sinai. There, he received the law and established God's covenant with Israel.
- the man of God: Moses had a special relationship with God (Deuteronomy 33:1).

Psalms 90:1–2

The Lord is the dwelling place for the godly. He has provided shelter for many generations. The word translated as dwelling place is rare in the Psalms. It describes a safe place where the Lord meets and cares for those in need (Psalms 68:5; 71:3).

Psalms 90:1–17

Although the Lord's people have lived in him for many generations, their sin creates distance between them and their eternal Lord. The Lord's anger against human sin can seem to last a lifetime. Even then, it is only a small sign of his full displeasure with sin. This sad situation leads the community to seek the Lord's light.

The first step is to ask the Lord to restore them because of his compassion and faithful love (Psalm 90:13–14). He alone can make his servants glad. He alone can bless the generations that come after them (Psalm 90:16–17).

Psalms 90:2

- The Lord is the eternal God.
- The Lord created the earth.

Psalms 90:3–6

Unlike God, humans are mortal and temporary.

Psalms 90:7–10

Sinners cannot escape God's anger against sin because the Lord sees their sins. Their lives pass quickly and are full of suffering.

Psalms 90:9–10

- A groan of sorrow (Ezekiel 2:10) represents a life facing the consequences of sin.
- Humans create trouble (see Psalm 10:6) and receive pain as a result.

Psalms 90:11–12

In the search for wisdom, no one can fully understand the Lord (see Isaiah 40:13). The right human response to the Lord is godly fear (see Psalm 60:4). The Lord alone can teach humans to follow the path of wisdom (Psalm 25:4–6).

Psalms 90:13

The phrase Your servants refers to the community of those loyal to the Lord.

Psalms 90:13–17

The psalmist prays for the Lord's favor and restoration.

Psalms 90:15

The psalmist calls upon the Lord to give the people gladness to replace their mourning (see Psalm 92:4–5).

Psalms 90:16

The children represent future generations in contrast to the generations past (Psalm 90:1).

Psalms 90:17

Humans waste their efforts unless the Lord makes them successful (Psalm 44:3).

Psalms 91:1

The Most High is an ancient title that expresses the Lord's exalted status as the ruler and protector of the godly (see Genesis 14:19).

Psalms 91:1–2

The Lord is an ancient shelter (see Psalm 90:1), open to those who seek refuge in him.

Psalms 91:1–16

This wisdom psalm expresses confidence in the Almighty God, who provides a shelter for those who take refuge in him. They receive redemption, life, and glory from the Lord, who loves and cares for those who seek him.

Psalms 91:3

God protects the godly from deadly disease and even a destructive word.

Psalms 91:3–4

The psalmist invites the godly to trust in the Lord and find protection in him.

Psalms 91:4

The shield might refer to a large shield that covers the body. The rampart likely refers to a smaller shield, though the exact meaning of the Hebrew word is uncertain.

Psalms 91:5–8

The godly should not be afraid, because the Lord watches over them. These promises do not guarantee an escape from trouble, but they create an expectation of the Lord's goodness.

Psalms 91:6

The word pestilence here means any kind of suffering or trouble.

Psalms 91:9–13

The poet again invites the godly to seek refuge in the Lord and enjoy the benefits of divine protection.

Psalms 91:11

He will command His angels: Satan quoted these words when he tempted Jesus (Matthew 4:6; Luke 4:10–11). However, God makes this promise for those who obey him (Psalm 91:14), not for those who arrogantly test him (Matthew 4:4, 7).

Psalms 91:14

Those who love the Lord will follow his commands (Deuteronomy 30:20; 1 John 5:3) and look for his protection (Psalms 91:1; 145:18).

Psalms 91:14–16

The godly can trust the Lord's protection and provision.

Psalms 91:15

- The Lord promises to answer the prayers of his people.
- The Psalms often mention people honoring the Lord (Psalm 50:15). Here, God promises to honor the faithful who risk everything for him (Psalms 62:7; 71:21; 84:11).

Psalms 91:16

A long life on earth represents just a small part of the Lord's goodness and eternal friendship (Psalm 23:6).

Psalms 92:1

In Jewish tradition, each day of the week has an assigned psalm:

- Sunday (Psalm 24)
- Monday (Psalm 48)
- Tuesday (Psalm 82)
- Wednesday (Psalm 94)
- Thursday (Psalm 81)
- Friday (Psalm 93)
- Saturday, which is the Sabbath (Psalm 92)

This is the only psalm that indicates this use in its title.

Psalms 92:1–3

The psalmist offers praise and thanksgiving for God's loving devotion and faithfulness.

Psalms 92:1–15

This psalm begins with thanksgiving and praise. The Lord, the Most High, is fair and just in judging the godly and the wicked. The godly will have a bright and strong future, while the wicked will die.

Wise people see and understand the Lord's actions, which show his justice (Psalm 92:6–7, 11, 15). The wicked, like grass, are quickly destroyed (Psalm 92:7–10).

Psalms 92:4–5

The Lord acts and the psalmist responds in praise (Psalm 92:4). God's actions come from his thoughts (Psalm 92:5).

Psalms 92:4–7

Fools perish because they do not understand the Lord's great works and his eternal plans.

Psalms 92:5–6

The Lord's thoughts confuse those who lack understanding or act foolishly, and those who do not seek wisdom (Proverbs 1:22; 10:23).

Psalms 92:7

Even when the ungodly appear to thrive (Psalm 73:3–5), they have no future (92:9; see 1:6; 90:5–6; Isaiah 40:6–8).

Psalms 92:8

The Lord is above the world of human experience. From this exalted place, he rules and judges (Psalm 7:7). From there, he:

- celebrates his victories (Psalm 68:18; see 47),
- comes to rescue the needy (Psalm 102:19),
- brings an end to the wicked (Psalm 92:7–8), and
- receives praise (Psalm 148:1).

Psalms 92:8–10

The glory of the Lord is the reason the poet receives new strength and honor. It is also the reason the enemy will soon be defeated.

Psalms 92:10

like that of a wild ox: The Lord allows the psalmist to express his joy (Psalm 92:8). Because of this, the psalmist is strong and will overcome his enemies.

Psalms 92:11–15

The psalmist understands the Lord's mighty acts. He shares in the glory of the wise of heart.

Psalms 92:12

Carvings of palm trees (1 Kings 6:29, 32, 35; 7:36) decorated the temple. Builders used many cedars (1 Kings 5:6). The trees represent the godly, who are planted in the very courts of the temple.

Psalms 92:13

The temple area consisted of the Lord's own house and the courts that surrounded it.

Psalms 92:15

in Him there is no unrighteousness: The Lord is always just. He rightly judges everyone (see Zephaniah 3:5).

Psalms 93:1

robed in majesty: The Lord stands victorious both before and after battle (see Psalm 45:3).

Psalms 93:1–5

The everlasting Lord gloriously establishes his kingship (see Psalms 47, 99–100).

Psalms 93:1–100.5

These psalms challenge the doubts created by the exile (see Psalm 89) and answer the questions asked in Psalm 90:11, 13. The Lord has established a kingdom (Psalm 93) that is characterized by:

- punishment of the wicked (Psalm 94),
- respectful obedience among his people (Psalm 95),
- justice for the poor (Psalm 96),
- celebration in Zion (Psalm 97),
- salvation for Israel (Psalm 98),
- holiness (Psalm 99), and
- praise (Psalm 100).

Psalms 93:3–4

God's victory over natural chaos gives the psalmist confidence that the Lord will also defeat his present enemies (compare Jeremiah 46:8; 47:2).

Psalms 93:5

- Through his stable rule and royal laws, the Lord orders the world.
- Your house: The house from which God reigns might be the Lord's heavenly palace or the earthly temple.

Psalms 94:1–7

After the community suffers at the hands of the wicked (Psalm 94:5–7), they pray for the Lord to bring justice (see Psalm 7:11; 9:12).

Psalms 94:1–23

This plea for the Lord's justice includes both communal and individual expressions of sorrow (Psalm 94:1–7, 16–23). The psalmist speaks about the pain and suffering caused by the wicked. He also describes the comfort and stability of the Lord's protection. He calls on the Lord to avenge the needy against the arrogant and foolish, he rebukes such people for their foolishness (Psalm 94:8–11), and speaks a blessing on the wise (94:12–15).

Psalms 94:2

When the Lord's enemies rise against him and his people (Psalm 3:7; 93:3), he must rise and punish the enemy (see 79:12; Isaiah 65:6).

Psalms 94:6

widow ... foreigner ... fatherless: The Lord's law protects those in need (Deuteronomy 24:17; 27:19), but they remain vulnerable in society.

Psalms 94:7

The wicked think that they can get away with their evil acts and speech, foolishly assuming that God is not looking or does not care.

Psalms 94:8–11

The writer of the psalm corrects people for acting foolishly.

Psalms 94:9

It makes no sense for people who have ears and eyes to think that their Creator is deaf and blind.

Psalms 94:10

discipline: This word can also mean "admonished" (Psalm 2:10), "discipline" (6:1; 94:12), or "instructs" (16:7). The Lord disciplines his people to improve their character (Proverbs 3:11–12; Hebrews 12:6–11). He punishes his enemies by giving them what they deserve (Psalm 1:6; Romans 6:23).

Psalms 94:11

While the Lord's thoughts are deep, people's thoughts are worthless (compare Psalm 92:5; 1 Corinthians 3:20).

Psalms 94:12–15

Because the Lord is faithful to his character, he rewards those who live by his wise instruction. He makes them happy, just as he promised.

Psalms 94:13

God's relief includes his comfort and rescue.

Psalms 94:14

Even when it seems that he has, the Lord will not reject his people.

Psalms 94:16

Only God has the power to stand up to the wicked (see Psalm 2:2).

Psalms 94:16–23

The psalmist resumes their prayer (see Psalm 94:1–7) with a desperate plea for the Lord's justice. It ends with the hope that evil will cease.

Psalms 94:18–19

The psalmist feels like he is slipping, but God promises to stand with him (Psalm 94:12–13; see 15:5; 93:1).

Psalms 95:1–11

This call to worship urges the people to respond to the Lord, the Shepherd, and to follow him faithfully. The previous generation, who refused to obey, did not receive the blessings of the promised land.

Psalms 95:3

above all gods: The psalmist argues against idol worship and pagan beliefs (Psalms 96:4–6; 135:15–18; see also Isaiah 46:5–7).

Psalms 95:3–5

The Lord is the great King over the whole universe.

Psalms 95:4–5

All creation exists because of the Lord alone, not because of many gods.

Psalms 95:6–7

- The great King cares for his people like a shepherd cares for sheep (Isaiah 40:11).
- The Lord, our Maker, the Creator of heaven and earth, also created a people for himself (Isaiah 45:9–12; 51:12–16).

Psalms 95:8

To harden your hearts means to be stubborn and resist the Lord's grace (see Numbers 20:2–13; see also Matthew 13:3–23; John 12:37–43; Ephesians 4:17–32; Hebrews 3:6–19; 4:6–11).

Psalms 95:8–11

If people want to enter into the Lord's rest, they need to respond immediately (see Hebrews 3:7–4:11).

Psalms 95:9

Israel's ancestors saw the Lord's wonders but did not understand their importance (see Psalm 92:5–6).

Psalms 95:11

- The generation of Israel that wandered in the wilderness for 40 years did not enter the place of rest that Israel enjoyed after conquering the land (1 Kings 8:56; see Deuteronomy 12:9). The Lord promised them the land and gave it to them (Isaiah 28:12), but they did not obey him (Isaiah 28:1). This warning reminds every generation of the need to obey with faith.
- The rest that God provides includes peace, provision, and protection (Psalm 132:14–18). The author of Hebrews challenged a new generation to enter the rest provided by Jesus Christ (Hebrews 3:7–4:13).

Psalms 96:1

Three psalms begin by urging people to sing a new song (Psalms 96, 98, 149). The song celebrates the Lord's universal kingship (see Psalm 33:3).

Psalms 96:1–13

- This psalm establishes the Lord's universal kingship (see Psalm 93) and prepares for the coming of the Lord to bring justice and righteousness to the world. The psalmist invites everyone to worship the Lord (Psalm 96:1–3), the glorious Creator of the earth (96:4–6), because only he deserves worship (96:7–9). The universe joins in praise as the righteous Judge establishes a new order (Psalm 96:10–13).
- This psalm (along with Psalm 105:1–15; 106:1, 47–48) is included in David's song of praise recorded in 1 Chronicles 16:1–43.

Psalms 96:4

great is the LORD ... greatly to be praised: The poet praises the Lord above all gods (Psalm 95:3) and nations (99:2). The Lord inspires more awe than anyone or anything else (Psalm 76:7, 12; 89:7; 99:3; 111:9). He is beyond human possession or comprehension. The story of what he does to redeem his people causes them to praise him.

Psalms 96:4–6

The gods of the nations are as nothing before the glorious and awesome Creator of the earth.

Psalms 96:5

The Lord made the heavens, an even greater task than creating the earth. The idols, made by human hands (Psalm 115:4), created nothing.

Psalms 96:6

Splendor and majesty: The Lord is glorious (Psalm 96:6; 104:1; 148:13), and so are his works in nature (8:1) and in redemption (111:3; 145:5).

Psalms 96:7

- families of the nations: Families and clans represent subdivisions of the nations (see Genesis 12:3).
- The nations must respond to the Lord's glory (Psalms 8:1; 19:1–4; 24:7).

Psalms 96:8

The courts of God's sanctuary were usually not open to non-Jewish people. In this psalm, the nations of the world (people who are not Jews) are invited to come in (Psalm 65:4; 84:2, 10; 100:4; 116:19; 135:2; Isaiah 1:12).

Psalms 96:9

Worshipers should tremble in awe (Psalm 96:4; see 18:7–15; 97:4) at the splendor of the Lord's great power and holiness (Hebrews 12:25).

Psalms 96:10

- The Lord's coming means the end of injustice. He rules fairly (Psalm 9:8; 96:13; 98:9). He brings a time of peace and order like the world has not known since Adam and Eve lived in the garden of Eden.

- The Lord's rule over the world stands on the strong pillars of "righteousness and justice" (Psalm 89:14), so it cannot be shaken (compare 11:3).

Psalms 96:11–13

The psalmist urges all of creation to respond with joy to the news of the Lord's coming. Compare a similar theme in Psalm 98:7–9.

Psalms 96:12

All of nature will experience renewal in God's presence (Psalms 65:13; 72:6, 16; Isaiah 44:23; 55:12; Romans 8:21–22).

Psalms 97:1

The distant shores represent the most remote parts of the world.

Psalms 97:1–12

God is greatly exalted over the gods and over all the earth. Awe-inspiring phenomena accompany his coming. Even the created order is visibly affected and the wicked perish, but the people of Zion love his coming and rejoice.

Psalms 97:2–4

Clouds ... Fire ... lightning: This language shows that the Lord is coming to judge.

Psalms 97:5–7

All creation responds to the coming of its King. He alone deserves worship.

Psalms 97:6

- When the Lord comes into the world, the heavens announce his righteousness (Psalm 50:6).
- Every nation will see the clear display of the Lord's glory (see Psalm 8:1; 19:1–4a; 24:7; Isaiah 40:5).

Psalms 97:7

At the Lord's coming, when every god must bow to him, those who worship other gods will face their own foolishness (see Psalm 95:3–5).

Psalms 97:8–12

Jerusalem rejoices at the news of the Lord's coming, for he brings justice and rescues the upright of heart.

Psalms 97:11

Godly people who live with integrity (see Proverbs 2:7, 21; 3:32; 11:6, 11; 14:2) have hearts that are right before the Lord. They maintain a relationship with the Lord and live rightly with others (Psalms 94:15; 125:4).

The wicked plan to destroy the godly (Psalm 11:2), but the Lord rescues them (11:1; 36:10). Then the sorrows of the godly turn into joy and praise (Psalms 32:11; 64:10; 111:1; 119:7).

Psalms 98:1–9

This psalm celebrates the Lord as King. The Lord is the true King of Israel, its champion and savior. His people sing a new song to celebrate his victory and his faithfulness to them.

The Lord shows his righteous rule to all the nations of the earth. One day, this will lead to a worldwide kingdom of justice (Psalm 98:2, 9). Because of this, all the earth should worship and rejoice together, for the Lord is coming (Psalm 98:4–6).

Psalms 98:2–3

The Lord makes known his righteousness and faithfulness (see also Isaiah 52:10).

Psalms 98:4–6

The psalmist invites the whole earth to worship the King (see Psalm 96:1).

Psalms 98:6

The temple musicians played trumpets to gather people for meetings (compare Psalm 81:3).

Psalms 98:7–9

The psalm speaks as if all creation rejoices when the righteous Judge comes (see Psalms 83:3–4; 96:11–13).

Psalms 99:1

- It is appropriate to tremble and quake in response to the Lord's holiness (see Psalm 96:9).
- The throne between the cherubim refers to the cover of the ark of the Testimony (Exodus 25:17–22).

Psalms 99:1–5

The Lord is the holy and righteous King (Isaiah 6:1–5). Mount Zion, where the temple of the Lord is located, metaphorically stands as the highest point on earth (Psalm 113:4; Isaiah 2:2; 6:1). From this high place, the "great King" (Psalm 47:2) can see, rule over, and receive praise from all nations and peoples.

Psalms 99:1–9

The psalmist calls the nations to worship the Lord, the king of the earth who rules from Zion.

Psalms 99:4

The qualities of the Lord's rule include:

- strength,
- justice,
- love,
- fairness, and
- righteousness (see Psalms 93:4; 97:2, 6–7, 12; 98:2–3, 9; 138:6).

Psalms 99:6

Moses and Samuel were great models and leaders who had prayed on behalf of the Lord's people (Exodus 32:31–32; 1 Samuel 12:23).

Psalms 99:6–8

God showed favor by responding to his people in the past, while holding sinners accountable.

Psalms 99:7

The Lord spoke to Moses and Aaron from the pillar of cloud (Exodus 33:9; Numbers 12:5–6). For a while, the people responded to the revelation.

Psalms 100:1–5

This psalm calls all nations to come to Jerusalem to worship the Lord and acknowledge his goodness to Israel.

Psalms 100:3

- The Lord is the one who determines who his people are.
- the sheep of His pasture: God will guide and protect his people (Psalm 23:1, 4).

Psalms 100:4

Gates and courts were part of the temple in Jerusalem.

Psalms 101:1–8

This song of praise expresses a commitment to live with integrity and to avoid evil. Jesus meets this ideal.

Psalms 101:2

- in my house: This commitment to integrity might refer to private life at home. Some interpreters see my house as the king's palace. The commitment would then refer to the policies of his administration.
- Living with integrity means choosing a wise lifestyle.

Psalms 101:4–5

- The psalmist hates what the Lord hates (Proverbs 6:16–19; see Psalms 5:5; 11:4–5).
- Perverse ideas come from corrupt human hearts (compare Psalm 18:26).

Psalms 101:6

The psalmist surrounds himself with people who are also committed to integrity (Psalm 101:2).

Psalms 101:7–8

The psalmist promises to remove all evil from his house and the city of the Lord, which represents the entire kingdom.

Psalms 102:1–2

The psalmist asks the Lord not to turn away (or hide your face). Israel experienced God turning his face away when they were exiled.

Psalms 102:1–28

A weak and suffering person prays for the Lord's mercy on Jerusalem and for his presence with its people.

Psalms 102:3

- Smoke is an image of the temporary nature of life (Psalms 37:20; 68:2).
- The psalmist's bones represent his whole being (see Psalms 6:2; 34:19–22).

Psalms 102:4

Like withered grass, the psalmist senses his life fading away.

Psalms 102:5

skin hangs on my bones: The psalmist has become very thin due to his deep sorrow (see Psalm 102:9; 109:24).

Psalms 102:6

Owls often live in deserted places, such as ruined cities. Because of this, the Bible sometimes uses the owl as a sign of ruin and desolation (Isaiah 34:11, 15).

Psalms 102:7–8

The psalmist cannot sleep (see Psalm 63:6–8). Like a lone bird on a housetop, he feels alone and separated from both friends (see Psalm 88:8) and enemies.

Psalms 102:10

The psalmist blames the Lord for his troubles.

Psalms 102:11

The psalmist feels that life is empty and short (Psalms 102:4; 109:23; 144:4).

Psalms 102:12

forever ... to all generations: Human life is short and fragile (Psalm 102:3–11). In contrast, the Lord remains forever and rules through every generation.

Psalms 102:12–17

The topic changes from the psalmist's troubles to the Lord's glory. A vision of the Lord's compassionate kingship gives him confidence in Zion's future.

Psalms 102:13

Now is the time for the Lord to restore Jerusalem from exile (see Psalm 75:2; Jeremiah 29:10; Daniel 9:1–19).

Psalms 102:15–16

When the Lord arises (Psalm 102:13), the nations will tremble with fear because they will see his glory (see Psalm 8:1; 19:1–4a; 24:7). Rebuilding Zion and the temple shows God's glory and fulfills this promise. An even greater fulfillment will come with the New Jerusalem (Revelation 21).

Psalms 102:17

The people of Israel were very poor and vulnerable (destitute) during the exile.

Psalms 102:18

Let this be written: The written record serves as a reminder of the Lord's goodness.

Psalms 102:18–22

The Lord will show mercy. Both Jews and Gentiles will worship him.

Psalms 102:19

His sanctuary refers to God's holy place in heaven (see Psalm 92:8–10).

Psalms 102:22

Many people (both Jews and non-Jews) will worship the Lord together (see Psalm 96:7, 9; 106:48; Isaiah 2:2–4; 43:10–13; 57:15; 60:3–7).

Psalms 102:23–28

Although the psalmist suffers in the present, he bases his hope for the future on the Lord's past faithfulness.

Psalms 102:24

The psalmist compares his short life (Psalm 102:23) to God's eternal existence (compare 90:4).

Psalms 102:25–27

- wear out like a garment: Unlike the eternal Creator, the created world will wear out like a piece of clothing (see Isaiah 40:28).
- The writer to the Hebrews describes this passage as having been addressed to Jesus, the Son (Hebrews 1:10–12).

Psalms 102:28

The Lord's presence provides the basis for the security and happiness of his people (Psalm 23:6).

Psalms 103:1–2

all that is within me, bless His holy name: Psalms 103 and 104 both start and end with this promise (103:1–2, 22; 104:1, 35; see also 146:1).

Psalms 103:1–6

The psalmist offers praise for the Lord's goodness.

Psalms 103:1–22

This psalm celebrates the Lord's perfection, compassion, forgiveness, and goodness.

Psalms 103:7–8

The Lord revealed himself to Moses in special ways to strengthen his relationship with his people (see Exodus 34:6–7; Numbers 14:18).

Psalms 103:9

If the Lord were to constantly accuse or remain angry forever, no one would be left (see Isaiah 54:7–8; 57:16).

Psalms 103:11–12

God's love and forgiveness have no limits and are complete.

Psalms 103:13

The Lord is like a father to his children. This idea is central to the teachings of Jesus about God's fatherhood (see Matthew 5:43–48; 6:1; 10:19–20; 12:50; Luke 6:36; 12:29–32; John 8:31–59; 15:1–8; see also 2 Samuel 7:14; Jeremiah 3:19; 31:9; Malachi 1:6; 2 Corinthians 6:16–18).

Psalms 103:14–16

The Lord compassionately cares for weak humans (see Psalm 37:2; 90:5; 92:7; 102:4; Isaiah 40:6–8).

Psalms 103:17–19

from everlasting to everlasting the loving devotion of the LORD extends: The Lord's kingdom is everlasting, so he commits himself to his people across many generations.

Psalms 103:18

To obey God means to be faithful and loyal to him.

Psalms 103:20–21

The psalmist urges the Lord's angels, servants, and messengers to praise the Lord.

Psalms 103:22

- God's kingdom extends over all things, so all things are called to praise the Lord.
- The last phrase is similar to Psalm 103:1–2.

Psalms 104:1

- Bless the LORD, O my soul!: Psalms 103 and 104 both begin and end with this commitment to praise (103:1–2, 22; 104:1, 35).
- You are very great: These words praise God for rescuing his people (see also Psalms 35:27; 40:16; 70:4).

Psalms 104:1–35

This creation hymn (see also Psalms 8, 33, 145) praises God's goodness and greatness. The psalmist thinks about the current world, the original creation, and a future new creation. He views both creations as wonderfully and wisely made (compare Psalm 139:14), as the work of the Lord's Spirit (104:30; Genesis 1:2; 2 Corinthians 3:6).

Psalms 104:2–4

The psalmist refers to two days of creation (see Genesis 1:1–8), when God created the heavens and the light.

Psalms 104:3

This poetic description pictures the clouds as beams that support the heavens.

Psalms 104:4

- Wind and lightning (flames of fire) are described as God's messengers. The Lord controls the wind, rain, and storms and uses them as he desires (Psalm 77:17–18; 78:26; 135:7; 148:5–6).
- The psalmist refers to the third day of creation (Genesis 1:9–13). The Lord is master of water and earth.

Psalms 104:6

At first, water covered the earth.

Psalms 104:7

The Lord created dry ground on day three of creation (Genesis 1:9–13).

Psalms 104:8

The earth was made because God willed it.

Psalms 104:9

The Lord set a firm boundary for the seas to protect the land. This shows that the Lord rules both the sea and the land. This idea also challenged the beliefs of the Canaanites, who celebrated Baal as the god who defeated the sea (see Psalm 29).

Psalms 104:9–10

The Lord rules over all waters, including seas, rivers, and springs on the land. He brought order to the waters that were once chaotic. As a result, the earth became a rich place for animals and people. Water refreshes the ground and provides life for birds and other animals.

Psalms 104:11–18

The psalmist celebrates animal, plant, and human life, as well as the Lord's abundant provision for all of it (Genesis 1:9–30).

Psalms 104:14

for man to cultivate: People are the managers of the created order, and they receive nourishment from the work of their hands.

Psalms 104:15

Both wine and olive oil can be misused (compare Proverbs 21:17), but the Lord gives them as gifts to im-

prove life. Life is sustained by basic food, represented by bread.

Psalms 104:17–18

- The storks migrated from northern Europe and stayed in Palestine during the winter.
- rock badgers: These animals are about the size of a rabbit and live in rocky areas.

Psalms 104:19

- the moon to mark the seasons: Ancient Israel based its calendar on the cycles of the moon.
- the sun knows when to set: This poetic description reflects what people normally see. The sun goes down at a regular time each evening.

Psalms 104:19–23

The psalmist rejoices in the order of night and day, marking day four of creation (Genesis 1:14–19). This cycle gives all creatures an opportunity to live.

Psalms 104:20–23

Cycles of darkness and dawn mark the days on earth.

Psalms 104:24–26

The Lord's works testify to his wisdom. All parts fit together (land and sea, night and day, land creatures and sea creatures). The Lord's wisdom makes life orderly and wonderful.

Psalms 104:25

teeming with creatures beyond number: The ocean is full of all kinds of life (see Genesis 1:20–21). This shows the Lord's creative work.

Psalms 104:26

- ships pass: Commercial ships used for sea trade were one of the wonders of the ancient Near East (see Isaiah 2:16; 23:1, 3).
- Leviathan: The psalmist describes this feared sea creature as something the Lord created and controls.

Psalms 104:27–30

All living things depend on the Lord, who provides what they need and who has power over life and death (compare Matthew 6:11).

Psalms 104:29–30

When You send Your Spirit: Life on earth is only possible as the Lord's gift, symbolized by his breath (Hebrew ruakh, which means "breath, wind, or spirit"). The Lord's Spirit is the agent of renewal (Isaiah 32:15–20).

Psalms 104:31

The Lord reveals his presence in the created order (see Psalms 8:1; 19:1–4; 24:7) and delights in his new creation (see Isaiah 65:19).

Psalms 104:31–35

The psalmist moves from describing the known creation to anticipating the new creation, when the Lord will renew the created order into a world without sinners.

Psalms 104:32

The trembling earth and the smoking mountains represent the Lord's coming in judgment against sinners and salvation for his faithful people (see Psalm 18:7–15).

Psalms 104:35

- The Lord will remove all forms of evil that defile his creation.
- The final phrase returns to the opening words of Psalm 104:1 (see also 103:1–2, 22; 146:1).

Psalms 105:1–5

The poet begins with a call to give thanks (see also Psalms 106:1; 107:1; 118:1; 136:1). The other psalms continue with the refrain "for He is good!" The rest of Psalm 105 tells of God's goodness.

Psalms 105:1–45

- This hymn praises the Lord's faithfulness to Abraham and his descendants in all their journeys:
- from Ur to Canaan (Psalm 105:12),
- to Egypt (Psalm 105:17, 23),
- through the wilderness (Psalm 105:37, 41), and
- back to Canaan (Psalm 105:44).

These events fulfilled the Lord's promise to Abraham (Psalm 105:9, 42), which was the basis for Israel's very existence. Joseph, whose suffering turned into glory, serves as a model of encouragement for Israel (Psalm 105:16–25).

- Psalm 105:1–15 (along with 96; 106:1, 47–48) is included in David's song of praise recorded in 1 Chronicles 16.

Psalms 105:6–11

The story of Israel is based on the Lord's commitment to Abraham. Even when a question arises about the future of God's covenant with David (Psalm 89), God's covenant with Abraham stands, as does the spiritual bond between God and Israel, Abraham's descendants.

Psalms 105:8

The covenant is the Lord's unbreakable promise to be the Father of Abraham and his descendants (see Genesis 12:1–9; 15:1–21).

Psalms 105:11

God promised the land of Canaan to Abraham's descendants as their special possession. They could live there as God's people (Psalm 105:44–45; Genesis 12:7; 15:7–21).

Psalms 105:12–15

The Lord protected Israel's patriarchs, the early fathers of the nation.

Psalms 105:15

Abraham was one of the nation's prophets (Genesis 20:7).

Psalms 105:16–22

These verses tell the story of Joseph (see Genesis 37–41).

Psalms 105:19

- his prediction: Literally, his word.
- the word of the LORD proved him right: See Genesis 39:6–12.

Psalms 105:23

Egypt (Hebrew Mitsrayim) is called the land of Ham.

Psalms 105:23–25

These verses describe Israel's suffering in Egypt (see Exodus 1:1–14).

Psalms 105:26–36

The psalmist tells the story of Moses and the plagues in Egypt (see Exodus 7:20–12:30).

Psalms 105:37

none ... stumbled: The Lord protected all of his people (compare Psalm 9:3).

Psalms 105:37–45

The exodus and the conquest of Canaan fulfilled God's promise to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob (Psalm 105:9–10). Unlike Psalm 78, the poet describes the Lord's goodness without mentioning Israel's history of rebellion (compare Psalm 106).

Psalms 105:39

The Lord's presence was as evident to all as a fire in the darkness (Exodus 13:22).

Psalms 105:42–45

The story of redemption is also the story of the Lord's faithfulness.

Psalms 105:44

Canaan was a land of pagan nations (see Psalm 111:6). The psalmist might also be thinking about God's promise to Abraham (Genesis 24:60) regarding the lands given to Isaac (Genesis 26:3).

Psalms 105:45

The Lord planned for Israel to show who he is by obeying him. Israel was to be his example among the nations.

Psalms 106:1

Hallelujah! is a Hebrew word (haleluyah) that means "Praise the Lord." This phrase appears in four small groups in the psalms:

- Psalm 104–106
- Psalm 111–113
- Psalm 115–117
- Psalm 146–150

Psalms 106:1–48

- The Israelite community in exile confessed the Lord's goodness and justice and their own past sins. From their humble state in exile, they asked for redemption and restoration. They hoped to be gathered back from all the places the Lord had scattered them in his anger.

The psalm ends with a memory of the Lord's past mercy and hope for renewed mercy (Psalm 106:44–48). Israel failed, but the Lord remains constant.

- Verses 1, 47–48 (along with Psalms 96; 105:1–15) are included in David's song of praise recorded in 1 Chronicles 16:1–43.

Psalms 106:2–3

Wise people who practice justice and righteousness receive encouragement to proclaim the Lord's great acts.

Psalms 106:4–5

The poet prays individually for the Lord's favor before leading the community confession that follows.

Psalms 106:6

The story of Israel's redemption includes their sinful actions from the time of their ancestors to now (Psalm 106:43). The themes of sin and God's anger towards sin start and end Book Four (Psalms 90:1–9; 106:6, 23, 43).

Psalms 106:6–13

The community joins together to confess their sins and their ancestors' many acts of unbelief.

Psalms 106:9

Red Sea: See Exodus 14:15–31.

Psalms 106:13

they ... failed to wait: God's impatient people did not trust him to work according to his will (for example, see Exodus 15:24; 16:2–3; 17:1–3; Numbers 14:26–45; 21:4–9).

Psalms 106:15

He ... sent a wasting disease: See Exodus 32:35 and Numbers 11:33.

Psalms 106:16–18

- The people became jealous because they wanted the same role as the priests God had chosen (see Numbers 16:1–35).
- The earth opened up: See Numbers 16:28–33.

Psalms 106:19–23

they ... worshiped a molten image: The people forgot their Savior and worshiped idols (see Exodus 32:1–6).

Psalms 106:22

the land of Ham: This means Egypt (Psalm 106:21).

Psalms 106:24–25

- The people disobeyed God's command when they refused to enter the pleasant land (the promised land (see Jeremiah 3:19).
- they did not believe His promise: See Numbers 13:25–14:12.

Psalms 106:26–27

God's judgment when Israel refused to obey was death and exile (Numbers 14:26–30). These judgments came because the people rejected God's word (Psalm 106:24–25) and provoked the Lord's anger (106:28–46).

Psalms 106:28

they yoked themselves to Baal of Peor: See Numbers 25:3; Deuteronomy 4:3.

Psalms 106:28–39

When the Israelites entered the land, they brought their idol worship with them. Their behavior stayed the same, and they angered the Lord with their actions.

Psalms 106:30–33

Phinehas killed an Israelite man who openly turned away from the Lord (Numbers 25:3–8). Because his action stopped the plague, the psalm credits him with righteousness. In this psalm he is presented as a stronger example of zeal for the Lord than Moses, who failed at Meribah (Numbers 20:11–13).

Psalms 106:34

Israel continued to disobey the word of the Lord while living in the promised land. Instead of destroying the nations, Israel accepted them and their customs (see Judges 2:1–3, 11–15; 3:5–6).

Psalms 106:37

The gods of other nations were really demons (see Deuteronomy 32:17).

Psalms 106:39

Idolatry is like adultery. Both make God's people unclean before the Lord (see Leviticus 18:24; Hosea 5:3).

Psalms 106:40

God hated Israel's sin, just as he hates all sin.

Psalms 106:40–46

The psalmist again talks about the Babylonian exile (Psalm 106:26–27). The Lord judged Israel harshly, but he also restrained his anger, remembering the covenant he had made with Abraham.

Psalms 106:43–44

When Israel fell, the destruction was not complete. The Lord had compassion on his people and left a remnant (a small group of people who remained).

Psalms 106:45

He remembered ... and relented: Unlike Israel, the Lord is faithful to his covenant (Psalm 105:8).

Psalms 106:46

Even though the exile was harsh, the Lord still protected his people (see 2 Kings 25:27–29).

Psalms 106:47

gather us: The community prays for God to bring them back from exile (see Psalms 102:19–22; 107:3; see also Isaiah 11:12; 40:11; 43:5; 54:7; 56:8; 66:18).

Psalms 106:48

- This doxology (a short song of praise) ends Book Four (compare Psalms 41:13; 89:52).
- from everlasting to everlasting: The reference to God's eternal nature links to the opening of Book Four (Psalm 90:1–2).
- Let all the people say, "Amen!": The Hebrew word 'amen means "It is true." The faithful accept the Lord's will during exile and his promise to be their God.

Psalms 107:1–43

This psalm is a hymn of praise to God the Redeemer. The psalmist begins by urging the redeemed to praise God for his goodness (Psalm 107:1–3). The psalmist then presents four examples of people whom the Lord saved from trouble (Psalm 107:4–32). He summarizes the Lord's control over everything (Psalm 107:33–42) and ends with an invitation to recognize God's loving devotion in all parts of life (107:43).

Psalms 107:2

The redeemed might be all who came out of exile.

Psalms 107:3

People came from all nations where the people of Israel and Judah had been scattered.

Psalms 107:4–9

Those who were lost in the desert wastelands thank God for his rescue. The desert wastelands might be a metaphor for leaving the path of wisdom (Psalm 1:1; Proverbs 4:10–15).

Psalms 107:6

The psalmist does not say what caused his trouble and distress. Because the problem is not specific, people in many different situations can identify with the laments.

Psalms 107:7–8

- God led them like a shepherd (see Psalm 23:1).
- Verse 8 is repeated in Psalm 107:15, 21, 31.

Psalms 107:10–16

The psalmist calls for thanksgiving and praise from people in despair over the consequences of their rebellion.

Psalms 107:11

God's counsel includes his instruction and will.

Psalms 107:12

Exhausted from their hard work (Lamentations 5:13), the people stumbled. While this might be expected of the wicked (Psalms 9:3; 27:2), it was different from the Israelites' escape from Egypt (105:37).

Psalms 107:17–22

Fools who received what they deserved but were rescued from death offer thanksgiving to the Lord.

Psalms 107:20

The Lord creates (Genesis 1:3) and sustains the universe (Hebrews 1:3) simply by speaking (Psalm 147:18). When God speaks, people are also healed (Matthew 8:8).

Psalms 107:23–32

Sailors give thanks to the Lord when he saves them from the chaos and peril of the sea.

Psalms 107:25–29

The same God who speaks and brings about the sailors' distress can also calm the storm with just a word (compare Jonah 1:4; Matthew 8:26).

Psalms 107:32

This call for public praise expands on the repeated phrases in Psalms 107:21–22 and 107:31.

Psalms 107:33–35

The Lord can choose to make the earth fertile or barren (Psalm 74:15; Isaiah 35:6–7).

Psalms 107:33–42

These two sections (Psalm 107:33–38, 39–42) expand the theme of the Lord's complete authority and power over things that humans cannot control.

Psalms 107:38

God's presence can be seen in the abundance of his people's families and herds (Psalms 127:3; 133:3; compare 109:8).

Psalms 107:39

People often become poor when their leaders are oppressive.

Psalms 107:40

The Lord rejects human rulers who act unjustly. He corrects their wrongdoing and brings justice on the earth.

Psalms 107:41

The large families of the poor are evidence of God's blessing.

Psalms 107:42–43

Justice wins in God's world (Psalm 1:6), and Israel's history shows God's loving devotion.

Psalms 108:1–13

This psalm combines two parts from David's other psalms (compare Psalms 57:5, 7–11; 60:5–12).

Psalms 109:1

The psalmist finds no evidence that God cares (see Psalm 28:1).

Psalms 109:1–31

The psalmist starts this lament by accusing his accusers of repaying good with evil (Psalm 109:1–5). At the end of the psalm, he prays to the Lord, seeking protection (Psalm 109:21–25) and vengeance (109:26–31).

Psalms 109:4–5

The psalmist shows kindness and godliness (see Psalm 35:12–14), but faces stubborn opposition and hatred.

Psalms 109:6–19

The NLT translates these verses as the words of the psalmist's accusers; Hebrew lacks They say, which makes it unclear who is speaking.

Psalms 109:8

The wicked person apparently held a position of leadership. Peter referred to this psalm in regard to Judas Iscariot (Acts 1:20–26).

Psalms 109:8–11

Family members of people guilty of capital crimes sometimes died with the offender (Numbers 16:1–33; Joshua 7:1–25) or had their property taken away (1 Kings 21:13–16).

Psalms 109:13

If one's family name was blotted out, it meant there was no offspring to continue the family name or remember its history (see Proverbs 10:7).

Psalms 109:14

Children share in the sinful condition of their parents (Psalm 51:5; Exodus 20:5; Ephesians 2:3). The speaker asks the Lord to punish this guilty person also for the sins of his family who lived before him (compare Matthew 23:35–36).

Psalms 109:16

The defendant committed very serious crimes that carried the death penalty and did not show even basic decency.

Psalms 109:18

Cursing is the accused person's whole way of life.

Psalms 109:20

The psalmist asks God to act fairly and give people what they deserve (see Psalm 94:23).

Psalms 109:21

The Lord's reputation is important. If the wicked win, people might think the Lord is also wicked and be tempted to act wickedly (Psalm 1:1).

Psalms 109:21–25

Feeling vulnerable and miserable, the psalmist asks his Lord for help. The accusations have crushed his spirit and drained his physical strength.

Psalms 109:23

A lengthening shadow suggests a temporary, empty life (Psalms 102:11; 144:4). A single locust can be easily brushed off clothing.

Psalms 109:26–31

These verses form a prayer for God's presence and for vindication. The psalmist wants everyone to see that he is vindicated by the Lord, not by any human agent.

Psalms 109:28

The Lord's servant demonstrates loyalty and obedience.

Psalms 109:29

The psalmist was accused of being clothed with disgrace (Psalm 109:18). Now, he asks that his accusers wear their shame like a piece of clothing.

Psalms 110:1

- The king of Israel had the great privilege of being the Lord's adopted son (Psalm 2; 1 Chronicles 22:10), but he failed (Psalm 89). This decree restores and elevates his position.
- The LORD: This title represents the Hebrew name Yahweh, which is God's personal name (see Exodus 3:6–14; 6:2–8; 20:2).
- my Lord: The Hebrew word 'adoni means "my master" or "my superior." The psalmist understood God's messianic ruler (the king chosen by God) to be greater than himself. The New Testament often quotes this psalm to show that Jesus is the Messiah (Matthew 22:44–45; Mark 12:36–37; Luke 20:42–44; Acts 2:34–35; Hebrews 1:13).
- The Lord's right hand represents his authority, strength, presence, and benefits. The Lord chose the descendant of David and raised him up to be close to him (Psalm 80:17).

Jesus claimed this position for himself (Matthew 26:64; Mark 14:62; 16:19; Luke 22:69), and the apostles announced that Jesus, having gone up to heaven, sits at the right hand of the Father (Acts 2:33; 5:31; 7:55–56; Romans 8:34; Ephesians 1:20; Colossians 3:1; Hebrews 1:3; 8:1; 10:12; 12:2).

- Ancient Near Eastern kings were sometimes shown placing their feet on the backs of their defeated enemies as on a footstool (see Hebrews 10:12–13).

Psalms 110:1–7

Jesus and the apostles quote this psalm to explain the unique role and authority of Jesus as the Messiah (Matthew 22:43–45; Acts 2:32–36). The psalm also confirms God's covenant with David. It gives hope that God will fulfill his promise in the future (see 2 Samuel 7:8–16).

Psalms 110:2–3

The kingdom will expand and increase, beginning from Jerusalem, until all enemies are conquered.

Psalms 110:4

- God had made an unbreakable oath and covenant with David. When the exile seemed to end the line of kings from David's family (Psalm 89:38), it created a crisis for God's people. The placement of Psalm 110 in Book Five points again to the future of David's line. David's descendant must live according to God's standard of integrity (Psalm 101). His rule will also be shaped by God's kingship (Psalms 93–100).
- You are a priest forever: The role of God's messianic ruler changes. The kings from David's family had a limited priestly role. They supported and organized the worship of the temple. For example, David brought the ark to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6:15) and organized temple services (1 Chronicles 6:31–48; 15:11–26; 16:4–42; 23:4–32; 25:1). Solomon oversaw the construction of the temple (1 Kings 5:1–7:51).

Even so, the offices of king and priest were separate in Israel. In the messianic kingdom, the king will also serve as a priest. He will be like Melchizedek, the king of Salem who was also a priest (Genesis 14:18). The New Testament explains that Jesus Christ fulfills this new order of priesthood (see Hebrews 5:6–10; 6:20–7:25).

Psalms 110:5–6

- at Your right hand: This position brings help and protection (see Psalms 16:7–8; 108:13).
- The Lord will strike down rebellious kings. Rebellion against the Lord leads to death (Psalm 2; Romans 6:23).

Psalms 110:5–7

The new priestly role of David's descendant does not cancel his old role as a conquering ruler. He still needs to bring the nations under his rule (Psalm 110:2–3; see Psalm 2).

Psalms 110:7

God's messianic ruler wins victory with renewed strength, like a traveler who drinks from streams along the way (Psalm 110:3).

Psalms 111:1–5

The godly praise God and delight themselves in his great works. His mighty acts reflect his righteousness,

grace, and compassion (see Psalm 116:5–7). All who submit themselves to him experience his glory.

Psalms 111:1–10

This wisdom psalm contains many references to the works of the Lord that reveal his character. God is:

- righteous,
- gracious,
- compassionate,
- faithful,
- just,
- trustworthy,
- upright,
- holy, and
- awe-inspiring (Psalm 111:3, 4, 7, 8, 9).

God's character gives hope in the covenant relationship (Psalm 111:5). God rescued Israel from Egypt (Psalm 111:9). God gave them the land (111:6). God provides for his people (111:5). However, God expects those in this relationship to also be righteous and have integrity.

Psalms 111:1–117.2

The word Hallelujah! is repeated throughout this group of psalms.

Psalms 111:5

God takes care of his people's needs, even providing food. He remembers his covenant with Abraham (see Psalm 105:8–11).

Psalms 111:6–8

Giving Israel the land of other nations was just and good. The Lord was judging those nations and showing grace to Israel. However, if the Israelites do not live faithfully and with integrity, they will also lose the land. The Lord's people must reflect his character.

Psalms 111:9

The people of the exodus generation went free because of God's grace.

Psalms 111:10

True wisdom is the source of life (Proverbs 3:18; 9:11; Ecclesiastes 7:12). It starts with the fear of the Lord (Proverbs 9:10).

Psalms 112:1–5

The fear of the Lord leads to a wise life that honors God and brings blessing to the family and the community. The godly follow God with joy. Their obedience does not come from fear like a slave obeying a master.

Psalms 112:1–10

This psalm repeats the themes of wisdom and the fear of the Lord (Psalm 111). Wise people have reasons to be happy (Psalm 112:1–5) and strong (112:6–10).

Psalms 112:2–3

blessed: Everyone will recognize the children of godly people (see Psalm 127:4) because the godly leave a legacy for their children (see 1:3; compare Matthew 6:20).

Psalms 112:4–5

Godly people imitate God by being generous, compassionate, and righteous (Psalms 51:1; 111:1–10; 2 Corinthians 9:9). They lend money to the poor without charging interest (Psalms 15:5; 112:9; Exodus 22:25).

Psalms 112:6

The wise avoid mistakes because they are honest and compassionate (Psalms 15:5; 37:23–24). People will remember them for a long time (Proverbs 10:7).

Psalms 112:8

Because the godly trust that God will rescue them and give them victory, they face their enemies with confidence (Psalms 59:10; 112:4; 118:7).

Psalms 112:9

Paul quotes this verse in his instructions about generous giving (2 Corinthians 9:9).

Psalms 112:10

- The wicked gnash their teeth in anger due to their bitter envy (Psalms 35:16; 37:12). The strength and reputation of the godly create conflict with those who wish them harm.
- The wicked will retreat in fear and shame.

Psalms 113:1–3

the name of the LORD: God's personal name (Hebrew Yahweh; see Exodus 3:15) reveals who he is (his nature, character, and reputation). He is exalted at all times (now and forever) and in every place (from east to west).

Psalms 113:1–9

This song of praise celebrates the greatness of the Lord's name and glory. God is exalted and glorious in

heaven (Psalm 113:4). He also stoops down to care for the lowly and needy on earth (Psalm 113:5–9).

Psalms 113:1–118.29

These psalms are called the Egyptian Hallel. Hallel means "praise." Jewish people use these psalms during Passover, which began when God brought Israel out of Egypt in the exodus. The people recite Psalms 113–114 before the Passover meal, and Psalms 115–118 are recited afterward.

Psalms 113:4

The Lord's glory extends to the heavens (Psalms 57:5, 11; 99:2; 108:5; 138:6; Isaiah 6:1; 57:15) and throughout the world of human relationships.

Psalms 113:5–9

The Lord is unlike anyone else, yet he personally cares for people on earth.

Psalms 113:6

The Lord humbles himself to connect directly with his people (see Psalm 138:6; Philippians 2:6–8).

Psalms 113:7–8

These phrases are a quotation from Hannah's prayer of praise (1 Samuel 2:8–9a).

Psalms 113:9

- People in this culture often treated a woman without children with shame or contempt (Genesis 16:4). But the Lord has the power to make her a happy mother. For example:
- Sarah (Genesis 21:2),
- Rebekah (Genesis 25:21),
- Rachel (Genesis 30:23), and
- Hannah (1 Samuel 1:20).
- God's greatness and goodness give people many reasons to praise him.

Psalms 114:1–2

- At the time of Israel's exodus from Egypt and their entrance into the promised land, Israel was one holy kingdom (Exodus 19:5–6).
- The mention of Judah and Israel as separate lands shows the psalm was written after the kingdom was divided (1 Kings 12:16–17; compare 1 Samuel 11:8; 1 Kings 1:35), and probably after the exile. Judah became God's sanctuary because the people worshiped God there. His tabernacle, and later his temple, were located there.

Psalms 114:1–8

This song celebrates the Lord's power in nature. It remembers Israel's start as a nation during the exodus (Psalm 114:1–2) and their entry into the promised land (114:3–6). It encourages respect for the God of Jacob (Psalm 114:7–8).

Psalms 114:3–4

- fled: God parted the waters so that Israel could escape Egypt (Psalm 77:17–18; Exodus 14).
- The Jordan River turned back when Israel arrived to cross it (see Joshua 3).
- skipped like rams: God's presence made the mountains quake (Exodus 19:16–20).

Psalms 114:8

The Lord miraculously provided for his people in hard times after the exile, just as he had done in the wilderness after the exodus.

Psalms 115:1–3

The community confesses their faith that God will rescue them for the glory of his name.

Psalms 115:1–18

This is a song of thanksgiving for God's blessings. The community gives all glory to the Lord, the true source of hope and blessing. Those who trust in idols feel great disappointment. The Creator's blessing extends to future generations (Psalm 115:14), especially to the priests (115:12).

Psalms 115:2–3

Where is their God?: People question God's presence or power when he does not act as they expect (compare Psalms 14:1; 42:3, 10). However, God is in the heavens. He has all power, authority, and knowledge. He does as he wishes, not what people think he should do. He carries out his plans according to his will (Ephesians 1:11) and acts in his own time and ways.

Psalms 115:4–11

- This entire section is repeated in Psalm 135:15–20.
- Unlike the Lord (Psalm 95:3–5), idols cannot do anything. They are useless.

Psalms 115:8

Worshiping idols leads one astray and corrupts those who trust in them (Isaiah 44:20).

Psalms 115:9–11

Israel ... O house of Aaron ... You who fear the LORD: The psalmist urges everyone in the God-fearing community to trust in the living God. This threefold address assures them that the Lord is their true helper and shield (compare Psalm 118:2–4).

Psalms 115:12–13

The groups mentioned in Psalm 115:9–11 receive assurance of the Lord's blessing, no matter their social status (see 113:8).

Psalms 115:14–15

- The psalmist blesses (Psalm 107:37–38, 41) all who trust in and fear the Lord. The Creator will care for the families of those who fear him.
- the Maker of heaven and earth: This phrase speaks about how the Lord created everything and has power over all creation.

Psalms 115:16–18

- The highest heavens belong to the LORD: God's exaltation starts in heaven (Psalm 113:4), far above the gods of other nations. The earth also belongs to him (Psalm 47:9; 95:4).
- The dead cannot participate in God's blessings. The living praise God in thanksgiving for his blessings (Psalm 79:13).

Psalms 116:1

I love the LORD: This unique opening expresses affection for and commitment to the Lord (see Psalm 18:1; Deuteronomy 6:5) on the basis of what the Lord has done.

Psalms 116:1–4

The psalmist praises the Lord for answering his prayers and rescuing him from death.

Psalms 116:1–19

This song of thanksgiving rejoices in God's character and in rescue from death (Psalm 116:1–11). It gives an assurance of God's protection in life and reminds the godly that the Lord watches over them even at death. The psalmist commits to living as God's servant and resolves to honor him publicly (Psalm 116:12–19).

Psalms 116:2

Because the Lord responds to the cry of his people(Psalm 107:41; 113:6–8), the psalmist now strongly believes in prayer.

Psalms 116:3

It is not clear if the psalmist's crisis was a literal near-death experience or if he was using the term figuratively.

Psalms 116:4

This is the first of three times that the psalmist calls on the Lord's name (which represents God's reputation).

Psalms 116:5–7

The gracious, righteous, and compassionate Lord (see Psalm 111:1–5) rescued and gave rest to the psalmist.

Psalms 116:6

People with childlike faith readily receive God's wisdom and instruction (Psalm 19:7–11; Matthew 18:3–4).

Psalms 116:8–11

The psalmist's near-death crisis made him more aware of life and of walking before the Lord. Though he had suffered, the Lord was faithful. However, people are all liars.

Psalms 116:9

I will walk before the LORD: The psalmist lived with integrity. After experiencing deep distress, he now enjoys open fellowship with the Lord (see Psalm 56:13; compare Job 42:5).

Psalms 116:10

I believed: Paul quotes this phrase in 2 Corinthians 4:13.

Psalms 116:12–14

- The Lord's gracious gifts are so great that the psalmist can do nothing to repay his debt. Keeping his promises publicly demonstrates his gratitude.
- All he has done for the psalmist includes answers to prayer, rescue, and life.
- The cup of salvation overflows with God's blessings (Psalm 23:5), unlike the cup of judgment (75:8).
- The psalmist makes vows (Psalm 116:18) to praise the Lord publicly (116:17–18).

Psalms 116:15–19

No one lives or dies outside of God's will. Having been given a second chance at life, the poet readily commits himself to the Lord with renewed acts of public devotion.

Psalms 117:1

Paul quotes this verse to show that Gentiles would eventually praise the God of Israel (Romans 15:11).

Psalms 117:1–2

This psalm is the shortest in the Psalter. It invites all people of the earth to praise the Lord for his loving devotion and faithfulness.

Psalms 118:1–29

The psalmist joyfully thanks the Lord for his goodness and urges others to trust in his loving devotion (Psalm 118:1–4, 29). This poem is the last of the Egyptian Hallel (Psalms 113–118).

Psalms 118:2–4

Israel ... the house of Aaron ... those who fear the LORD: These three groups represent the entire covenant community (compare Psalms 115:9–11; 135:19–20).

Psalms 118:5–9

The Lord alone is the psalmist's helper.

Psalms 118:6–7

- The LORD is on my side: Compare Romans 8:31; Hebrews 13:6.
- God's presence removes the need to fear people (Psalm 56:11). The psalmist joyfully expects God's rescue (Psalm 59:10; Psalm 112:8).

Psalms 118:8–9

Trusting in the Lord is better than placing confidence in even the most powerful human leaders (Psalms 118:6; 146:3).

Psalms 118:10–12

- Strength comes from the name of the LORD. This is shown by the threefold repetition of the attackers, the name of the LORD, and the victory he gives.
- Even when hostile people surrounded the psalmist, the Lord extinguished them like burning thorns (see Isaiah 9:18; 10:17).

Psalms 118:14–18

The psalmist celebrates the victory of the Lord's strong right hand, which kept him from death.

Psalms 118:17–21

God has restored the psalmist from death to life, so he praises the Lord publicly (see Psalm 116:6, 12–19).

Psalms 118:22

The cornerstone shapes and supports a building or arch. It is the most important of all the stones. The Lord selects and places this stone for his sanctuary (Isaiah 28:16).

Jesus referred to himself as this cornerstone (Matthew 21:42; Mark 12:10–11; Luke 20:17; see Acts 4:11; Ephesians 2:20; 1 Peter 2:6–7).

Psalms 118:22–24

The psalmist sees his own salvation as the beginning of a new day in which the Lord will do great things.

Psalms 118:24

This is the day that the LORD has made: The Lord's victory has begun, but it will be completed on another day (Psalm 118:25).

Psalms 118:25–29

The psalmist ends with prayer and thanksgiving, anticipating an even greater revelation of God's victory and rescue.

Psalms 118:26

- The one who comes in the name of the Lord brings the Lord's complete victory (see Psalm 118:10–12).
- When Jesus triumphantly entered Jerusalem, the crowds shouted blessings. They used phrases from this verse (Matthew 21:9; Mark 11:9; Luke 19:38; John 12:13).

Jesus quoted this passage as he wept over Jerusalem (Matthew 23:39; Luke 13:35).

Psalms 119:1–4

Wise people are happy. They have integrity (see Psalm 84:11) and follow God's guidance. They obey God's teachings and seek them with complete devotion (see Psalm 27:7; 119:10, 45, 94, 155). They reject all evil forms. Compare Psalm 1:1–2.

Psalms 119:1–8

Aleph (א) is the first letter of the Hebrew alphabet. Psalm 119 is written as an acrostic poem. Each section has eight verses, and every verse in that section begins with the same Hebrew letter. The first section begins with Aleph.

God, the author of these instructions, commands that his followers live by them. The psalmist prays to be given the grace to live by that revelation.

Psalms 119:1–176

This psalm blends wisdom, lament, praise, thanksgiving, and confession. It often uses eight Hebrew words translated as:

- "Instructions"
- "law"
- "words"
- "commandments"
- "statutes"
- "judgments"
- "promises"
- "precepts"

These words encourage love for and obedience to God's instructions in the Scriptures (see 2 Timothy 3:14–17). A deep commitment to these instructions unifies the psalm.

Psalms 119:4

To keep God's commandments means to guard them by obeying them.

Psalms 119:9

- A young person often acts foolishly (Proverbs 22:15) and can easily make mistakes that ruin their life (Proverbs 7:6–23). However, youth is the best time to build self-discipline and seek wisdom (see Psalm 34:11; Proverbs 1:4).
- keep his way pure: This means avoiding corruption by evil and sin and developing the integrity described in Psalm 15.

Psalms 119:9–16

Beth (ב) is the second letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It makes the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist is determined to stay pure and encourages gaining wisdom through God's principles (Psalm 119:9) and instructions (119:10–16).

Psalms 119:10

The student asks God the teacher to discipline him so that he will not stray.

Psalms 119:14

God's wisdom is more valuable than any wealth people desire (Psalm 119:72, 127; Proverbs 3:14–15).

Psalms 119:15

The path of wisdom involves thinking deeply about God's teachings (see Psalm 119:1, 3). Wise people consider the meaning of God's word.

Psalms 119:17–18

The psalmist wants to live a life full of praise and obedience to please the Lord (Psalms 118:17; 119:25, 77, 116, 144, 175). Only the Lord can remove his enemies and help him understand the wonderful truths in God's teachings.

Psalms 119:17–24

Gimel (ג) is the third letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

Like a stranger in a hostile land, God's servant needs God's guidance.

Psalms 119:20–21

The arrogant are probably those who mock the psalmist (Psalm 119:22–23).

Psalms 119:23–24

Those who meditate on God's instructions receive wise advice from them.

Psalms 119:25–32

Daleth (ד) is the fourth letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The poet feels deep pain and sadness but asks the Lord to give him strength. He wants to follow the Lord. Suffering and death may result from the Lord's discipline (Psalms 118:17–18; 119:67, 71, 75), but his instruction renews the weary soul (see 119:12).

Psalms 119:29

- path of deceit: Self-deception comes from sinful human nature (Jeremiah 17:9). It leads to foolishness.
- Access to God's word is a privilege, not a right.

Psalms 119:33–40

He (ה) is the fifth letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

As a student, the poet asks his teacher, God, to renew life and to transform disgrace into righteousness.

Psalms 119:36

The love for money can lead to sin (compare Exodus 18:21; 1 Timothy 3:1–5; 6:10).

Psalms 119:41–43

The psalmist asks for protection from enemies who speak harshly (see Psalms 42:10; 44:16; 89:50–51; 102:8).

Psalms 119:41–48

Waw (ו) is the sixth letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist prays that God's word would continue to be the source of his love and salvation.

Psalms 119:44–46

The psalmist is determined to obey the Lord.

Psalms 119:47–48

The psalmist finds joy in God's word despite experiencing pain (Psalm 119:92, 143).

Psalms 119:49–56

Zayin (ז) is the seventh letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist asks God to remember his word as the psalmist also remembers God's word and his name. Remembrance expresses devotion.

Psalms 119:52

judgments of old: This refers to God's just rulings or decisions (his laws). These are found in the Torah, the books of Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy.

Psalms 119:57–64

Heth (ח) is the eighth letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist seeks God's favor and loving devotion. Although surrounded by evildoers, he remains a loyal servant of the Lord.

Psalms 119:61

Wicked people try to lead him into sin, but the psalmist remembers God's word and stays strong (see Psalm 119:16).

Psalms 119:64

God's goodness fills the earth. The entire creation shows evidence of his goodness (see Isaiah 6:3; 11:9).

Psalms 119:65–68

- Good judgment and knowledge come from wisdom (Psalm 111:10).
- The psalmist admits he used to wander like a lost sheep (Psalm 119:176).
- now I keep your word: See Psalm 119:25–29.
- You are good, and You do what is good: God's character is perfect (Psalm 97:2; James 1:17; 1 John 1:5).

Psalms 119:65–72

Teth (ט) is the ninth letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist admits his sin and gratefully accepts the Lord's discipline.

Psalms 119:73–76

As God's child, the psalmist asks for divine wisdom.

Psalms 119:73–80

Yodh (י) is the tenth letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

In this prayer for comfort and compassion, the psalmist commits himself to his Creator, who has afflicted him. He wants God to pay back his enemies for the wrongs they have done. He also prays to receive the gift of life. He not only prays for himself but also considers the whole community of the godly, asking that God's answers to prayer would encourage them.

Psalms 119:81–88

Kaph (כ) is the eleventh letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist feels exhausted from waiting for the Lord, but he still hopes for God's future rescue.

Psalms 119:85–88

God's word is trustworthy. This contrasts with the lies of the enemies who hunt the psalmist without reason (see Psalm 119:78).

Psalms 119:89–96

Lamedh (ל) is the twelfth letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The stability of God's wisdom gives understanding. God's word provides order and a framework for living, even when under pressure from adversaries.

Psalms 119:95

The wicked planned to kill the psalmist, but they faced destruction themselves (Psalm 1:6).

Psalms 119:96

I have seen a limit to all perfection: Humans cannot fully understand God's ways (see Ecclesiastes 3:11).

Psalms 119:97–102

make me wiser: God's word provides wisdom and perspective. God is the true source of wisdom.

Psalms 119:97–104

Mem (מ) is the thirteenth letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The instruction and wisdom of God through his word are far better than the best that human teachers can offer.

Psalms 119:103–104

- Wisdom is better than the finest food (Psalm 19:10; 81:16).
- The psalmist had already turned away from the false promises of foolishness (see Psalm 119:18, 78, 86, 163).

Psalms 119:105–106

The Lord's word is like a lamp. It offers perspective, hope, and guidance in darkness (Psalm 18:25–29; 119:130). This light also gives life (Proverbs 6:23).

Psalms 119:105–112

Nun (נ) is the fourteenth letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist's deep commitment to God's word comes from within (Psalm 119:112) and directs his actions.

Psalms 119:108–112

- freewill offerings of my mouth: This Hebrew expression is unique in the Old Testament (compare Psalm 50:23).
- The psalmist is vulnerable to his opponents because of his commitment to a wise life.

Psalms 119:113

The godly hate the wicked and their actions (Psalm 5:4–6; compare Ezekiel 33:11).

Psalms 119:113–120

Samekh (ס) is the fifteenth letter of the Hebrew alphabet and marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist declares his hatred of evil and his love for God and his ways.

Psalms 119:121–128

Ayin (ע) is the sixteenth letter of the Hebrew alphabet and marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The servant of the Lord struggles to endure the evil around him. He confidently asks the Lord to rescue him right away!

Psalms 119:125

Simply possessing God's law does not provide any benefits. The psalmist knows that only as the Lord gives discernment will he understand it.

Psalms 119:129–136

Pe (פ) is the seventeenth letter of the Hebrew alphabet and marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist prays earnestly for God to speak to him as he suffers from his adversities.

Psalms 119:137–144

Tsadhe (צ) is the eighteenth letter of the Hebrew alphabet and marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

God is righteous, and his word is right and just, especially in contrast to the deceptions of the wicked.

Psalms 119:139

The psalmist feels angry (compare Psalm 69:9) because he sees wicked people ignoring God's word.

Psalms 119:141

The psalmist feels very troubled by those who oppress him (see Psalm 119:143; compare Isaiah 53).

Psalms 119:145–148

I rise and anticipate translate the same Hebrew verb.

Psalms 119:145–152

Qoph (ק) is the nineteenth letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist prays to the Lord at night. Even when God seems distant, he is actually close.

Psalms 119:150–151

Coming to attack me (or draw near) is a Hebrew wordplay on You are near. The wicked stay far from God's instructions, but the psalmist stays close, so he does not need to fear.

Psalms 119:153–160

Resh (ר): This request for life appears throughout Psalm 119, but it is focused in this stanza.

Psalms 119:161–164

- my heart fears ... I rejoice: Fear, trembling, and joy show the psalmist's devotion to God.
- God's word is a treasure (great spoil).
- In the Old Testament, the number seven represents wholeness.

Psalms 119:161–168

Shin (ש) is the twenty-first letter of the alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

The psalmist looks beyond his adversaries to the peace of God. This perspective allows him to praise God throughout the day.

Psalms 119:169–176

Taw (ת) is the twenty-second letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It marks the beginning of the next section of this psalm.

God's servant asks the Lord for help one last time. He still feels like a lost sheep.

Psalms 119:176

God, the Great Shepherd, seeks out his lost sheep (Psalm 23:1; Luke 15:4–6).

Psalms 120:1–2

The psalmist is surrounded by liars, so he makes his lament to the Lord, the only one who can help him.

Psalms 120:1–7

This short, individual lament expresses the psalmist's trust that the Lord will deal with deceptive evildoers. It also laments living as a stranger among hateful liars. The psalmist's picture of his life in a foreign land might have been a reality as he set out for Jerusalem, or it might depict his feelings and concerns as he begins his pilgrimage. Overwhelmed with injustice, he trusts God and looks forward to arriving in the Lord's presence.

Psalms 120:1–134.3

These short and memorable songs were sung by pilgrims as they traveled to Jerusalem for the national festivals held three times each year (Deuteronomy 16:16). The title of these psalms includes a Hebrew word that can mean "steps" or "stairs." Some scholars understand it to mean "going up to Jerusalem." These psalms, often called the Songs of Ascents, lead the listener on a journey to Jerusalem to praise God for his goodness to Israel through history.

Psalms 120:3–4

- The psalmist speaks with the liars around him. He feels confident that the Lord will judge them.
- The Divine Warrior (see Psalms 7:12–13; 11:4–6) will attack the liars with sharp arrows and burning coals.

Psalms 120:5

Meshech was a Japhethite territory far to the north of Canaan. Kedar was an Ishmaelite territory in Arabia. Violent people lived in both places.

Meshech was known for its slave trade (Ezekiel 27:13; see also Exodus 21:16), and Kedar was known for its warriors (Isaiah 21:16–17). These places represented the rebellious and violent land where the psalmist suffered.

Psalms 120:5–7

The psalmist feels the pain of being alone, isolated, and in constant conflict.

Psalms 120:6–7

peace: See Psalms 37:11; 122:6–9; 125:5; 128:6.

Psalms 121:1

The mountains were known for idol worship (Deuteronomy 12:2), and Israel was drawn to the hilltop shrines (Hosea 4:13). This verse can be seen as a rhetorical question expecting a "no" answer: The gods of the hilltop shrines cannot save anyone.

Others understand the mountains to be a symbol of the Lord's strength (Psalm 95:4). In that case, the question would be taken literally (From where does my help come?), with the answer in the next verse.

Psalms 121:1–8

The leader of the group of pilgrims uses word pictures to assure the group of the Lord's presence during the journey.

Psalms 121:4

God watches over his own, even and especially when they face many troubles (Psalms 12:5, 7; 69:29; 91:14; 146:9).

Psalms 121:4–6

- The Maker of heaven and earth (Psalm 121:2) protects Israel.
- God stands with Israel, offering support and care to the faithful (see Psalm 16:7–8).
- Both the sun and the moon were worshiped as gods in the ancient Near East. But God limits their power. They are part of creation and also praise the Lord (Psalm 148:3).

Psalms 122:1

The central sanctuary was the house of the LORD. This phrase first referred to the tabernacle (Exodus 23:19; 34:26).

Psalms 122:1–9

Jerusalem is presented here as the city of God, the city of David, and the center of faith. A group of pilgrims joyfully arrives in the city (Psalm 122:1–2). The psalmist praises Jerusalem (Psalm 122:3–5) and prays for the city's peace (122:6–9).

Psalms 122:2

Several psalms celebrate or look forward to being inside the gates of the city (Psalms 9:14; 87:2; 100:4; 118:19).

Psalms 122:3

In the time of David and Solomon, people knew Jerusalem as a safe place (1 Kings 10:6–7).

Psalms 122:3–5

Jerusalem can represent God's heavenly dwelling place. David became the model for the rulers God chooses.

Psalms 122:4

- Each person in Israel belonged to a tribe, and all tribes belonged to the Lord.
- Giving thanks means presenting an offering acceptable to the Lord (Psalms 50:14, 23; 100:4; 118:19).
- as a testimony for Israel: See Exodus 23:17; Deuteronomy 16:16.

Psalms 122:5

the thrones of judgment stand: In the time of David and Solomon (1 Kings 3:28), Jerusalem was known for wisdom and justice. It will be like that again (Isaiah 9:7).

Psalms 122:6–9

Prayers for the peace of Jerusalem are motivated by love of family and God's sanctuary.

Psalms 123:1–4

This lament about the psalmist's humble position shows strong trust in the Lord (Psalm 123:1–2). The psalmist prays for God's favor on the community because evil surrounds them (Psalm 123:3–4). The poet looks beyond Jerusalem (Psalm 122) to God's throne in heaven.

Psalms 124:1–2

The negative rhetorical questions emphasize the positive idea that the Lord was indeed on their side.

Psalms 124:1–8

This thanksgiving song describes what might happen if the Lord were not present with his people.

Psalms 124:4–5

the raging waters: The enemies could have defeated the Israelites and destroyed them if the Lord had not supported his people (compare Psalm 69:15; Jeremiah 46:8).

Psalms 124:6–8

The enemies of God's people were like lions or bears that tear prey with their teeth (see Psalm 57:4; Proverbs 28:15). The Lord shut their mouths (Daniel 6:22).

Psalms 125:1–5

The psalmist expresses the community's trust in the Lord's protection (Psalm 125:1–2) and prays for peace (125:3–5).

Psalms 125:2

surrounds: God guards and protects like a wall of fire (Zechariah 2:5).

Psalms 125:3

The godly may be tempted to abandon God's ways because of pressure from others or from the surrounding culture.

Psalms 125:4–5

People who do not follow the "straight paths" are foolish (Proverbs 2:12–15). God gives his goodness to the godly (see Psalm 122:6–9).

Psalms 126:1–3

The Lord brought about Israel's restoration from exile, just as he had brought Israel out of Egypt (Psalm 114:1). The restoration transformed the weeping of the Lord's people into laughter and showed the Lord's character to the nations (Psalm 9:11; 64:9; Isaiah 12:4).

Psalms 126:1–6

This psalm celebrates Israel's return from exile (Psalm 126:1–3). The psalmist then prays that God will fully restore the people (Psalm 126:4–6).

Psalms 126:4–6

- The prophets had spoken of the restoration as a time when the wilderness would change into the garden of Eden (Isaiah 51:3; Ezekiel 47). However, the reality was far from paradise. Here, the restoration community prays for complete redemption (see Haggai 2:19).
- like streams in the Negev: Seasonal rains filled the dry riverbeds (wadis), making the land green again. The prayer seeks a similar change in Israel's fortunes, fulfilling the imagery of the "Second Exodus" in Isaiah (see "The Promise of a Second Exodus" Theme Note).
- carrying sheaves of grain: This harvest represents God's complete restoration.

Psalms 127:1–2

- Unless: These conditional statements emphasize that the Lord is the one who protects the city (compare Psalm 124:1–2).
- Human effort achieves nothing unless the Lord blesses it (see Psalm 44:3).
- you rise early and stay up late: This phrase describes people who work constantly and live with pressure and competition.
- Those whom God loves can rest and sleep in peace (Psalm 3:5; 4:8).

Psalms 127:1–5

Blessings and protection come from God. Without his presence, success is not possible (Psalm 127:1–2). This is especially true for children, who are gifts from God (Psalm 127:3–5).

Psalms 127:3–5

Children are one of God's blessings. In Hebrew, the word for children (banim) sounds like the word for builders (bonim; Psalm 127:1). This wordplay shows that having children helps build a family.

Psalms 127:4–5

Like arrows: The image compares children to arrows in a warrior's hand. Children strengthen and support the family and help defend its honor when others accuse or oppose them (compare Psalms 120:4; 7:12–13).

Psalms 128:1–2

eating the fruit of your labor: This means gaining benefit from whatever work one does.

Psalms 128:1–6

The godly, who fear the Lord, will know true happiness (Psalm 128:1–2). The Lord is with them (see Psalm 127:1–2), strengthens their family life (128:3–4), and blesses them for generations (128:5–6).

Psalms 128:3

Children are like strong young olive trees because they are full of potential. Olive oil symbolizes God's blessing (Psalm 104:15; Numbers 18:12; Jeremiah 31:12; Haggai 2:19).

Psalms 128:4–6

- God will continually bless those who fear him (Psalm 133:3) from his dwelling in Zion (20:2; 50:2; 110:2), no matter where they live.
- children's children: God's blessings continue through generations for those who are faithful (Psalms 79:12–13; 89:1; 100:4–5; 103:17–19).

Psalms 129:1–2

Israel's earliest years as a nation took place while the people were living in Egypt.

Psalms 129:1–8

The psalmist briefly reviews Israel's history of trouble (Psalm 129:1–2) and redemption (129:3–4). He ends with curses against the enemies and blessings on the godly (Psalm 129:5–6).

Psalms 129:3–4

The LORD is righteous: He rescued Israel from Egypt, from many enemy attacks, and from the Babylonian exile.

Psalms 129:6–8

Grass on a rooftop had shallow roots and would scorch easily. A crop was ignored by the harvester when the yield was low. The enemies who had sown hurt among God's people would gain little.

Psalms 130:1–3

A cry from the depths comes from a place of deep distress (compare Psalm 69:2, 14; Isaiah 51:10; Ezekiel 27:34). Feeling weak, the psalmist prays for God's favor.

Psalms 130:1–8

Beginning with himself as a representative of the community, the psalmist cries for God's mercy (Psalm 130:1–3) out of deep distress. He places his hope in the Lord (Psalm 130:4–6), trusting that the Lord will rescue in his own time and way. With this confidence, the psalmist invites Israel to wait for the Lord (Psalm 130:7–8).

Psalms 130:3

The psalmist knows that his sins make him guilty and deserving of God's judgment.

Psalms 130:4–6

The good news comes in God's readiness to forgive sinners. His grace encourages people to fear him and hope in him.

Psalms 130:5

God's word gives hope (Psalms 119:42–43, 49; 147:11).

Psalms 130:7–8

Israel is encouraged to hope in the Lord (Psalms 9:18; 27:14; 131:3) because the Lord pays the high price for redemption and removes the sin that separates humans from him (see also Psalm 111:9; Exodus 6:6–8; 2 Samuel 7:23–24; Isaiah 43:1–4; Titus 2:14; Hebrews 9:12; 1 Peter 1:18).

Psalms 131:1

- The heart represents the entire person (see Psalm 27:8).
- God hates arrogance, which is a foolish way of life (Proverbs 6:16–19).
- The psalmist does not trouble himself with matters that properly belong to the Lord.

Psalms 131:1–3

Out of his contentment in the Lord, the psalmist invites Israel to seek their rest in God (Psalm 131:3).

Psalms 131:2

- The psalmist has calmed and quieted himself. He has given up his ambitions and pride (Galatians 2:20).
- like a weaned child: The psalmist compares himself to a contented child who rests quietly with its mother.

Psalms 132:1–18

This psalm celebrates the Lord's faithfulness to David. When David wanted to bring the ark to Jerusalem (Psalm 132:1–5), the Lord agreed and made Jerusalem his earthly home (132:6–10). God's choice of Jerusalem also shows his choice:

- of David's family line (Psalm 132:11–13),
- of Zion (Psalm 132:14–17), and
- of the priesthood (Psalm 132:9, 16).

Psalms 132:6

- Ephrathah is another name for Bethlehem (Genesis 35:19; 48:7).
- Jaar is the singular form of the plural Jearim. The ark was at Kiriath-jearim for 20 years in Samuel's time (1 Samuel 7:1–2).

Psalms 132:6–10

These verses recall David moving the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6:1–15) and the Lord's promise to David (2 Samuel 7:4–16).

Psalms 132:8–10

These verses are a quotation from Solomon's prayer at the dedication of the temple (2 Chronicles 6:41–42).

Psalms 132:9

The priests were to show righteousness by the way they live (Psalm 132:16; Malachi 2:6).

Psalms 132:11–12

The LORD swore an oath to David (2 Samuel 7:4–16): God's promise is unconditional, but the covenant depends on conditions (If ... then). Those who break God's covenant should expect God's judgment as discipline (see Psalm 89:30–37).

Psalms 132:13–17

The psalmist remembers how God chose Jerusalem and appointed the priests.

Psalms 132:17

anointed one: God chose and established this ruler (see Psalms 1–8) to always provide light for the Lord's people. This light would shine continuously (see 1 Kings 11:36; 2 Kings 8:19; compare John 8:12; Revelation 21:23–24).

Psalms 132:18

The enemies will feel shame, while the king will be honored (Psalm 132:9, 16).

Psalms 133:1

Brothers are connected by family, by work, or by loyalty. In this psalm, brothers means all members of the community, including men and women, who live in unity.

Psalms 133:1–2

The psalmist speaks about the joy of relationships dedicated to God.

Psalms 133:1–3

In this wisdom psalm (see Psalm 1), peaceful and harmonious relationships show that God is present.

Psalms 133:2

- The fine oil was used to appoint and set apart Aaron for his role as priest (see Exodus 29:7).
- head ... beard ... collar of his robes: The oil set Aaron apart completely for God's service.

Psalms 133:3

- The dew represents the richness of God's blessings (his goodness and care). In Jerusalem, this moisture comes from winds off the Mediterranean Sea. Mount Hermon, which has snow on its peak, is known for its abundant moisture.
- A blessing is God's life-giving power. It shows his provision (care for needs) and protection (Psalm 5:12; 41:2). It also comes from his presence (21:6; 67:1). In the end, all nations will receive God's blessing (Psalms 67; 72:17). Zion is the central place of God's blessing (Psalms 134:3; 147:13).
- God gives everlasting life to people.

Psalms 134:1–2

Those who serve by night were the priests and Levites (see also Psalm 135:2).

Psalms 134:1–3

In the last of the pilgrims' songs (Psalms 120–134), the travelers ask the temple workers to praise the Lord. In return, they will receive a long-awaited blessing.

Psalms 135:1–21

God is the Creator and the Lord of history, the "Maker of heaven and earth" (Psalm 134:3). He deserves praise because, unlike idols, he saves his people.

Psalms 135:4

The names Jacob and Israel represent all twelve tribes. The Lord loves his chosen people. They are his treasure among all the world's kingdoms (Exodus 19:5–6).

Psalms 135:5

The Lord is greater than any real or imagined supernatural being (see Psalms 95:3–5; 115:4–8).

Psalms 135:6

- God has complete authority and power over the whole created order. God does whatever pleases him.
- The phrase in the heavens and on the earth refers to all of creation.

Psalms 135:7

The psalmist tells of God's complete power and authority over the weather (Psalms 29; 77:17–18; 78:26; 104:4; 147:8–9; 148:5–6).

Psalms 135:8–11

- In the tenth and final plague against Egypt, God destroyed the firstborn of each family.
- The signs and wonders refer to the ten plagues (see Exodus 7–11; Deuteronomy 4:34; Nehemiah 9:10).

Psalms 135:8–12

The Lord had complete authority and power over the exodus and the conquest of the promised land.

Psalms 135:13–18

God's name and character are very different from idols.

Psalms 135:15–18

Idols lead people to think wrongly because they are only things humans make. They cannot speak, see, hear, or breathe (Isaiah 41:22–24; 44:9, 18; Romans 1:21–23).

Psalms 135:15–20

This entire section is repeated in Psalm 115:4–11.

Psalms 135:19–21

The groups mentioned here formed the covenant community (see Psalm 115:9–11).

Psalms 136:1–3

The psalmist calls the community to praise the Lord, who is good and full of love. He is the true Lord over all people. Verse 1 echoes the poetic line in 2 Chronicles 5:13.

Psalms 136:1–26

This is the last of the Great Hallel psalms (Psalms 120–136). It uniquely repeats the phrase His loving devotion endures forever in every verse.

The hymn begins and ends with a call to praise (Psalm 136:1–3, 26). It declares the Lord as the Creator of everything and the Redeemer of Israel, both in ancient times (Psalm 136:10–22) and in the recent past (136:23–24).

Psalms 136:10–22

The psalmist tells the early history of Israel's redemption.

Psalms 136:23–24

The psalmist tells the recent story of Israel's redemption, but does not specify the details.

Psalms 136:25

The Lord provides for all of his creatures.

Psalms 136:26

The phrase God of heaven is a name for the Lord used during and after the exile (when many Israelites were taken from their land). It appears in:

- Ezra (Ezra 1:2; 5:11, 12; 6:9, 10; 7:12),
- Nehemiah (Nehemiah 1:5; 2:4, 20), and
- Daniel (Daniel 2:18, 19, 37, 44).

Psalms 137:1–9

In response to the pain of exile (Psalm 137:1–4), the psalmist decides to remember Jerusalem, even though the memories cause him pain (137:4–6). He also speaks a strong prayer asking God to bring justice on his enemies (Psalm 137:7–9).

Psalms 137:2–4

Because the music of Jerusalem was connected to the joy of life in the promised land, the exile took away any reason to sing joyful songs. The Babylonians asked the Judeans to sing and dance for them, but the people were so full of grief that they could not do it.

The songs about the Lord celebrate his power and goodness, but his people were now filled with doubt and questions. They hung their harps in the trees, which may show that their joy had come to an end under God's judgment (Deuteronomy 21:23).

Psalms 137:5–6

The psalmist pledges his loyalty to Jerusalem, the city at the center of God's reign and the location of fellowship with him.

Psalms 137:7–9

- The poet saw how the Edomites betrayed the people of Judah, so he calls on God to judge Edom. The long conflict between Edom and Judah reached its worst point near the end of Judah's history. At that time, the Edomites handed the Judeans over to the Babylonians (Obadiah 1:10–11) and celebrated Jerusalem's fall.
- This prayer asking God to bring justice uses strong language and can be shocking.

Psalms 138:1–3

The Lord receives praise before the gods of the nations.

Psalms 138:1–8

In this wisdom psalm, the Lord is presented as the God of gods. He rescued his people and has a perfect plan

for them as individuals. The nations will join Israel in glorifying God.

Psalms 138:1–145.21

In this final group of psalms of David, psalms of praise and wisdom (Psalms 138–139, 145) form a frame around five psalms of lament (Psalms 140–144).

Psalms 138:4–5

As the Lord's glory fills the earth, people must willingly submit to him. Every king (compare Psalm 2) will join in praise when they learn the Lord's ways of truth and love.

Psalms 138:6

God is holy and great, far beyond human understanding (see Psalms 99:2; 113:4; Isaiah 6:1; 57:15).

Psalms 138:6–8

The exalted God cares for the humble (Psalm 138:6), especially his servant, the psalmist (138:7–8).

Psalms 138:8

The psalmist trusts in the Lord's perfect plans and prays for God's continued involvement. The psalmist sees himself as part of God's plans (see Psalms 9:10; 139:14).

Psalms 139:1–6

The Lord knows the psalmist well. God has examined him closely, in a thorough examination that can be painful at times (Job 7:17–19).

Psalms 139:1–24

In this wisdom psalm, the psalmist opens every part of his life to God. He invites God to examine his thoughts, actions, and words. Even though life is difficult, he wants to grow in wisdom so that he does not share in the judgment of the wicked (Psalm 141:5; 142:3; 143:8, 10; 144:3–4).

The psalmist also knows that he cannot escape from the Lord. His stress fades as he remembers that God has cared for him with love, even before he was born (Psalm 139:13–18). He ends by asking God to keep examining him and to guide him on the path of wisdom (Psalm 139:23–24).

Psalms 139:2

The phrase when I sit and when I rise refers to everyday activities (compare Deuteronomy 6:6–9).

Psalms 139:3–6

The Lord's all-knowing and all-powerful nature provides comfort to the godly, but it troubles the wicked (Psalm 2:3).

Psalms 139:6

The Lord's wonderful understanding lies beyond the psalmist's ability to comprehend (see Judges 13:18).

Psalms 139:7–12

The psalmist shows wonder at God being everywhere at all times.

Psalms 139:8

if I make my bed in Sheol: God has complete access to all he has created, even the most hidden or hard-to-reach places.

Psalms 139:9

- rise on the wings of the dawn: This poetic expression describes traveling eastward, as far as the sunrise, if that were possible.
- the farthest sea: This expression takes the traveler in the opposite direction, far to the west.

Psalms 139:13

- my inmost being: The delicate inner parts of the body include a person's very being.
- Even when hidden in his mother's womb, the psalmist was guided by the Lord.

Psalms 139:17

How precious to me are Your thoughts: God's careful examination shows his loving care. Life with the Lord brings blessings that are beyond words.

Psalms 139:19–24

The psalmist's sense of awe leads him to consider the wicked and to reflect on himself. The Lord, as the examiner of all people, judges the wicked for their destructive acts and speech. So, the psalmist prays that he will not be among them.

Psalms 139:21

Do I note hate those who hate You: Rejecting evil shows wisdom (see Psalms 1:1; 5:4–6).

Psalms 139:23–24

As the psalmist prays about the wicked, he also reflects on himself. He does not assume that he is

righteous. This prayer has been spoken again and again by God's people over many generations.

Psalms 139:24

The path of wisdom leads to eternal life (see Psalm 1:6; Proverbs 4:18; 6:23).

Psalms 140:1–3

The psalmist prays for the Lord to rescue him from wicked people.

Psalms 140:1–13

In this personal lament, the psalmist describes God's enemies and their evil plans. He prays for the Lord's protection and rescue, trusting in God's strength and justice. He predicts that fire will judge the evil (Psalm 140:9–11) and that he will be proven right and live in the Lord's presence (140:13).

Psalms 140:3

snakes ... vipers: These creatures portray the wicked as very corrupt people (see Proverbs 23:32; Isaiah 14:29; Romans 3:13).

Psalms 140:4–5

The psalmist prays for God's protection (see Psalm 121), asking the Lord to keep him safe from the wicked's many plans.

Psalms 140:7

O GOD the Lord: This title comes from combining the name Yahweh with the title Adonai (which means Master). See also Psalms 68:20; 69:6; 71:16; 73:28; 109:21; 141:8.

Psalms 140:9–11

The psalmist prays for God's judgment on the wicked.

Psalms 140:10

The psalmist asks for burning coals to fall on his enemies and for them to be thrown into the miry pits, so that they cannot attack again. This language hints at the New Testament teachings on hell (see Matthew 5:22, 29–30; 10:28; 18:9; Mark 9:43–47; Luke 12:5; James 3:6; 2 Peter 2:4).

Psalms 141:1–2

- The psalmist urgently prays for rescue. He does not have incense or an evening offering (Exodus 29:38–39), but his prayers and devotion represent those elements (see Isaiah 1:13; Revelation 5:8).
- uplifted hands: This is a posture of prayer (Psalms 28:2; 88:9; 143:6; Exodus 9:29; 1 Timothy 2:8).

Psalms 141:1–10

The psalmist prays for rescue and for wisdom. He also looks ahead to the end of evil. The idea that people receive what they deserve (Psalm 141:10) holds the psalm together.

Psalms 141:3–5

- Wisdom sometimes requires protection from oneself. People might say or think things that lead to a harmful path (Proverbs 13:3; 21:23).
- Wisdom accepts correction from godly people (see Proverbs 3:11; 9:8; 15:31; 19:25).

Psalms 142:1–3

Although overwhelmed by his persecutors (Psalm 142:6), the psalmist seeks wisdom from the Lord.

Psalms 142:1–7

when he was in the cave: Compare Psalm 57:1.

Psalms 142:7

He feels trapped and stressed, similar to being in prison (see Psalm 107:10).

Psalms 142:3–4

The psalmist feels deep despair (see Psalm 77:3), and the Lord helps him in his distress. The psalmist trusts in the Lord's wisdom (see Psalm 139) but mourns being trapped by evil people (5:9–10; 140:5; 141:9; 142:3).

Psalms 142:5

Even when alone, the psalmist trusts the Lord, who is his life (see Psalms 9:9; 16:5; 27:13).

Psalms 142:6–7

Though overwhelmed by loneliness and trouble, the psalmist focuses on the Lord's goodness and protection. He knows that the Lord alone is his Redeemer, so he offers his praise.

Psalms 142

The psalmist faces severe persecution, so he cries to the Lord, and the Lord will rescue him.

Psalms 143:1–2

The psalmist prays for God's love and mercy.

Psalms 143:1–12

In this lament, the psalmist feels overwhelmed by constant trouble from his enemies, so he turns to the Lord's love, righteousness, and faithfulness. He remembers what God has done in the past and longs for God to renew his love. He opens himself to God's wisdom because he knows that God's instruction leads to life.

Psalms 143:2

Everyone has sinned and is guilty before God (Romans 3:20–24).

Psalms 143:3–4

My spirit grows faint within me: The psalmist admits his desperation as his life seems to slip away under cruel and powerful enemies.

Psalms 143:5–6

Remembering God's acts from the past reassures the psalmist of God's faithfulness (Psalms 42:4; 63:6; 77:3, 6; 119:55).

Psalms 143:6

The psalmist's thirst is a deep longing for God's redemption (see Psalm 42:1–2).

Psalms 143:7

The psalmist experiences depression. He describes himself as close to death from sorrow (Psalms 31:10; 119:87). He feels worn out (Psalms 39:10; 71:9; 119:81). He is weak from longing (Psalm 84:2). He feels overwhelmed by the burdens of life (Psalm 90:7, 9).

Psalms 143:7–10

The psalmist asks the Lord to renew his love.

Psalms 143:8–10

- The psalmist prays for wisdom (see Psalms 5:8; 25:4–6; 138; 143:10).
- Your good Spirit: The Spirit brings God's goodness (see Psalm 23:6).

Psalms 143:11

revive: Here, it means to bring someone out of despair and restore them to life (Psalms 80:19; 85:6; 138:7).

Psalms 143:12

The psalm ends with a prayer for God to show that the psalmist is in the right and to restore his life.

Psalms 144:1–2

my Rock … my steadfast love … my deliverer … my shield: The psalmist's descriptive names for the Lord reveal his deep love for him.

Psalms 144:1–15

This lament begins with an exclamation of love for the Lord. The community then reflects on the temporary nature of life (Psalm 144:3–4). The psalmist asks for God's help and anticipates victory (Psalm 144:5–11).

A new song (Psalm 144:9–10) and a prayer for rescue (144:11) introduce the theme of the Lord's blessings through his care and protection (Psalm 144:12–15).

Psalms 144:3–4

what is man: The same question in Psalm 8:4–6 leads to the answer that humans are only mortal (they do not live forever), yet God gives them honor and responsibility to rule.

The psalmist focuses on how brief and fragile human life is. He describes it as temporary and passing quickly (see Psalms 90:3, 7–10; 102:11; 109:23; 146:4).

Psalms 144:5–8

The psalmist asks God to act against his enemies (compare Psalm 18:7–19).

Psalms 144:12

The psalmist compares sons and daughters to plants and pillars, which are images of strength and beauty.

Psalms 144:12–15

This prayer for the Lord's blessing brings the laments of Psalms 140–144 to a close. It describes God's provision (care for needs) and protection (keeping people safe; see Psalm 127), not only for the psalmist but also for his children and for all who follow God.

Psalms 144:13–14

no going into captivity, and no cry of lament: These images show peace and safety.

Psalms 145:1–3

The psalmist praises God, the Great King who reigns over all other rulers (see Psalm 47:2).

Psalms 145:1–21

This psalm of praise is the last in this collection of the psalms of David (Psalms 138–145). Praise continues in the last five psalms (Psalms 146–150).

This psalm celebrates the Lord as the King of all (Psalm 145:1–3, 10–13). God's actions show his royal qualities (Psalm 145:4–7). He cares for all creatures (Psalm 145:14–17) and for those who fear him (145:18–20).

Psalms 145:4–7

This litany (a repeated form of praise, often with the same line said again and again) celebrates God's character and his mighty deeds. Each generation will continue to tell others about God's power (Psalm 22:30).

Psalms 145:8–9

God consistently demonstrates his character toward all his creation (see Psalm 136:25).

Psalms 145:10–13

These verses form a description of the Lord's kingdom.

Psalms 145:14–20

The Lord cares for his creatures.

Psalms 145:20

The Lord cares for those who love him and fear him. God-fearers love the Lord and find refuge in him (Psalm 5:11). They seek him as their only true Savior (Psalms 40:16; 70:4). They will experience a good future (Psalm 69:36) and enjoy the peace that God gives (119:165).

Psalms 146:1

This verse is similar to Psalm 103:1, 2, 22; 104:1, 35.

Psalms 146:1–10

The call to praise (Psalm 146:1–2) leads to a warning against foolishness and false confidence (146:3–4). The psalm ends with a blessing for everyone who places their hope in the Lord (Psalm 146:5–7).

Psalms 146:1–150.6

The Psalter ends with five hallelujah psalms, so named because each begins and ends with Praise the LORD! (Hebrew haleluyah).

Psalms 146:8–9

Repeating the Lord's name (shown as LORD in the Berean Standard Bible) four times emphasizes that he alone heals, lifts burdens, loves, and protects.

Psalms 147:1

This verse is a call to worship.

Psalms 147:1–20

The psalmist calls for the Lord to be praised for restoring and blessing Zion, caring for the poor, displaying his power over nature, and revealing himself to his people.

Psalms 147:2–6

The psalmist remembers how the Lord restored Jerusalem and brought back his people who had suffered in exile.

Psalms 147:4–5

- The Lord created the heavens.
- He determines the number of the stars: God's people can feel secure knowing the Lord cares for every detail of his creation. He knows all that belongs to him.

Psalms 147:6

God delivers justice to both the poor and the wicked (Psalms 55:22; 140:12; 145:14; 146:7).

Psalms 147:7–11

Human achievements do not impress God, who commands nature. Instead, he finds joy in those who fear him.

Psalms 147:8

God has complete authority and power over the weather (Psalms 77:17–18; 78:26; 104:4; 148:5–6).

Psalms 147:10–11

the legs of a man: Any physical or mental strength comes from the Lord, like the strength of a horse. These gifts are reasons to praise the Lord, not to boast (Jeremiah 9:23–24).

Psalms 147:13

- the bars of your gates: These represent protection from enemies.
- God blesses his people by giving them safety, prosperity, peace, and the things they need (see Psalm 133:3).

Psalms 147:15–18

Simply by speaking his command, the Lord can change the season from harsh winter to refreshing spring (see Psalms 147:8; 148:5–6).

Psalms 147:19–20

word … statutes … judgments: The Lord gave powerful words to Israel so that they might obey him (Psalm 105:45).

Psalms 148:1

When Jesus entered Jerusalem, the crowds welcomed him like a king and shouted blessings, including a phrase from this verse (Matthew 21:9; Mark 11:10; Luke 19:38).

Psalms 148:1–14

This psalm calls for the whole created order to praise the Lord because he has honored his faithful people.

Psalms 148:6

The created order is stable because of the Lord's word (see Psalm 33:9).

Psalms 148:8

In the ancient Near East, people believed that different gods controlled different parts of nature. But the Lord rules over all of nature. Every part of creation serves him and brings him praise by obeying him (Psalms 77:17–18; 104:4; 135:7; 147:8, 15–18; Numbers 11:31).

Psalms 148:11–12

The psalmist calls all humans to offer praise to God, regardless of status, age, or gender.

Psalms 148:13–14

- Praise of the Lord by all people is right because he is glorious and has blessed his people (see Psalm 147:13; Isaiah 46:13; Ephesians 3:10).
- His saint are God's trusting and devoted servants (Psalm 86:2).

Psalms 149:1–9

This psalm of praise celebrates the Lord's victory. God is the Maker of Israel (Psalm 149:1–2) and the victorious King who shares his glory with his faithful followers (149:3–9).

Psalms 149:4

God's people, whom the world ignores and looks down on, will be shown to be right (Matthew 19:30). The humble will overcome those who oppress and persecute them (see Isaiah 61:3).

Psalms 149:6–9

vengeance: The Lord is the one who brings justice against wrongdoing (see Psalms 2:3; 94:1; 102:20; 142:7; 146:7).

Psalms 150:1

The phrase mighty heavens refers to Genesis 1 and God's amazing work in filling the emptiness.

Psalms 150:1–6

Everything that breathes is commanded to praise the Lord as he deserves. The whole Psalter describes the greatness of the Lord, so this psalm is a fitting conclusion.

Psalms 150:3–5

- The psalmist calls all people to praise God with instruments and dancing.
- flutes: These are wind instruments (instruments you blow into to make sound). The Bible does not mention them as part of formal temple worship. This suggests they were used more in everyday life or celebrations, rather than in official worship at the temple.
- clashing cymbals: Temple musicians clapped two bronze bowls together to make a loud sound as part of the music.

Psalms 150:6

praise the LORD!: This refrain is a fitting conclusion to the entire book of Psalms.